

Govt issues SOP to protect trees, boost green cover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Determined to protect the environment, the Delhi Government has notified a comprehensive Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) to address offences related to trees. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta described the initiative as a historic decision aimed at safeguarding Delhi's green cover and ensuring strict enforcement of tree protection laws.

Sharing details, CM said on Monday that the SOP has been notified by the Department of Forests and Wildlife under Section 33 of the Delhi Preservation of Trees Act, 1994. It establishes a robust, transparent, and time-bound mechanism for the prevention, detection, and prosecution of illegal

felling, damage, and unauthorised activities involving trees. She added that the implementation of this SOP will ensure effective and accountable action in every case of violation.

The Chief Minister informed that a strong rapid response system has been developed under the SOP, enabling citizens to register complaints through a toll-free helpline, an online portal, and offline modes. All complaints will be transmitted in real time to the concerned field officers to ensure prompt action.

Quick Response Teams constituted at headquarters and division levels will reach the site within a stipulated time to prevent further damage and will collect evidence scientifically through geo-tagged photographs and



videos. Rekha Gupta stated that enforcement at the field level has been further strengthened under the SOP. Officials of the Forest Department, including Beat Officers and Tree Officers, have been empowered to issue prohibitory orders to prevent violations, seize equipment used in offences, and coordinate with law enforcement agencies, enabling swift and effective action in cases related to tree protection.

The Chief Minister said that to ensure round-the-clock monitoring, a Forest Control Room at the headquarters level and Division Control Rooms at the divisional level have been established, which will function 24x7. These control rooms are equipped with the necessary infrastructure to facilitate continuous

monitoring of complaints and ensure coordinated action with various emergency services.

Rekha Gupta stated that the Government has reactivated the Green Helpline number 1800118600. In addition, the Green Helpline portal (<https://ghl.eforest.delhi.gov.in>) is fully operational. These will be widely publicised to encourage greater citizen participation. The portal provides an accessible platform for lodging complaints and tracking their progress.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision on environmental protection, the Chief Minister said that his approach of 'development in harmony with nature' serves as a guiding inspiration for the nation.

She noted that, inspired by

the efforts of the Central Government towards achieving the goals of a Green India and sustainable development, the Delhi Government is also taking concrete steps. This SOP is a significant initiative in that direction, aimed at ensuring a clean, green, and safe environment for future generations.

The Chief Minister reiterated that the Delhi Government is fully committed to protecting the capital's green assets and will ensure strict, transparent, and time-bound action against violators of tree protection laws.

She also appealed to citizens to actively participate in environmental conservation and promptly report any violations to the concerned authorities so that timely and effective action can be taken.

Delhi plans 108 new PG medical seats to boost healthcare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has proposed 108 new postgraduate, DNB, and fellowship seats across 10 Government medical and teaching institutions to strengthen medical education and improve healthcare services in the Capital.

The proposal includes 67 seats for MD and MS programmes, 36 seats for Diplomate of National Board (DNB) courses, and five fellowship positions. Officials said the move aims to expand advanced medical training and create a larger pool of



specialised doctors. Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the expansion is an important step for the city's healthcare system.

"The increase in PG, DNB, and Fellowship seats will help train highly skilled

doctors. This will improve patient care and overall health outcomes in Delhi," he said.

The additional seats will be distributed across major government hospitals and medical colleges. Maulana

Azad Medical College has been allocated the highest number, with 35 MD and MS seats. Dr Baba Saheb Ambedkar Medical College will receive 24 MD and MS seats.

Indira Gandhi Medical College has been allotted 18 DNB seats, while Deep Chand Bandhu Hospital will get eight DNB seats. Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital has been assigned two DNB seats along with three fellowship positions.

The University College of Medical Sciences, in association with Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital, has been allocated four MD and MS seats. Guru Gobind Singh Government

Hospital and Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital will receive two DNB seats each. Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital has been allotted four DNB seats.

The Delhi State Cancer Institute has been given four MD and MS seats along with two fellowship positions, reflecting a focus on specialised cancer care training. Officials said the proposal is designed to create balanced growth across different streams of medical education.

It also aims to address the rising demand for trained specialists in public healthcare institutions.

Assembly seeks report on vehicular pollution action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Legislative Assembly has stepped up pressure on authorities to act on vehicular air pollution, directing departments to submit a detailed Action Taken Report by January 31, 2027, based on findings of a key audit.

The Assembly Secretariat has forwarded the Third Report of the Public Accounts Committee, which is based on the Comptroller and Auditor General's performance audit on the prevention and mitigation of vehicular air pollution in Delhi. The report covers the period ending March 31, 2021, and highlights several gaps in policy execution and enforcement.

The Secretariat has formally written to the Transport Minister and the Secretary-cum-Commissioner of the Transport Department, seeking a comprehensive and time-bound response. The report must clearly outline the status of implementation of recommendations as of December 31, 2026.

Delhi Assembly Speaker



Vijender Gupta said the issue requires urgent and coordinated action.

He stressed that audit findings must lead to real improvements on the ground and not remain confined to documents.

The report identifies serious shortcomings in the city's efforts to control vehicular pollution. It points to weaknesses in regulatory systems, gaps in enforcement and poor coordination among agencies. These issues continue to affect Delhi's air quality management.

Gupta said the response to pollution cannot rely on small, gradual measures. He noted that the audit highlights structural problems in planning and monitoring.

These include insufficient air quality monitoring sta-

tions, incomplete tracking of pollutants and a lack of reliable emission data. Such gaps make it difficult to design effective policies.

The Speaker also flagged concerns about public transport. He said the system faces long-standing challenges such as a shortage of buses, limited route coverage and poor last-mile connectivity.

Delays in route planning and the introduction of alternative transport systems have reduced accessibility and reliability.

These limitations, he said, have led to increased dependence on private vehicles, adding pressure on roads and worsening air pollution. On enforcement, Gupta pointed out that implementation of emission norms remains inconsistent.

Two brothers held over killing of UP journalist

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two brothers carrying a total reward of ₹50,000 on information leading to their arrest have been held from northwest Delhi in connection with the killing of a property dealer-cum-journalist in Uttar Pradesh's Hathras, an official said on Monday.

Accused Kamal Sharma (38) and Gaurav Sharma (36) were apprehended from a spot near the Prembari drain in the Wazirpur Industrial Area following a tip-off about armed suspects moving in the locality.



Police said the duo were wanted in connection with the killing of Ved Prakash Sharma alias Sonu, a 35-year-old property dealer who was also associated with a local news platform in Hathras.

"He had gone missing on April 6, and his body was found the next day from a drain near the Sadabad-Jalesar road," a police officer said.

Two more held in Noida violence case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

Gautam Buddh Nagar Police has arrested two more men in connection with the recent violence during workers' protests in Noida, with investigators pointing to a coordinated effort involving organised groups and social media mobilisation.

The accused, identified as Himanshu Thakur and Satyam Verma, were taken into custody on Sunday. Police said both were linked to a workers' group called *Bigul Mazdoor Dasta* and played an active role in inciting unrest during demonstrations held under the Phase-2 police station area.

Officials said the arrests are part of an ongoing crackdown on those allegedly involved in orchestrating violence during the protests on April 13, when workers had gathered to demand a wage hike.

According to the police, the protests turned violent after misleading content



was circulated on social media platforms. Authorities believe these posts were aimed at provoking demonstrators and disturbing public order. The situation quickly escalated, leading to incidents of stone-pelting, arson, and vandalism. Several vehicles, private establishments, and public property were damaged during the unrest.

Investigators said Himanshu Thakur was present in Noida on the day of the violence and was in regular contact with Aditya Anand, who has been identified as the alleged mastermind of the incident. Anand was arrested earlier on April

18 in Tiruchirapalli, Tamil Nadu, by a joint team of Noida Police and the Uttar Pradesh Special Task Force.

Police said Thakur, who currently resides in north Delhi, maintained communication with Anand before and during the protests. This link is being examined as part of efforts to establish the chain of events that led to the violence.

Satyam Verma is also accused of mobilising protesters and encouraging aggressive actions during the sit-in demonstrations. Both men are believed to have played key roles in coordinating activities on the ground.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, IMRAN Khan S/o Ekramul Haque R/o Flat No-123, 1st Floor, The Marlin, Plot No-13/HG-1, Sec-13, Vasundhara, U.P. have changed my fathers name Late Ekramul Haque To Ekramul Haque for all future purposes.

PD(916)C I, Neetu W/o Harnesh Verma, R/o C-1502, Amrapali Zodiac, Plot No. GH-03, Sector-120, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201301, have changed my name from Neetu to Neetu Verma for all future purposes.

PD(917)C I, Neni Devi, Mother of No.15730344M Hav Mahendra Giri, R/o- Vill/PO-Kasti, Teh- Baori, Dist-Jodhpur, Rajasthan- 342037, have changed my name from Neni Devi to Naini, vide affidavit dated 20/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(918)C I, Kamal, Mother of No.16035045F Rfm Patil Ruturaj Raghunath, R/o- A/P-Bhairapur, PO- Mattiwaade, Teh & Sub Dist- Hukkeri, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591225, have changed my name from Kamal to Kamal Raghunath Patil, vide affidavit dated 20/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(919)C I, Parash Kanwar W/o- Chhel Singh, R/o- Vill- Shri Sela, Dist- Pali, Rajasthan, have changed my name from Parash Kanwar to Paras Kanwar, vide affidavit dated 20/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Pusha Devi, Mother of No.10137122N Rfm Vikas, R/o- Vill & PO- Soldha, Distt- Jhajjar, Teh- Bahadurgarh, Haryana, have changed my name from Pusha Devi to Pushpa, vide affidavit dated 20/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(921)C I, Omwati, Mother of No.17018274M Nk Manish Kumar, R/o- Vill- Malra Sarai, PO- Lawan, Dist- Mahender Garh, Teh- Mahendergarh, Haryana- 123029, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 14/07/1970 whereas my correct DOB is 01/01/1965 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(922)C I, Sunil Kumar S/o Shri Satish Sah R/o I - Block, I - 1902 Jahangirpuri Delhi - 110033, have changed my name to Sunil Sah (both are the same person).

PD(923)C I, Mrs. Neeta Sharma W/o Shri Narendra Sharma has to inform that I have misplaced the Original Allotment Letter and Share Certificate of Flat No.B-27, Moonlight Apartments, Plot No.70, I.P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi- 110092 and the same are not traceable by my best efforts.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Sourabh Garg who is owner of Plot No. 42, area measuring 20 Sq. Yds. out of Kharsa No. 101/21, 22/1, 116/1/1, 2/1, 102/1, 117/16, Situated at Village Shi (Nahar Singh Colony), Tehsil Ballabhgarh, District Faridabad, Haryana, having acquired the same vide Sale Deed dated 10/07/2020 executed by Mrs. Jivdha Panwar in favour of Mr. Sourabh Garg duly registered in the office of SR-Ballabhgarh as registration No. 1102, Advt. Book No. 1, Dated 10/07/2020 now Shri Sourabh Garg intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from SIFMG India Credit Co. Ltd. That Original Original Sale Deed dated 20/06/1995 executed by Mr. Sajjan Singh in favour of Mr. Dharmender Singh and GPAATS And Will dated 19.11.2003 executed by Mr. Dharmender Singh in favour of Mrs. Sudeshna has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar, Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049. Contact no: 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Mr. Gopal Vashista had acquired Plot No. 856, measuring 178.20sq.mtrs., Sector-57/U.E-II, Gurugram, Haryana vide Conveyance Deed dt. 05.03.2026 executed by HUDA, Doc. No. 20810, Original Allotment Letter favouring Mrs. Jyoti, Reallotment dt.12.05.2006 & Exchange Letter dt.03.10.2012 favouring Mrs. Nirmal Rani, Reallotment dt.27.05.2017 favouring Mr. Gopal Vashista all issued by HUDA are lost. Now Mr. Gopal Vashista is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CFCFL.
OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H.No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi 110024

AXIS BANK
Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samarwathar Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380005 Also at Axis Bank Ltd., Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002
Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described here below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) attentions is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower/ Co-borrower: Gajendra Singh Rathore, Flat No 118, Sector-33 Rail, Vihar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301.2. Rukaman Kanwar Flat No 118, Sector-33 Rail Vihar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301
Description of Property: Flat No 1005, 10th Floor, Tower-a-2, Amra, amrapali Leisure Park, Greater Noida, Noida-201305

Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession:	Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.):
11-Sep-2025	17-Apr-2026	(Rupees) One Crore Forty Nine Lakh Twenty Nine Thousand Fifty Six and Paisea Thirty Six Only)

The above-mentioned Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) are hereby given a 30 days' Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days' from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: 21-Apr-2026, **Place:** Noida **Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.**

LOST AND FOUND
Amar Singh S/o Sh. Harnarayan Singh R/o DDA MIG Flat No. 38 - D, 3rd Floor, Pocket-C, Ph-II, Jhilmil, Delhi-110092, has been lost of original Demand Letter, Possession Letter, NOC and Possession Slip etc of MIG Flat No.38 - D, 3rd Floor, Pocket-C, Ph-II, Jhilmil, Delhi-92 and not traceable of best efforts if found any person Contract No. 7738044482 or above address.

PUBLIC NOTICE
M/s Ankur Traders and Engineers Pvt Ltd in MEASURING 0.650HECT, PART OF KHATA NO-38, KHASRA NO-520, SITUATED AT VILLAGE MADAPUR, MUSTAFABAD, PARGANA DASNA, TEHSIL DHAILANA, DISTT HAPUR, UP and FREEHOLD PLOT AREA MEASURING 0.3870 HECT, PART OF KHATA NO.7, KHASRA NO.518, VILLAGE MADAPUR, MUSTAFABAD, PARGANA DASNA, TEHSIL DHAILANA, DISTT HAPUR, UP. We have lost Sale Deed No. 217 dated 06.01.2016, Sale Deed No. 5573 dated 20.07.2016 anywhere in Hapur. A DDR No. 20260000364026 also registered at Hapur. We also declare that I have not taken any type of Loan, CC Limit or OD Limit on the said property. If anybody found and any concern with in this property, please contact, Advocate Bhupinder Kumar, Ph. No. 8295949981 # 1593, SECTOR 16-17, HISAR WITHIN 15 DAY OF THIS PUBLICATION.

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Anil Kurana and Mrs. Shaily Khurana are the owners of Plot Bearing Plot No-66, Block-D, admeasuring 250.00 Sq Mtr, in the Residential Colony known as Sushant Lok Phase II, Sector - 57, Situated in and around Village Tigra, Tehsil and Distt. Gurgaon Haryana through Sale Deed Dated 03.09.2004 as doc. no. 11879 executed by M/s Ansal Properties & Industrial Ltd. in favour of Mr. Anil Kurana and Mrs. Shaily Khurana in respect of Plot bearing No-66, area measuring 250.00 Sq Mtrs. for which complaint is regd vide Application No.- 2405212026, registered at P.S. Dwarika Sector-23, Crime Branch, Delhi on 17.04.2026. Anyone who finds the above-mentioned documents, is requested to hand over the same to the Manager of ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd., having office at Janakpuri.
Mr. Anil Kurana and Mrs. Shaily Khurana intends to transfer the ownership of above said plot by way of Sale Deed to Mrs. Shikha Nagar. Subsequently, Mrs. Shikha Nagar is in the process of mortgaging the said property with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. 44A/1A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +910120-4499711, e-mail: accounts@nvrnorth.in



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With focus on fire safety compliance and emergency preparedness, Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday visited the Fire Service Management Academy (FSMA), Rohini. The visit was aimed at reviewing the operational readiness, training, and standards of the Delhi Fire Service and assessing gaps in enforcement.

During the visit, the LG reviewed training modules and operational preparedness at FSMA and witnessed live demonstrations of firefighting and rescue operations, including deployment of specialised equipment such as the indigenous AWT (Articulating Water Tower) with a reach of up to 55 metres for firefighting operations, remote-controlled firefighting machines, mini-robots, and specialised Turntable Ladders imported from Germany.

Interacting with trainee officers, he reiterated that summer had set in and stressed the need for preparedness and quick response. He highlighted

the importance of modern technology in strengthening firefighting operations, expressed confidence in their professionalism, and assured full administrative support whenever required.

Earlier, the LG had also chaired a high-level review meeting with officials of the Department of Delhi Fire Service, where he reviewed modernisation of infrastructure, strengthening of manpower, and overall emergency response systems.

Expressing concern over the reports of institutions operating without mandatory fire safety clearances, he pointed out that schools, hospitals, hotels, and theatres, etc running without valid fire NOCs put lives at risk. He reiterated that fire safety is a non-negotiable aspect of urban governance, particularly in critical institutions such as schools, hospitals and public buildings.

The LG directed that inspections be intensified, pending applications be fast-tracked, and strict action be taken against institutions operating without valid fire safety clearances.

NDMC files NGT report on stray feeding curbs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has submitted a compliance report before the National Green Tribunal (NGT) detailing action to regulate the feeding of pigeons, monkeys, cattle and stray dogs, and to address related sanitation concerns.

According to the report filed on Friday, the civic body has identified pigeon feeding points in its area and directed the staff to regularly penalise people causing insanitary conditions.

"In the last three months to identify locations of pigeon feeding points, 23 challans were done in January 2026, 14 in February 2026, and 39 in March 2026, and directions



were issued to challan regularly the persons creating insanitary conditions," the report stated, adding that the enforcement department has also removed unauthorised vendors from the concerned areas. Daily cleaning is also being carried out at such locations, the officials said.

Regarding stray dogs, the NDMC said it has taken steps through the Palika ABC Society to regulate feeding. Around 100 designated feeding points have been identified and 100 instruction boards installed.

No summer relief: Electricity bills headed for hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Electricity bills in Delhi could become more expensive in the coming months after the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity (APTEL) on Monday rejected a request to delay repayment of dues worth around ₹38,552 crore.

The request was made by the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC), which wanted more time so that the burden on consumers could be spread out and a sudden rise in bills could be avoided. The Tribunal has directed DERC to commence the liquidation of regulatory assets within three weeks from April 20, emphasising timely compliance with the Supreme Court's mandate.

"We direct the Commission to commence the process of liquidation of regulatory assets as per the Regulatory Assets (RA) judgement of the Supreme Court within three weeks from today positively," a bench comprising Judicial

Member Virender Bhat and Officiating Chairperson Seema Gupta said in the 61-page order.

With that request rejected, Delhi may now have to follow the earlier repayment schedule. The APTEL has also set aside the DERC's move to conduct an audit of Delhi's power distribution companies (Discoms) through the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG). Following this, the DERC has invited bids for hiring of audit services for undertaking Verification, Reconciliation & Finalisation of Enforcement Sales for BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL) and Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL).

Accordingly, the DERC may issue an order to recover the ₹38,552 crore through a higher Regulatory Assets (RA) surcharge in power bills, enabling recovery from consumers in a phased manner over a period of seven years. This includes ₹19,174 crore for BRPL, ₹12,333 crore for BYPL, and ₹7,046 crore for TPDDL, reflecting approved expendi-

tures incurred by discoms in supplying electricity.

"...The Commission has been delaying the liquidation of regulatory assets for one reason or another, thereby permitting an increase in the amount of regulatory assets day by day, which would place an additional burden upon the end consumers of the electricity in the NCT of Delhi. We do not see any cogent and plausible reason which is preventing the Commission from commencing the liquidation of regulatory assets.

The entire conduct of the Commission in this regard appears to be malicious and needs to be deprecated. The Commission has been holding back its hands on the regulatory assets despite giving repeated undertakings and assurances in this regard to the Supreme Court, to the Delhi High Court and to this Tribunal, the details of which have been noted herein above, as pointed by the Learned Counsels for Delhi Discoms," the bench



observed. The Tribunal observed that while the Supreme Court, in its judgment dated August 6, 2025, had directed regulatory commissions to undertake a "strict and intensive audit" of Discoms, it did not specify that such an audit must be carried out by the CAG. It further held that the statuto-

ry requirements under Section 20 of the CAG Act were not complied with. It also noted that the Discoms were not allowed to present their case before the audit decision was taken.

On these grounds, the Tribunal quashed the approval dated March 5, 2026, for the proposed CAG audit.

At the same time, the Tribunal directed DERC to proceed with the audit by appointing an independent Chartered Accountant within one week from the date of the order and to complete the exercise within three months, in line with the Supreme Court's directions.

In recent years, electricity

tariffs were reduced for consumers in the capital. At the same time, unpaid dues kept piling up in the system. That means the pending amount now has to be cleared somehow.

Notably, Delhi's situation is also different from states where power distributors are Government-owned. In states like Tamil Nadu, Governments have indicated they may absorb part of the burden instead of passing it directly to consumers. Delhi's discoms, including BSES Yamuna Power Limited and BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, are privately run.

The recovery, therefore, may have to come through higher tariffs, higher subsidies from the Delhi Government, or a mix of both. So, unless an alternative funding solution is found, electricity bills in Delhi for households and businesses are likely to face upward pressure.

For households and businesses, the message is simple: unless another funding solution is found,

Delhi electricity bills could face upward pressure in the months ahead.

The order from APTEL came after DERC moved the tribunal seeking permission to have the accounts of power discoms audited by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) to verify the legitimacy of the RA claims.

DERC had argued that spreading repayments over a longer period would soften the blow for consumers and prevent a sudden tariff spike. However, the tribunal did not agree. Delhi will now have to follow the existing repayment schedule.

The issue goes back to Supreme Court directions issued in August 2025. The court asked all state regulators to begin clearing such dues from April 2024 and complete the process by April 2028.

The Supreme Court also said regulators could use all available options to recover the money, including increasing electricity tariffs if required.

CM pulls up officials over delays in Azadpur inspection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday conducted a surprise inspection in north Delhi's Azadpur area, expressing strong dissatisfaction over delays in development work, poor coordination among agencies, and unsatisfactory sanitation conditions. She warned officials that negligence in public projects will not be tolerated and directed them to ensure visible progress on the ground.

The inspection covered key locations including Gupta Market, Azadpur Chowk and Tripolia Chowk. The Chief Minister reviewed the ongoing works of the Delhi Metro and the Public Works Department and sought real-time updates from officials present at the site. She made it clear that development must reflect in actual execution and not remain limited to paperwork.

During an on-site review meeting, the Chief Minister stressed that all projects



must follow three key principles: transparency, strict timelines, and high-quality standards. She said delays in execution directly affect public convenience and directed departments to complete all works within fixed deadlines without compromising safety or accessibility.

Addressing the issue of waterlogging in the area, the Chief Minister instructed the Public Works Department to prepare a comprehensive plan for rebuilding the drainage system in Azadpur, Adarsh Nagar, and Tripolia Chowk. She also ordered immediate

desilting of drains to provide short-term relief while ensuring a permanent solution is developed.

The Chief Minister asked officials to speed up road repairs and ensure that streets are free of potholes. She also directed authorities to restore and improve footpaths to make them safer and more accessible for pedestrians. Emphasis was laid on improving waste management systems and ensuring regular cleanliness drives across the area.

The Chief Minister warned that all works will be closely monitored and any lapses

will result in direct accountability of the officials concerned. She also reviewed civic infrastructure and called for prompt repair of damaged public facilities.

A major part of the inspection focused on ongoing Metro construction work. At Azadpur Chowk, the Chief Minister examined structural aspects of the project, including the quality and strength of pillars.

She expressed concern over any shortcomings and directed officials to ensure that construction meets all safety and quality standards.

She also instructed that footpaths affected by Metro construction must be restored immediately after completion of work.

Proper drainage arrangements at construction sites were also mandated to prevent water accumulation. The Chief Minister stressed the need for coordination between different agencies, especially with the Public Works Department, to ensure the timely completion of projects.

Government makes rainwater harvesting mandatory; offers 10 per cent rebate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has made it mandatory to install rainwater harvesting systems and will share part of the cost and provide a 10 per cent rebate where rainwater harvesting systems are functional. At the same time, if systems are not installed or not maintained, that rebate can be withdrawn.

Announcing this measure to conserve water, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh also said it will mitigate the twin issues of urban flooding during monsoons and water shortages in the next summer.

He said this after chairing a high-level meeting bringing together officials from over 60 departments of the Delhi Government and the Government of India.

The meeting marked a decisive shift in policy and execution-with a clear direction that rainwater harvesting



systems will now be treated as mandatory and actively enforced across the city. The initiative aligns with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his call to "Catch the Rain - where it falls, when it falls," turning water conservation into a people's movement.

Addressing officials, the Minister emphasised that Delhi receives sufficient rainfall, but fails to conserve it effectively. "For four months every year, rainwater flows through our drains and goes

to waste. If we channel this water into the ground, we can recharge our groundwater and reduce the crisis we face every summer," he said.

The Minister announced that all departments have been given clear, time-bound targets. Government buildings, parks, residential colonies, and institutional campuses must install functional rainwater harvesting systems before the onset of the monsoon. "Every department has been assigned responsibility. First,

Government buildings must lead by example- if systems are not installed, they must be put in place immediately. If they exist, we will ensure they are working properly before the rains arrive," he stated.

In a significant policy move, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) will play a central role in implementation and monitoring. The Board will not only support installation efforts but also provide financial incentives. "DJB will share part of the cost and provide a 10 per cent rebate where rainwater harvesting systems are functional. At the same time, if systems are not installed or not maintained, that rebate can be withdrawn," the Minister added.

He also underlined stricter enforcement measures going forward. While rainwater harvesting has long been mandatory for certain properties during building approvals, the lack of monitoring has weakened compliance.

Delhi plans ₹200 crore Ekta Mall at Pitampura Dilli Haat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning a ₹200 crore Prime Minister Unity (Ekta) Mall in Pitampura's Dilli Haat under the Centre's One District One Product initiative, to create a national platform for artisans, local products, cuisine, art and cultural traditions, an official document said.

The project will be developed by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) and will have 36 stalls for States and Union Territories, with one stall each for districts of the respective States, along with a food court.

Public conveniences, parking facilities, exhibition spaces, cultural activity zones and dedicated areas for events, summits and conferences will



also be made, a tender document said.

It said the Unity Mall is being designed as a blend of local architecture and modern facilities to strengthen the Make in India and ODOP concepts, help rural artisans sell their products on a larger platform and preserve local handicrafts, cuisine, literature, culture and traditions.

The proposed project area will cover a minimum of 1,200 square metres and is expected to come up tentatively at the existing Dilli Haat Pitampura premises, although the final location will be decided by the Delhi Government.

Similar projects are being implemented in several other states under the scheme, it said.

BJP welcomes HC order on Kejriwal recusal plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday welcomed the Delhi High Court's decision to reject a plea by Arvind Kejriwal and others seeking the recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma in the excise policy case, and launched a sharp attack on the former Chief Minister, saying the ruling reinforces that an accused cannot choose a judge.

Reacting to the court's decision, Delhi Minister Parvesh Verma launched a sharp attack on the former Chief Minister, saying the ruling reinforces that an accused cannot choose a judge. Verma said allowing such demands would weaken the judicial system and disrupt court functioning across the country.

He pointed to the large number of pending cases at various levels, including trial courts, High Courts and the Supreme Court, and said the system would



L-R: Arvind Kejriwal and Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma

collapse if litigants began selecting judges.

The Delhi High Court dismissed the plea that sought the recusal of Justice Sharma from hearing matters related to the excise policy case. The petitioners had cited concerns of possible bias, which the court found legally untenable.

Verma accused Kejriwal of attempting to cast doubts on the judiciary. He said such actions risk undermining public confidence in institutions that must function independently.

He also questioned the basis of the plea, noting that the appeal itself accepted the lower court's ruling as correct while raising objections against the High Court judge on perceived grounds.

According to Verma, the argument was based on the judge's presence at a public event, which was cited as a reason for apprehension. He dismissed this reasoning and said it weakens the credibility of the judicial process. He added that such claims create a pattern where court decisions are

accepted only if they favour the accused.

Backing the High Court's decision, Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva said he agreed with every observation made in the judgment. He criticised Kejriwal for making personal remarks about the judge and her family in recent days.

Sachdeva said such comments cross the limits of propriety and could hurt the dignity of the judiciary. He questioned the logic behind linking a judge's impartiality to the professional roles of family members.

He said applying such reasoning would set an unreasonable precedent in the legal system. He further said courts are institutions meant for justice and not spaces for political confrontation. According to him, attempts to build narratives through personal allegations are misplaced, as judicial decisions are based on facts and legal findings.

HC advocate dies after fall from 15th Floor of CP hotel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 26-year-old advocate practising at the Delhi High Court died by suicide on Sunday night after jumping from the 15th-floor balcony of The Royal Plaza hotel in Central Delhi's Connaught Place area.

The deceased, identified as Rajesh Singh, a resident of Mahavir Enclave, had cut through the protective net of the balcony using a pair of scissors before jumping. He left behind a two-page suicide note asking that no one be held responsible for his death.

Police received information about the incident at around 9:15 pm on April 19 at Connaught Place police station. The station house officer-led a team immediately to the hotel.

Rajesh was taken to Lady Hardinge Medical College, where doctors

declared him dead. His body has been preserved for post-mortem examination.

In the note, which ran to two pages, Rajesh wrote that no one should be held guilty for what he had done. He also made one final request: that an orchid be placed on his table.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that Rajesh had checked into The Royal Plaza the previous evening, Saturday, April 18, at around 6:30 pm. The hotel room's windows were sealed from the inside. He had come prepared for a night alone. He had brought two bottles of liquor with him to the room.

According to police sources, investigators have been able to reconstruct much of what happened in the hours between his check-in and his death. He had a drink. He smoked a cigarette. Then, at some point in the



evening, he called his former girlfriend. The two had broken up roughly six months earlier.

They had first met during their college years. The content of that conversation has not been fully established. Police said the exact exchange between them is not yet known. What is known is what followed.

The former girlfriend, apparently alarmed by the call, contacted Rajesh's closest friend, who was in

Mumbai. That friend then called Rajesh's sister and told her something seemed wrong. The family immediately began trying to locate him.

They first approached the Palam police station, from where they were able to determine through his phone location that Rajesh was somewhere in Connaught Place.

They made their way there. By the time they were close to finding him, he had already jumped.

Police said he had cut through the protective net of the 15th-floor balcony using a pair of scissors, which were recovered from the room. The balcony net of the hotel had been breached at a specific point, consistent with the use of a sharp implement.

The Crime Team and forensic experts visited the spot and collected evidence from the hotel room and the site of the fall.

FRI Dehradun to submit report on tree transplants in six months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Forest Research Institute (FRI) in Dehradun, which was tasked to study the reasons for the low survival rate of transplanted trees in Delhi, will submit its interim report in six months, with the final report due in 12 months.

The study will span a total period of one year from the release of the first installment of the sanctioned budget, a source in the department said, adding that ₹30 lakh has been allocated for the exer-



cise. "The interim report will focus on a review of existing literature and documented data on tree transplantation, while the final report will present detailed findings based on field assessments and scientific analysis," the source added.

The move comes amid concerns over low survival rates. A previous report by FRI estimated an overall survival rate of 35.45 per cent, with variation across species. The forest department data also showed that of 1,357 trees transplanted between 2019 and 2022, only 578 survived, translating to a survival rate of 42.5 per cent.

Delhi Environment and Forest Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa earlier told PTI that the study is aimed at making the transplantation process more effective.

IN FOCUS



A caretaker showers Rajlakshmi, an Asian elephant, to beat the heat at the National Zoological Park in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With summer just getting started, parts of India are already feeling the burn. If stepping out already feels harsher than usual, the coming days may not bring much relief, as scorching temperatures are set to sweep across north India from April 21 to April 22, pushing maximums to 42-45 degrees Celsius in several States.

Eastern and central India are already sweltering under 43-45 degrees Celsius daily, and the heat is now getting worse. Weather forecasts severe temperatures for Delhi-NCR, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, with searing heat



BMC workers sprinkle water on a road as people walk through to get relief from the heat in Bhopal

wave not ruled out. In its forecast, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday predicted heat wave conditions are very likely to prevail over isolated pockets of north-west, central and the adjoining parts of east India for the next four to five days.

IMD said isolated pockets of Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Punjab, East Rajasthan, Vidarbha, Chhattisgarh, West Uttar Pradesh, West Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gangetic West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha and scattered pockets of East Uttar Pradesh are expected to

witness heatwave conditions on different dates between April 20 and April 25.

“Hot and humid weather conditions are very likely to prevail in isolated pockets over Gangetic West Bengal during April 20-26; Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal during April 20-22; Kerala and Mahe, Coastal Andhra Pradesh and Yanam during April 20-24; coastal areas of Gujarat on April 24 and April 25,” the IMD said.

Also, warm night conditions are expected to prevail in isolated pockets over Haryana, Chandigarh, West Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha on April 20 and April 21, Chhattisgarh on April 20, and Odisha between April 20 and April 22.

From May 1, CBI notices to carry QR code to verify genuineness

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

CBI notices from May 1 will carry a special QR code, allowing people to verify their genuineness through an artificial intelligence-powered chatbot, ABHAY, a first-of-its-kind initiative by any agency to deter the public from falling prey to cybercriminals, officials said on Monday.

Launching the chatbot at the 22nd DP Kohli Memorial Lecture in New Delhi on Monday, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant called it a “pivotal and opportune initiative” that would act as an “effective safeguard” against fraudsters masquerading as CBI officials.

“Such a mechanism can serve as an effective safeguard against fraudsters who masquerade as CBI officials



and circulate fabricated notices through instant-messaging platforms, often invoking the threat of so-called digital arrest to coerce and browbeat unsuspecting individuals,” the CJI said. A senior CBI official said the QR codes will also include the notices’ expiry dates.

When a person receives the purported notice, they can scan the QR code on ABHAY available on the CBI website, which will immediately check the agency’s database to determine whether the document is genuine or forged.

Domestic worker among 3 held for Golf Links robbery

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested three men, including a domestic worker, for allegedly holding a businessman’s family hostage and looting valuables worth around ₹25 lakh from their residence in the upscale Golf Links area, officials said on Monday.

The accused have been identified as Guddu Kumar Kamat alias Raju, 35, and Raman Kamat alias Sushil, 38, both residents of Bihar, and Amit Singh alias Gabbar, 30, a resident of Sangam Vihar in Delhi. Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Sachin Sharma said Guddu and Raman were arrested from Mumbai, while Amit was apprehended from Uttar Pradesh on Sunday after a multi-state operation.

According to police, the robbery took place on April 17 and involved a well-planned conspiracy led by the domes-



tic help, who had been recently employed at the victim’s house. Investigators said the accused had carried out a recce of the property before executing the crime.

During the probe, police found that Raman had joined the household just three days before the incident. He allegedly used this access to assist the gang. On the day of the robbery, he opened the main gate, allowing 5 to 6 accomplices to enter the premises.

ARSD collage fire sparks urgent demand for permanent classrooms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The students’ union of the DU’s Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma (ARSD) College urged the college administration to find a permanent solution to the use of bamboo porta-cabins as labs and classrooms, pointing to a recent fire that broke out in temporary structures.

Porta cabins have been used to accommodate the surge in student numbers following the introduction of the first batch of the four-year undergraduate pro-



grammes last year.

The principal of ARSD College, Gyantosh Kumar Jha, confirmed that a fire had broken out in one of the bamboo porta-cabins on

Saturday. “The porta-cabin had two rooms, the boys’ common room and a room of the college students’ union. The fire broke out due to a short circuit,” Jha

said. Pranav Bhatt, joint secretary of the students’ union of the college, said, “This fire thankfully did not injure anyone because this porta cabin was a little farther away from the main building and the rooms in it were less used. However, there were two biology labs and three classrooms operating out of similar portable cabins.”

“The classrooms have been shifted to the main building now, but the labs are still operational, which is why we have requested the authorities to find a solution. With increasing tempera-

ture and a heatwave already forecast by the weather department, the chances of fire increase, and action should be taken before something serious happens, not after.” A video of the fire that broke out has been circulating on social media.

Rudrashish Chakraborty, associate professor of English at Kirori Mal College (KMC), said, “This incident brings back concerns that we have been pointing out for months. When the first batch of fourth years was introduced, several colleges had to make temporary arrange-

ments like the porta-cabins to accommodate the increase in the number of students.”

Chakraborty added that the “lack of proper infrastructure” is reflected in many aspects, as the university, which he said was equipped to handle a three-year course, and the change to four-year programmes have put a strain on the facilities.

“These temporary structures often do not have adequate safety norms,” he said, emphasising the need to focus on the safety of students.

Azam Khan, son’s appeals rejected in dual PAN card case; conviction upheld

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rampur

A special MP/MLA court in Uttar Pradesh’s Rampur on Monday rejected the appeals filed by jailed senior Samajwadi Party leader Mohammad Azam

Khan and his son Abdullah against their conviction in a case related to possession of two PAN cards, officials said on Monday.

The two have been lodged in Rampur district jail since November 17, 2025, after a magistrate trial court

sentenced them to seven years’ imprisonment in the case. Following the conviction, both had moved appeals before the MP/MLA special sessions court, claiming innocence.

Delivering its order, the court of Special Judge



(MP/MLA) Vijay Kumar on Monday dismissed the appeals and upheld the conviction of both Azam Khan and his son. Assistant District Government Counsel (MP/MLA) Seema Singh Rana told reporters that the court has upheld

the findings of the lower court. “The appeals filed by Mohammad Azam Khan and Abdullah Azam Khan against their conviction in the dual PAN card case have been rejected, and the conviction has been upheld,” she said.

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Judge slams Kejriwal, says won’t recuse

She added that recusing from the matter without hearing it will amount to surrendering her duty. “I know I will be criticised as a judge. Chahe wo social media mein ho ya applications me. Mujhe pata hai ki mujhe kitna aur kya karna hai. Agar main bina sune recuse kar leti to main apni duty surrender kar deti (I will be surrendering my duty if I recuse without hearing the matter),” the judge said, adding that a courtroom cannot be a theatre of perception. Justice Sharma concluded that the narrative in the pleas for her recusal was based on conjectures and “perceived inclinations”. “This court will stand up for itself and the institution.... I will not recuse,” the judge said.

Kejriwal had raised several objections against the judge hearing the Central Bureau of Investigation’s (CBI) plea against his discharge in the liquor-policy case, including that she had earlier denied him relief on his petition challenging his arrest and refused to grant relief on the bail pleas of other accused, including Manish Sisodia and K Kavitha.

Besides Kejriwal, the applications for the judge’s recusal were also filed by Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leaders Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak. Other respondents, including Vijay Nair and Arun Ramchandra Pillai, had also sought her recusal. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta appeared in the court for the CBI and opposed the plea. He had earlier urged Justice Sharma to initiate contempt action against Kejriwal and the others for seeking her recusal.

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and others in the Delhi liquor-policy case, saying the CBI’s case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

Bus crash in Jammu kills 21, army rescues many

“I was leading the convoy when the accident occurred on the way. The vehicle fell from a height of nearly 100 metres. We immediately secured the area and launched the rescue operation, thus saving many precious lives including those of men and women with great difficulty,” said a soldier who was leading a convoy from Udhampur to Ramnagar.

Officials said two more critically injured persons succumbed to their injuries at Udhampur District Hospital during treatment, raising the death toll to 21.

“Army personnel were the first to reach us, appearing like messiahs amid the chaos and confusion. They pulled us out of the wreckage. I had a miraculous escape — this feels nothing less than a second life for me,” said Neetu Rani (32) from her hospital bed.

Sharing an update, MoS PMO, Dr Jitendra Singh, in a post on X confirmed the death toll as well. Dr Singh posted, “21 casualties so far and 61 injured. The injured have been shifted to Udhampur Hospital, while the other, more seri-

ously injured, is being airlifted to Government Medical College, Jammu. My sincere condolences to the bereaved families. All possible assistance is being provided”. President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the loss of lives in the accident.

He also announced an ex gratia of ₹2 lakh for the families of those killed and ₹50,000 for those injured in the accident.

J-K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah assured all possible assistance to the families of the deceased and those injured. Omar also announced immediate relief from the Chief Minister’s Relief Fund for victims of the Udhampur road accident.

An ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh will be provided to the next of kin of each deceased, ₹1 lakh to those seriously injured, and ₹25,000 to persons who sustained minor injuries in the accident.

Nearly 3,700 people have died, and over 29,000 others were injured in more than 20,000 road accidents across Jammu and Kashmir since June 2022.

US seizes Iranian ship as Trump pushes for peace

In the leadup and throughout the seven-week war, Trump has faced criticism from the left and from some of his own supporters that he followed Israel’s lead into launching the conflict.

But Trump on social media is blaming the media for pushing what he claims is a false narrative. “Israel never talked me into the war with Iran, the results of Oct. 7th, added to my lifelong opinion that IRAN CAN NEVER HAVE A NUCLEAR WEAPON,” Trump posted.

The New York Post quoted Trump in an interview claiming that Vice President JD Vance is headed to Pakistan for negotiations on the Iran War, along with special envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, who is Trump’s son-in-law.

“They’re heading over now,” Trump said. “They’ll be there tonight.”

But it’s not quite clear if Trump was speaking more broadly or if the claims about Vance are accurate. Administration officials have in response to questions declined to confirm if Vance is, in fact, mid-air on the way to Islamabad, the capital of Pakistan.

Navy escorts ships in Hormuz

The Navy has deployed at least seven of its ships near the Persian Gulf for this endeavor and are escorting the Indian vessels once they cross the Strait of Hormuz. At present, fourteen Indian ships are still in the Persian Gulf, waiting to cross Hormuz. The Indian Navy remains in constant communication with these vessels and has advised them to move only after clearance.

The fresh advisory, meanwhile, comes after the firing incident on two Indian vessels by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) on April 18. Since then, the Indian Navy has further shored up its security drills, it was learnt.

As tensions continue in the region, 11 Indian

vessels have already crossed the strait so far. The last tanker, Desh Garima, crossed on April 18 — the same day two Indian vessels, Jag Arnav and Sanmar Herald, had to turn back after being fired upon by Iranian Guards while attempting the passage. After crossing the strait, Desh Garima is now being escorted by the Indian Navy in the Arabian Sea and is expected to arrive in Mumbai on April 22. As regards the caution for the Larak Island, it is located at the narrowest point of the Strait of Hormuz and is home to a major portion of Iran’s oil infrastructure. As it is critical to Iran’s energy sector, the surrounding waters are heavily guarded, and traffic through Hormuz is closely monitored through a network of bunkers and radar systems. The Larak Island lies south of Hormuz Island in the roughly 33-km-wide Strait of Hormuz, a key chokepoint that carried about 20% of global oil before the Iran-US conflict.

According to reports, several Iranian bases operate there as well, capable of deploying smaller, faster boats to target vessels.

For now, this is being treated as the safer shipping corridor, passing between Hormuz and Larak islands. The pre-war lane further south near the Oman coast is currently being avoided, with reports suggesting possible mine-related risks in the area. With Indian vessels now advised against passing close to Larak Island, the passage of any Indian ship through the Strait of Hormuz remains uncertain unless it receives clearance from the Indian Navy.

Pahalgam butcher linked to posh Pak area

He established a base in Yaripora village of Kulgam district and easily mixed with the locals. Known for a prosthetic leg below the knee, he earned the nickname ‘Langda’ among villagers. In 2007, he married a local woman, Shabbira Kutche. The couple had a son named Umar but Habibullah fled back to Pakistan with his wife in 2007, abandoning his infant son in the village. Investigations have established that Habibullah was already involved in several targeted killings of non-locals during his two-year stay in the Kashmir valley.

Upon returning to Pakistan, he ran a dairy business in Kasur as a front while deepening his LeT ties. He trained regularly about three times a year at the outfit’s Markaz Yarmouk training camp. “In 2012, senior LeT leader Zaki-ur-Rehman Lakhvi elevated him to a key operational role overseeing Kashmir-specific modules. Post-2012, he adopted aliases like Sajid Jatt and Ali Sajid, directing attacks from across the border while heading LeT’s offshoot, The Resistance Front (TRF). He is also described as a close aide to LeT Founder Hafiz Saeed and has been linked to the group’s political front, ‘Milli Muslim League’, a senior security official said on Monday.

Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) of Pakistan has housed him in a three-storey yellow-coloured house in Soan Garden, Islamabad, an active LeT command hub shared with other operatives, including Ghulam Abbas alias Samama and commander Huzefa Bakkarwal. Habibullah holds a Pakistani national identity card issued in 2020,

listing an address in a posh Islamabad sector. However, central security agencies say Habibullah resides in the Soan Garden location.

The Pakistani national identity card with a different address has been issued by the ISI to keep his identity secret. Meanwhile, investigations and forensic evidence gathered by the Central agencies and Jammu and Kashmir police have established Habibullah’s role in multiple strikes. He was involved in the 2013 Haiderpora attack on security forces, the DKG and Surankot operations, the 9 June 2024 Reasi bus attack in which nine Hindu pilgrims were killed and most importantly in the Pahalgam massacre. On 22 April 2025, though some reports cite 15 April, terrorists Bilal Afzal alias Faisal Jatt, Habib Tahir and Hanan Zafar alias Hamza Afghani, all Pakistani nationals from Punjab and PoK, struck Baisaran meadow near Pahalgam, killing 26 civilians and injuring 20. The trio was later eliminated in Operation Mahadev.

Recovered mobile phones, forensically examined at the Central Forensic Science Laboratory, revealed WhatsApp messages from Sajid Jatt’s number sending precise coordinates via the Alpine Quest App. Devices were traced to LeT-linked sites near Karachi’s Faisal House and Lahore’s Quid-e-Azam Industrial Estate, sources in security agencies said.

TRF claimed the attack on social media, with propaganda traced to Pakistani numbers and locations including Battagram in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa region. The National Investigation Agency (NIA)’s 1,597-page chargesheet filed on 15 December 2025, has named Sajid Jatt as the main conspirator alongside LeT and TRF, detailing a joint ISI-LeT plot that used only Pakistani attackers to maintain deniability. He is wanted for waging war against India, among other charges. Security officials describe Sajid Jatt as a hardcore terrorist, who orchestrated civilian-targeted violence in Kashmir. His ability to maintain a low profile while running cross-border operations from a secure Islamabad base underscores Pakistan’s continued support for LeT infrastructure. Indian security agencies continue to track his network, with the NIA examining links to other outfits like Jaish-e-Mohammed. As India’s most-wanted LeT commander, Habibullah alias Saifullah Sajid Jatt remains a high-priority target, his past in Kulgam now a grim reminder of how Pakistan-based handlers easily embedded themselves in the Valley’s terror ecosystem.

Wanted LeT terrorist in Saudi: Security agencies

Using forged documents and the Rajasthan residency claim, he obtained an Indian passport in the name of Sajjad. Questions have been raised about lapses in police verification during issuance. He fled India in 2024, using the fake passport. He first went to Indonesia. From there, he used another forged travel document to reach Saudi Arabia.

There is no extradition treaty between India and Saudi Arabia, but J&K authorities with help from central agencies and the Union Ministry of External Affairs, are pursuing his extradition through diplomatic channels.

The details emerged during a major Srinagar Police operation launched on 31 March 2026, directly monitored by DGP Nalin Prabhat targeting a deep-rooted inter-state LeT module. The case was registered earlier in April 2026 and is likely to be handed over to the National Investigation Agency (NIA). Details have been shared with central agencies and state police to plug loopholes in document verification and passport issuance.

The operation led to the arrest of two Pakistani terrorists Abdullah alias Abu Hureira, who was on the run for 16 years and Usman alias Khubaib from Malerkotla district in Punjab. Subsequent investigation led to the arrest of three Srinagar residents identified as Mohammad Naqeeb Bhat, Adil Rashid Bhat and Ghulam Mohammad Mir alias Mama by the J&K Police.

Their interrogations revealed the module’s funding networks, hideouts in forested areas around Srinagar, and links to arms procurement. This operation followed the dismantling of a ‘white-collar’ LeT cell linked to Faridabad’s Al Falah University in November 2025.

Parking dispute in Capital ends in murder

The BMW was parked. The argument, which had been simmering for days, flared late Sunday night again over where the second vehicle would go. What began as a neighbourhood disagreement over a few square feet of parking space turned into a shouting match that neither side was willing to step away from. Paras called his brother, Nayyar, from Noida for support. The arrival of reinforcement, however, did not calm things down. It made them worse.

Police allege that at this point, Sharma produced an illegal firearm and fired at Panjaj, hitting him in the chest. Panjaj collapsed on the spot. Sharma fled immediately.

Sharma’s wife has told investigators that her husband did not possess any weapon. Police are examining this claim and are probing whether the firearm was brought to the spot in advance or whether it was already in Sharma’s possession. The source of the weapon is a key thread in the investigation.

A crime team has inspected the site and is scanning CCTV footage from cameras in and around the building and the surrounding lanes to reconstruct the sequence of events and track the accused’s movement after he fled. Multiple police teams have been formed, and raids are being conducted at locations where Sharma might be hiding.

A case has been registered at Preet Vihar police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act.

The victim’s family is in shock. Residents of the building and the surrounding locality said the incident has created an atmosphere of fear. The area has been cordoned off, and evidence has been collected from the scene.

For a man who drove a BMW, the inability to find a place to park a second car ended with a neighbour dead and a family destroyed. Further investigation is ongoing.

India-South Korea ties enter futuristic phase

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

India and South Korea on Monday took a significant step toward strengthening their strategic and economic partnership, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and South Korean President Lee Jae Myung overseeing the signing of Multiple Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) aimed at deepening bilateral cooperation across sectors.

Addressing a joint press statement, PM Modi described President Lee's visit as a "crucial step" toward building a more advanced and future-ready bilateral framework. He warmly welcomed the South Korean leader on his

first visit to India, praising his personal journey as an inspiring example of perseverance, public service, and dedication.

"This visit of the President of Korea to India is extremely important. Democratic values, a market economy, and respect for the rule of law are in the DNA of both our countries. We also share a common outlook in the Indo-Pacific region," Modi said.

Highlighting the growing strength of bilateral ties, the Prime Minister noted that India-South Korea relations have become more dynamic and comprehensive over the past decade. He emphasised that the partnership is now transitioning into a more advanced phase.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi exchanges a handshake with South Korean President Lee Jae Myung at Hyderabad House in New Delhi on Monday

"With President Lee's visit, we are transforming this trusted partnership into a futuristic one. From chips to ships, talent to technology, and environment to energy, we will unlock new opportunities for cooperation and ensure shared progress and prosperity," he added.

President Lee echoed similar optimism, stating that

both nations aim to double their annual trade volume from the current USD 25 billion to USD 50 billion by 2030. He underlined the importance of collaboration in an increasingly uncertain global environment.

"In this era of uncertainty, India and Korea can be ideal partners for comprehensive cooperation to promote mutual growth and innovation," Lee said.

He added that both sides have agreed to expand cooperation in strategic sectors such as shipbuilding, artificial intelligence, finance, and defence, while also enhancing cultural and people-to-people exchanges.

Both leaders also reaffirmed

their commitment to maintaining peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region, with PM Modi stressing the importance of a "peaceful, progressive, and inclusive Indo-Pacific."

The bilateral relationship has steadily gained momentum since the implementation of the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in 2010, which significantly boosted trade and investment flows between the two countries.

Reiterating the shared vision, Modi said, "Through our collective efforts, we will continue to contribute to a peaceful, progressive, and inclusive Indo-Pacific," signalling a new chapter in India-South Korea relations.

CPI(M) moves ECI against PM over misuse of Doordarshan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Monday lodged a formal complaint with the Election Commission of India (ECI), accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi of violating the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) by using the public broadcaster, Doordarshan, for "partisan political messaging."

The complaint pertains to the Prime Minister's address to the nation on April 18. The CPI(M) alleged that the broadcast was a "blatant" attempt to influence voters in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, where Assembly elections are imminent.

In a letter addressed to the Chief Election Commissioner, CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby stated that the content and tone of the Prime Minister's speech could not be classified as Governmental communication. "It was blatantly political, targeting the Opposition parties — naming many of them — and seeking to influence public opinion in favour of the ruling party," the letter read.

The party argued that the broadcast violated Section 4 of the MCC, which explicitly prohibits the "misuse of official mass media during the election period for partisan coverage of political news."

TCS Nashik case: Unmasking the harassment racket inside tech giant

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

In the brightly lit corridors of Tata Consultancy Services' Nashik BPO unit, Sumita Kakkar (name changed for privacy) believed she had found stability. A bright software engineer, she joined the Sai Nath Nagar facility in early 2025, drawn by the company's reputation and the promise of professional growth. But between June 2025 and March 2026, she realised her dreams of a stable professional career were going down the drain. What began as subtle workplace friction soon turned into a nightmare of coercion, sexual harassment, stalking and religious intimidation.

Her ordeal started with her team leader. Under the guise of 'formal training', he would lean too close, put his hands on her shoulders or brush her waist. She brushed it off at first as she thought it was awkward corporate proximity.

Then came the incident during Gudi Padwa celebrations in March 2026. Another colleague took advantage of the festive cheer, molesting her while colleagues celebrated outside.

"They made it clear this was no accident," she later told police in her chilling testimony before the SIT. Her complaint is part of nine FIRs now rocking the IT giant.

Six accused team leaders and seniors - Danish Sheikh, Asif Ansari, Shafi Sheikh, Shahrukh Qureshi, Raza Memon and Tusif Attar - let loose a reign of psychological terror. They mocked her Hindu faith openly. One sneered at Hindu deities, calling the worship of Shivaling 'obscene' and twisting tales from the Mahabharata to demean her beliefs.

"Rapes happen because women don't wear burqas." The words hit her hard, equating her refusal to convert with moral failure. Then the objectionable jabs about her marital life began.



Accused in the alleged TCS Nashik sexual harassment and religious coercion case being produced at the District Sessions Court in Nashik

When she pushed back, the stalking escalated beyond the office. Social media messages flooded her phone, unwanted, persistent. Blocking them changed nothing; new accounts appeared. Fear became her constant companion as her tormentors upped the attack.

Faced with persistent sexual advances and mental trauma, the complainant tried the internal route. Emails to HR went unanswered or met with indifference. One senior allegedly

dismissed her pleas: "These things happen in the corporate world." No action followed. Left with no other option, she and seven other women, plus one male colleague, filed complaints at the Mumbai Naka police station in Nashik.

The Nashik police responded swiftly, forming a Special Investigation Team. Nine FIRs were registered for molestation, mental harassment, hurting religious sentiments, and attempted forceful conversion. By mid-

April 2026, eight arrests followed, including a female operations manager, Ashwini Chainani, accused of shielding the perpetrators as a member of the Internal Complaints Committee.

Meanwhile, the processing associate Nida Khan, named in one FIR and dubbed the alleged mastermind by investigators, has remained elusive. Police teams visited Mumbai near Thane, tracing leads as she fled for anticipatory bail in Nashik sessions court, citing her pregnancy.

The court refused to grant any interim relief to her on Monday and has posted the matter for April 27. While Nida Khan's family insisted the case was fabricated, Nashik police called it a coordinated racket targeting young Hindu women. Nashik Police Commissioner Sandeep Kamik has made it amply clear that the SIT headed by ACP Sandeep Mitkar is carrying out an in-depth investigation. The SIT will file the chargesheet in due course.

Fire at Rajasthan refinery a day before opening

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi/Jaipur

A major fire broke out near the main unit of the newly built ₹79,450-crore Rajasthan refinery of Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) on Monday, a day before the scheduled inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Thick columns of black smoke emitted from the fire that broke out near the crude distillation unit — the primary or front-end unit that is often referred to as the heart of an oil refinery. The blaze at the HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd (HRRL) refinery was doused in about two hours, with no reported casualties, officials said.

But the Prime Minister's event to dedicate to the nation the 9 million tonnes a year oil refinery-cum-petrochemical complex at Pachpadra in Balotra district of Rajasthan, which was scheduled for Tuesday, was postponed.



Firefighters douse a blaze after a fire broke out at the HPCL Pachpadra Refinery in Balotra, Rajasthan

VHP urges industry bodies to review recruitment practices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Monday called for a review of hiring and placement practices in the corporate sector, urging companies to exercise vigilance in recruitment from "particular" communities and in assigning supervisory roles, especially where women employees are concerned.

The organisation said it has written to major industry bodies, including FICCI, CII, ASSOCHAM, PHDCCI and NASSCOM, seeking their intervention and calling for



stricter implementation of the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013.

Addressing a press confer-

ence, VHP general secretary Bajrang Lal Bagra said the organisation does not support quota-based hiring and stressed the need for caution in recruitment.

Referring to the case involving Tata Consultancy Services' Nashik unit, he said, "What has come out in the Nashik case is that Hindu girls were being forced to convert to the Muslim faith under pressure.

Our concern is that special attention should be given to the recruitment of male employees from a particular community and to their behaviour toward Hindu

women colleagues." The VHP demanded a review of existing placements in companies, particularly where reporting structures involve women employees working under supervisors from specific communities.

"In large corporations where young men and women come to work far from their homes, the conversion of Hindu girls to the Muslim faith is what we call 'corporate jihad'," Bagra said and claimed that these were not isolated acts by individuals but "organised, funded and professionally executed" activities.

Put passenger safety and dignity first: President to railway officers



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Monday urged railway officers to always take decisions with the safety, comfort and dignity of passengers at the centre.

She also asked them to bring in fresh ideas and leverage technology to strengthen efficiency, improve safety and ensure smooth movement of passengers and freight. Addressing probationary officers of the Indian railways, who had called on the President at the Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi, Murmu said railways has one of the largest and most complex networks in the world, carrying not just passengers and goods, but also the aspirations of millions. "You will require not just technical skill but integrity, compassion and a deep sense of accountability to manage this system. You should always take decisions with the safety, comfort and

dignity of passengers at the centre," she said.

Murmu said infrastructure is the foundation upon which modern nations are built. "Railways and highways are not merely systems of transport; they are instruments of economic expansion, social inclusion and national integration. When a train reaches a remote village or a highway connects a distant region, it opens immense opportunities for socio-economic development of such regions," the President said.

She said that from modernisation of infrastructure and expansion of electrification to the introduction of advanced safety systems and improved passenger amenities, the railways is evolving to meet future demands.

"You can contribute effectively to this transformation," Murmu said.

Murmu asked the officers to "remember that efficiency must go hand in hand with empathy."

Shutdowns over civilian killings hit normal life in Manipur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

Normal life in several hill and valley districts of Manipur was affected on Monday following two shutdowns called by different organisations to protest the killing of two children and a couple of civilians at separate places by suspected militants earlier this month, officials said.

Educational establishments and markets remained closed, while public transport remained off the roads in all five valley districts, home to the Meitei community, and Naga-inhabited areas of Ukhrul and Senapati districts, they



said. Sit-ins against the killings were held at various parts of Imphal valley, including at Uripok and Nagaram locality of the State Capital.

Women's organisation Meira Paibis called a five-day shutdown since Sunday to

protest the April 7 bomb attack at Tronglaobi in Bishnupur district, in which a 5-year-old boy and his 6-month-old sister were killed while sleeping, and their mother was injured.

During protests against the incident, three people were killed, and around 30 others were injured in firing when a mob stormed a nearby CRPF camp.

The United Naga Council also called a three-day "total shutdown" beginning Monday to condemn the death of a retired Army man and another person after suspected militants fired at an Ukhrul-bound convoy of civilian vehicles coming from Imphal on April 18.

‘Height of hypocrisy’: BJP hits back at Congress over Pakistan remarks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP hit back at the Congress on Monday over its criticism of the Centre's foreign policy, accusing the Opposition party of siding with a "dalal country" and displaying "the height of hypocrisy" in its remarks on Pakistan.

The ruling party's statement came in response to a social media post from senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh, who took a swipe at the Modi Government over Pakistan's role in the US-Iran peace talks.

In his post on Monday, Ramesh said Pakistan Army



chief Field Marshal Asim Munir becoming a "huge favourite" of US President Donald Trump is a "monumental setback" for India and that the country needs a complete overhaul of its diplomatic-engagement strategy.

Responding to the criticism, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari wrote on social media, "Lectures on how to

handle Pakistan coming from Pakistan's friend Congress are the height of hypocrisy."

He recalled the Congress's failure in responding to the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks, when the party was in power at the Centre, and asked it to stop "sermonising" on foreign policy.

"The nation has not forgotten how, after the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks, the Congress Government failed to firmly target Pakistan-sponsored terror, gave Islamabad repeated cover, pushed failed Track-2 optics, and compromised India's sovereignty in the Sharm el-Sheikh joint statement," Bhandari said.

Mamata slams PM Modi's jhalmuri stop as scripted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Monday alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's unscheduled stop to buy Bengal's favourite snack 'jhalmuri' during poll campaigning in Jhargram was just a "drama".

"How come cameras were present when he made the unscheduled stop? The entire episode was scripted," she alleged at a poll rally at Murarai Assembly constituency in Birbhum district.

The prime minister on Sunday posted a video on his official X account in which he was seen buying 'jhalmuri', a popular Bengali street food made of puffed rice, green chillies, and spices from a nondescript shop in Jhargram.

The PM, who was accompanied by his security personnel, paid the shopkeeper for the snack. When the man denied taking the money, the prime minister insisted that he accept it.

Questioning the spontaneity of the entire episode, Banerjee said, "Cameras



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee speaks during a campaign ahead of West Bengal Assembly elections in Murarai

were placed there beforehand. The SPG (the force responsible for providing proximity security to the

prime minister) had arranged for the whole thing." "He was seen carrying a ₹10 note in his pocket. Is it

believable? It's all drama," she claimed.

Addressing the Murarai rally, the TMC supremo accused the BJP of secretly aiding "some traitors in fielding independents from the minority community in different constituencies".

"This has happened in my area, Bhabanipur, as well. They have come from Murshidabad and Malda," she said. "They have commodified religion. I respect humanity. I believe in secularism. I respect every religion, caste, creed and language. But those who have

betrayed their own people, betrayed our party, will be rejected by the people."

On the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, she accused the Election Commission of "first having deleted lakhs of names and then having branded people as infiltrators as wished by the BJP".

"But in the wake of the Supreme Court directive and due to my fight, 32 lakh electors of the 60 lakh who had been placed under logical discrepancy, have been retained in the rolls," she said.

States Focus



STALIN AND I SHARE VISION FOR DEVELOPMENT: KEJRIWAL

National convener of the Aam Aadmi Party, Arvind Kejriwal, on Monday said he shared a common vision for education, healthcare, and women's empowerment with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin. Kejriwal, former chief minister of Delhi, who is in the city to campaign for the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance candidates along with the chief minister today, said both have always learnt from each other. "I deeply appreciate the impact his dedicated governance has created in transforming the lives of the people of Tamil Nadu," Kejriwal said in a post on the social media platform after calling on Stalin.



DEFEAT THE SLAVE ALLIANCE IN TAMIL NADU: UDHAYANIDHI

Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Monday urged the people to defeat the 'slave' alliance and ensure a resounding win for the DMK-led SPA in the April 23 Assembly elections. Addressing a poll campaign at Thiruvottiyur in support of CPI (M) candidate L Sundararaj, he said the people should respond to the alleged "betrayal" of the BJP Government at the Centre for causing a financial crisis in Tamil Nadu. "Ensure the defeat of the slave alliance in Tamil Nadu. April 23 is the time to give a fitting reply to the BJP Government," he urged the people, apparently referring to the AIADMK's alliance with the BJP as a "slave" alliance.

Rajnath promises 'Durga Squad', seventh pay commission in Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sainthia (WB)

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday charged the TMC Government of plunging West Bengal into "lawlessness" and promised to set up a "Durga Squad" to protect women and implement the seventh pay commission for State Government employees if the BJP came to power in the State.

Addressing an election rally in Sainthia in Birbhum district, Singh accused the ruling TMC of presiding over a climate of fear, corruption and lawlessness and claimed that industries and investors were leaving the State due to insecurity and lack of Government support. Claiming that while the country was progressing under Prime Minister Narendra



Defense Minister Rajnath Singh during a roadshow in support of BJP candidates ahead of the West Bengal elections in Birbhum on Monday

Modi's leadership, Singh asked Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee why the State was lagging despite growth elsewhere in the country. "Under the TMC Government, corruption has increased, land mafias have increased, and nepotism has increased," he said, adding that if the BJP formed the Government, "goons and crim-

inals" would either be in jail or "hide inside their homes".

He alleged that while investments were flowing into other States, investors were reluctant to come to Bengal because of the presence of "goons and criminals" and the absence of protection from the State Government. The senior BJP leader alleged that law and order

had deteriorated sharply under the TMC regime and claimed that women no longer felt safe in the State.

Referring to Banerjee's slogan, "Bangla Nijer Meyekei Chay", Singh said, "Even the mothers, sisters and daughters of Bengal do not feel safe today. Murders, loot and crimes are taking place openly."

He promised that a BJP Government would constitute a "Durga Squad" to deal with crimes against women.

"For atrocities against women, we will create a 'Durga Squad', and anyone who troubles women will be given strict punishment," Singh said.

The defence minister also claimed that there was an "atmosphere of fear" in the State and alleged that people were scared to openly express support for the BJP.

Modi killed women's quota, Opposition against delimitation: Kharage



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharage addressing a public meeting ahead of the Assembly elections in Cooch Behar, West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Cooch Behar (WB)

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharage on Monday claimed it was Prime Minister Narendra Modi who "killed" the Constitution amendment bill to implement women's quota in legislatures from 2029 and pointed out the Opposition was against the delimitation bill only.

Taking a jibe at the prime minister for campaigning extensively across West Bengal for the Assembly polls, he asked whether Modi wished to become the State's chief minister.

Kharage claimed that PM Modi has been travelling across Bengal for an inordinately long period, "neglecting his official work". "Does he want to become the chief minister of West Bengal or wants to remain the country's prime minister?" he asked.

Over the prime minister accusing the Congress and other Opposition parties of committing "foeticide" after the bill to implement 33 per cent women's reservation in legislatures in 2029 derailed in the Lok Sabha, Kharage said, "It is you (Modi) who killed the women's reservation bill; we fought against the Delimitation Bill and not the bill on women's quota." Addressing a poll rally in Cooch Behar, the Congress president reminded the gathering that the UPA Government in 2010 passed a Women's Reservation Bill in the Rajya Sabha. "We are always keen

to ensure the rights and welfare of women."

He also pointed out that the Congress has had women leaders like Sarojini Naidu, Indira Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi and asked whether the BJP has ever made a woman its president or elevated any of them to a high position.

Even though the Women's Reservation Bill had passed the Rajya Sabha test in 2010, the UPA failed to bring the proposed law to the Lower House of Parliament, and it lapsed.

At the rally, Kharage said, "We (Parliament) came together in 2023, and the women's quota bill was passed. But Modi slept over it for 30 months only to wake up before the West Bengal and Tamil Nadu Assembly polls."

He wondered what had stopped the BJP-led NDA Government at the Centre from bringing it into force earlier.

Kharage asserted that the BJP was trying to get the delimitation bill passed under the garb of the women's quota bill. "What has failed is the Delimitation Bill," he said.

He claimed that PM Modi wants to hold general elections early in the country by pushing forward delimitation. "You (Modi) backstab democracy and then claim to have worked for the cause of women's empowerment," Kharage said.

Modi came to power in 2014, but women had voting rights well before that, he added.

Mahayuti to launch signature drive for women's reservation: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday criticised the Opposition for blocking the women's quota Bill, alleging that their "regressive mindset" had dashed hopes of a historic moment for women's representation in India.

Addressing a press conference, Fadnavis announced that the ruling Mahayuti



alliance will now launch a massive outreach campaign to collect one crore signatures from women across the State, aiming to build a "people's mandate" and

expose the Opposition's anti-women stance.

He said that April 17 was expected to mark a watershed moment in the country's political and social journey, with the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, providing 33 per cent reservation to women in assemblies and Lok Sabha, set to be passed in Parliament.

Fadnavis accused the Opposition parties of affecting the "foeticide" of women's rights in elected bodies.

BJP does politics over bodies, neglects families: Abhishek

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Monday accused the BJP of doing politics "over bodies" and claimed that the saffron party falsely linked the TMC with the unnatural death of two BJP workers in 2018 and forgot all about them and their families later.

Addressing an election meeting in support of party candidate Santiram Mahato



in Balarampur Assembly constituency in West Bengal's Purulia, Banerjee recalled that the then BJP national president Amit Shah had visited their families and promised jobs to the

next of kin of the deceased, which had yet to happen.

"Will the Purulia BJP MP Jyotirmoy Singh Mahato and the BJP candidate from Balarampur Assembly seat explain why the next of kin of the two deceased — Dulal Kumar and Trilochan Mahato — did not get any job as promised? Will they explain why BJP leaders snapped contacts with the next of kin of the deceased after using their deaths politically?" he asked.

Pradhan slams Mamata over appeasement and corruption

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Monday strongly criticised West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Monday, alleging that the State has descended into "chaos, appeasement and corruption" under the TMC's rule.

In a social media post, Pradhan said the situation in West Bengal has deteriorat-



ed to the extent that the Trinamool Congress's (TMC) "Maa, Mati, Manush" has been reduced to a mere slogan, while public trust in governance has eroded.

Bengali diaspora backs regime change, ready to invest: BJP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The BJP on Monday claimed that the Bengali diaspora was in favour of regime change in West Bengal and expressed willingness to invest in the State.

Addressing a press conference, State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya alleged that the ruling Trinamool Congress "failed" to create an investment-friendly environment, leading to an "exodus of companies from



the State". He said Bengalis working in countries such as the US, the UK, Australia and Singapore lent support to the saffron party, asserting that

"Bengalis working overseas are connected to the State emotionally and want to contribute to its growth. Many of them are keen to bring foreign direct investment and set up new ventures," a US-based member of the organisation said.

States like Maharashtra attract billions in FDI, while West Bengal lags far behind, he alleged. "The BJP is the only investment-friendly party. There has been a flight of capital from Bengal under the TMC rule.

Beedi workers' plight ignored as West Bengal poll campaign peaks

PRADIPTA TAPADAR
■ Samserganj (WB)

As political leaders criss-cross Murshidabad promising to stop infiltration and restore names deleted during the SIR ahead of the West Bengal assembly polls, 12-year-old Ruksana Khatun sits cross-legged on the mud floor of her house in Suti, rolling tobacco into tendu leaves before leaving for school.

Beside the girl, her mother, Rahima Bibi, works at a frantic speed. A pile of nearly 600 beedis lies in a corner. They still have 400 more to make before noon. The child is not officially a worker. On paper, she is only helping her mother.

But in Murshidabad's sprawling beedi belt — stretching across Suti, Samserganj, Dhuliyan, Jangipur and Lalgola — thou-

sands of children quietly help their families meet impossible daily targets, while local contractors who control the trade also wield enormous influence over village politics.

Nearly a quarter of the country's beedi workers are concentrated in Murshidabad, where the industry forms the backbone of the local economy.

"If she doesn't help me, we cannot finish a thousand. Then they cut our payment," Rahima said. For every 1,000 beedis rolled, the family earns between ₹160 and ₹180.

Murshidabad, one of India's biggest beedi hubs, is home to nearly 25 lakh people linked to the trade. In villages around Jangipur, Lalgola, Aurangabad and Dhuliyan, almost every house doubles up as a workshop.

Women sit for hours in

dimly lit rooms with piles of tobacco around them. Children help them before and after school hours, and often instead of school.

"In Murshidabad's bidi belt, childhood ends when fingers of these minors become fast enough to roll tobacco. Many girls stop attending school after class 5 or 6. Some are married off, but many begin helping their mothers full-time," said a schoolteacher in Samserganj, requesting anonymity.

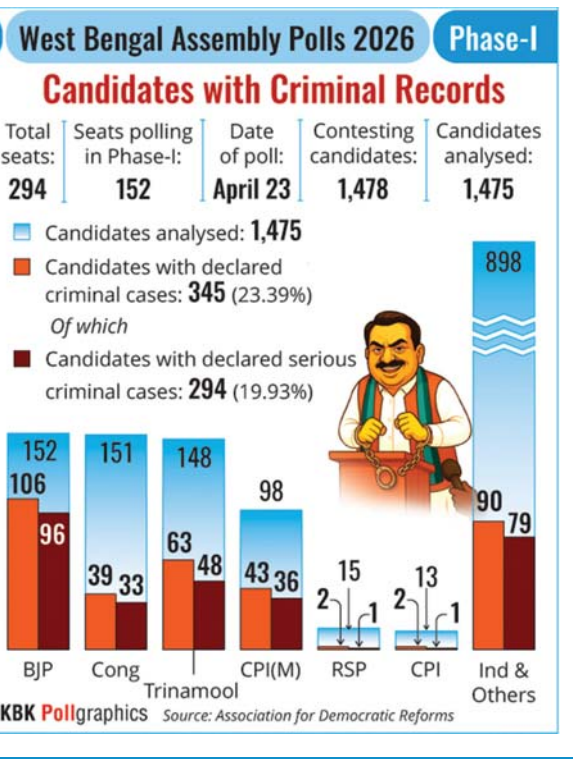
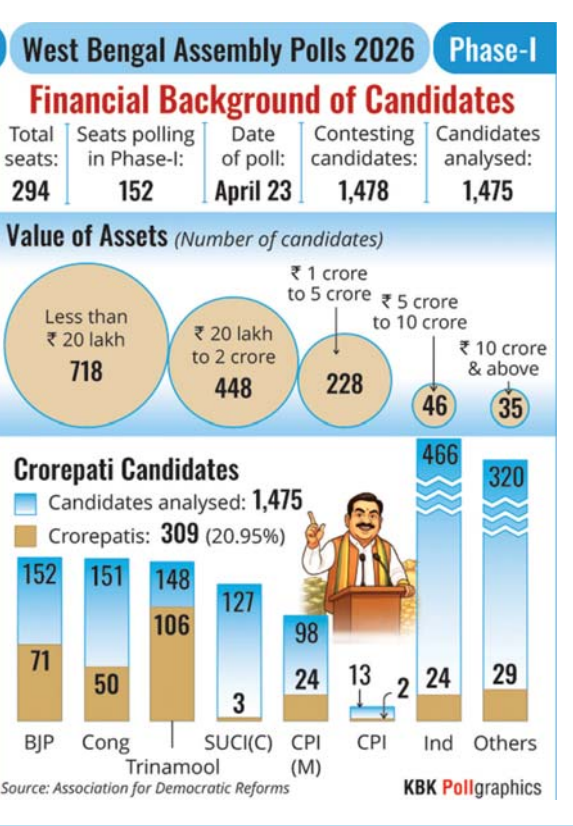
Workers said the local contractor or munshi decides everything — whose bundle will be accepted, who will get an advance before Eid, who will receive a beedi worker's card and who will get provident fund or hospital benefits. "If you anger him, work stops. And if work stops, how will we eat?" said Hasina



Bibi. Several workers accused the contractors of being closely linked to political leaders and using that influence during elections.

"During polls, they tell us which meeting to attend and which party to vote for. Nobody says it openly. But everyone understands. If you are seen with the wrong party, next week there may be no work," alleged a woman in Jalangi.

The issue briefly erupted into the open in September 2025, when around 10,000 beedi workers from villages in Lalgola block launched a protest demanding higher wages. Led largely by women, the agitation spread across Pathan Para, Bishwanathpur, Chama Para and Fakir Para. Their wages had remained stuck at ₹165 per 1,000 beedis. After days of protests, the rate was raised to ₹190.





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**Supreme Court junks PIL
seeking to declare Netaji
Bose ‘national son’**



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma accused West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee of compromising her State's future by encouraging encroachment by a "particular community" and appeasement just to stay in power. He said that his Government would continue to fight to preserve its heritage and its people, while asserting that there is no linguistic divide in Assam.

The BJP leader was reacting to Banerjee's post on X earlier in the day, slamming the Assam Government for "threatening" Bengali-speaking people and alleging that the BJP was pursuing a "divisive agenda".

Replying to Banerjee's post, Sarma wrote, "Didi, let me remind you, in Assam, we are not fighting our own people. We are fearlessly resisting the ongoing, unchecked Muslim infiltration from across the border, which has already caused an alarming demographic shift."

He maintained that in several districts, Hindus are now on the verge of becoming a minority in their own land. Sarma claimed that this is not a political narrative, but a reality, with the Supreme Court terming such infiltration as external aggression.

"And yet, when we rise to defend our land, culture and identity, you choose to politicise it," he alleged.

**Allid HC seeks Govt
response over
non-payment of
prize money
to student**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has sought response from the Uttar Pradesh Government on a student's petition seeking payment of ₹51,000 cash prize which she won during a district-level painting competition organised by the culture department nearly six months ago.

Hearing the petition filed by participant Diksha Mishra, a two-judge bench comprising Justices Saral Srivastava and Garima Prashad fixed



April 23 as the next date of hearing in the case.

Diksha, a student, moved the High Court after she did not receive the prize money despite winning first place in a district-level painting competition.

According to the petition, various competitions were organised by the culture department of the State Government under the Seva Pakhwada-2025 programme from September 17 to October 2, 2025. A district-level painting competition was also organised in Prayagraj on September 29, the plea said.

During the court proceedings, the petitioner's counsel contended that the petitioner won first place in the senior category for which a cash prize of ₹51,000 was announced for her. Despite winning the competition, the petitioner has not yet been paid the prize money, the counsel said.

The High Court in its order dated April 9 directed the additional chief standing counsel, representing the State Government, to obtain instruction (reply) from the relevant officials and submit it on the next date of hearing.



Battle for ballot: West Bengal's 2026 election landmark



**RANJIT KUMAR
SINHA**

India is currently in the midst of a major election cycle. The Election Commission of India (ECI) has scheduled general assembly elections for four states and one Union Territory, alongside several bye-elections.

Voters in these regions are electing new legislative assemblies this month. Polling was successfully completed in Assam, Kerala, and the Union Territory of Puducherry on April 9, 2026. Tamil Nadu is set to vote on April 23, 2026, while West Bengal will undergo two-phase polling on April 23 and April 29, 2026.

Prior to the commencement of the polls, the Election Commission ensured that updated electoral rolls were in place across all jurisdictions. However, the electoral roll situation in West Bengal has been a complex, high-stakes process involving intensive revision and significant judicial oversight due to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise conducted ahead of the 2026 assembly elections.

This situation has turned the state into a legal and political battleground. The Election Commission maintains that removing millions of names is a necessary "cleaning" of the records to ensure a fair election.

However, political parties on all sides have reacted with suspicion. While the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) has called the process a "conspiracy" to delete their supporters, the BJP — which generally supports the cleanup — has also protested whenever its own core voters were affected.

The tension reached a breaking point when the INDIA bloc took the unprecedented step of filing an impeachment notice against the Chief Election Commissioner. They accused the poll body of using the "cleaning" process as a cover for massive, biased voter deletions. Though the notice was eventually rejected by Parliament (both Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha) on April 6, 2026, the move highlighted a deep breakdown in trust, with political parties claiming the Commission had shifted from being a neutral referee to an active player in the election battle.

The relationship between the TMC and the Election Commission reached a historic low during an acrimonious meeting on April 8, 2026. A TMC delegation met with Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar to raise concerns over the nearly 91 lakh voter



deletions. The meeting reportedly lasted less than ten minutes and ended in chaos; TMC leaders alleged the CEC told them to "get lost," while the Commission countered by accusing the delegation of shouting and indecent behaviour.

This institutional war had already spilled into the streets in January 2026 when central agencies conducted a high-profile raid on the offices of I-PAC, the political consultancy firm advising the TMC. In a dramatic move, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee personally entered the I-PAC office during the search to protest the action.

The Enforcement Directorate subsequently moved the Supreme Court, accusing the Chief Minister and senior police officials of "illegally barging" into the site and forcibly removing key evidence, which the agency claimed was linked to a multi-crore financial irregularity case.

Driven by the scale of the crisis, the Chief Minister took the extraordinary step of appearing before the Supreme Court to defend her actions and the rights of the State's voters. Standing before the Bench, she framed the entire situation — from the agency raids to the mass voter deletions — as a coordinated attack on the federal structure, famously questioning whether central agencies had become tools to undermine a State's democratic mandate.

These escalating confrontations — from the raids on political offices to the Chief Minister's rare personal appearance in the apex court — created an atmosphere of total distrust. This

friction culminated in the explosive meeting on April 8, where the animosity between the State's leadership and the Election Commission finally reached a point of no return.

However, beneath this high-level political warfare lay the core of the crisis: the millions of ordinary voters whose names had vanished from the rolls. What was supposed to be a simple update of the voter lists had turned into a historic catastrophe. With nearly 12 per cent (according to official sources) of the State's voters removed, the situation became too massive for the Election Commission to handle alone, forcing the courts to step in and protect the people's right to vote.

To prevent a total administrative collapse, the Supreme Court assumed the role of an ultimate referee, ensuring the technicalities of the SIR did not override the fundamental right to vote. The Court ordered that any citizen who was wrongly removed must be given a final chance to get back on the list before they lose their franchise.

As of mid-March 2026, officially, there are approximately 6.44 crore registered voters in the state. The SIR resulted in a large volume of claims and objections, with over 60 lakh cases requiring adjudication. To ensure transparency, this process was overseen by judicial officers from West Bengal, Jharkhand, and Odisha.

Following legal challenges regarding the deletion of names, the Supreme Court intervened under Article 142 of the Constitution. The ECI has been directed to issue supplementary

revised electoral rolls to incorporate the names of voters whose appeals are cleared by Appellate Tribunals before the polls.

The specific deadlines for this are: For Phase 1 (April 23): Voters whose appeals are allowed by April 21, 2026. For Phase 2 (April 29): Voters whose appeals are allowed by April 27, 2026.

The Supreme Court has clarified that the mere pendency of an appeal does not grant a person the right to vote; a voter is only eligible if the Appellate Tribunal has officially allowed their appeal and their name is included in the supplementary roll by the specified cut-off date. Currently, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) are delivering Voter Information Slips door-to-door to help enrolled electors locate their polling stations.

While the focus has now shifted to high-voltage campaigning, this West Bengal election will be remembered for the intense battle fought in judicial fora, public spaces, and across administrative frontlines.

The battle reached a peak when the TMC moved the Calcutta High Court to challenge the ECI's decision to transfer senior bureaucrats, creating a unique scenario where the state executive and the constitutional poll body were in direct legal conflict.

In the Supreme Court, Justice Joymalya Bagchi famously remarked that the ordinary voter was being "sandwiched between two constitutional authorities." The Apex Court raised alarms over the sheer speed of the SIR process, noting that judicial officers were adjudicating over 1,000 cases a day. This led to the landmark use of Article 142 to ensure the "sentimental" right to vote was not lost to administrative haste. For the first time, a "multi-tier scrutiny system" involving 19 tribunals and over 700 judicial officers became the final gatekeepers of the electorate.

The "slugfest" even spilled into the streets. On April 1, 2026, in Malda's Kaliachak, seven judicial officers were held hostage for nine hours by a mob, an incident the Supreme Court termed a "calculated attempt" to derail the election. On the campaign trail, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee linked the deletions to a "hidden NRC agenda," while the BJP and ECI framed the 90.66 lakh deletions as a long-overdue "purification" of the rolls.

Ultimately, this election has set a historic precedent where the judiciary effectively became a co-manager of the election. The "battle" of 2026 will be recorded as the moment when the technical integrity of the voter list became as contested and "high-voltage" as the political rallies themselves.

Writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

SC dismisses Umar Khalid's plea seeking review of verdict denying him bail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has dismissed activist Umar Khalid's plea seeking a review of a verdict denying him bail, while observing that there are reasonable grounds to believe the allegations levelled against him in connection with a conspiracy behind the 2020 Delhi riots.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and NV Anjaria also rejected the plea seeking an oral hearing of the review petition.

"Having gone through the review petition and also the documents enclosed, we do not find



any good ground and reason to review the judgment dated January 5, 2026.

Accordingly, the review petition is dismissed," the bench said in its April 16 order. According to the Supreme Court's rules, review petitions are considered by judges who delivered a judgment or passed an order in chambers to remedy an apparent error or a resultant grave injustice that was a consequence of a decision of the apex court.

Parties seeking a review can request judges for an open-court hearing to

rectify the grave injustice caused due to the decision under review.

On January 5, besides Khalid, the top court refused bail to Sharjeel Imam but granted it to five others, saying all the accused did not stand on the same footing.

The February 2020 riots in northeast Delhi broke out during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) and the National Register of Citizens (NRC), leaving 53 people dead and more than 700 injured.

The Delhi Police had arrested a total of 18 people in the conspiracy case. Of them, 11 have got bail so far.

We can't have fishing inquiry, says SC on West Bengal voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

"We can't have a fishing inquiry," the Supreme Court said on Monday after it was mentioned that five to seven lakhs voters have allegedly been added by the Election Commission (EC) in poll-bound West Bengal.

Senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy mentioned the matter before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi.

Referring to media reports, Guruswamy said there was an addition of nearly five to seven lakh voters in West Bengal using Form 6.

Form 6 is for inclusion of name in the electoral roll for



a first-time voter or on shifting from one constituency to another.

Guruswamy said the addition of voters through Form 6 is not permissible after the cut-off date and that adding so many voters would have an impact on the upcoming Assembly election in the state.

"You challenge it, we will see," the CJI said.

Guruswamy said they do not have enough information and the final electoral roll is yet to be published.

"We can't have a fishing inquiry," the CJI observed, adding, "We will not entertain like this."

Shocking that well-educated people getting duped in digital arrest cases: CJI Surya Kant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday said it was shocking that well-educated people were getting duped in cases of digital arrests.

The CJI, who was heading a bench which also comprised Justice Joymalya Bagchi, flagged the recent case of an old woman who was duped of her entire retirement benefits in one of such cases.

The observations came from the CJI after Attorney General R Venkataramani mentioned the

suo motu case concerning victims of digital arrest before the bench.

"Meeting have taken place. We are moving very fast," the top law officer said, while requesting the bench to take up the suo motu case for hearing on May 12.

The CJI then referred to the case of the elderly woman whom he knows in his official capacity.

"Unfortunately, her entire retiral benefit has been duped," the CJI said.

One of the advocates told the bench that it was most unfortunate that despite the apex court hearing a suo motu case regarding digital arrest, such incidents



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

were continuously coming to light.

"It is shocking that well-educated people are getting duped like

this," the CJI observed. The bench said it would list the matter for hearing on May 12.

Digital arrest is a growing form of cybercrime in which fraudsters pose as law enforcement officers, court officials or personnel from Government agencies to intimidate victims through audio and video calls. They hold the victims hostage and put pressure on them to pay money.

On February 9, the top court described the siphoning of more than ₹54,000 crore by digital frauds as absolute "robbery or dacoity" and asked the Centre to draft a standard operating procedure (SoP) in consultation with stakeholders like the RBI, banks and the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to deal with such cases.

The apex court had expressed grave concern over the "menace" of digital arrest scams and said banks must play a proactive role in preventing cyber-enabled fraud.

It had directed the CBI to identify digital arrest cases and asked the Gujarat and Delhi Governments to accord sanction to the federal probe agency to proceed with the investigations in identified cases. It had also asked the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the

DoT, and others to jointly hold a meeting to come up with a framework for providing compensation in digital arrest cases.

The attorney general had informed the bench that the RBI has drafted an SoP for banks to deal with such cases and it, among other things, prescribes action by the banks where temporary debit holds can be placed to prevent cyber-enabled frauds.

Issuing a slew of directions, the top court had asked the Ministry of Home Affairs to formally adopt the RBI's SoP and issue directions for its implementation across the country.

Decide by May 4 on Padma Vibhushan to Olympian Jadhav: HC to Centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has directed the Union Government to decide by May 4 on conferment of the Padma Vibhushan award posthumously to wrestler Khashaba Dadasaheb Jadhav, India's first individual Olympic medallist.

Justices Madhav Jamdar and Pravin Patil of the HC's Kolhapur bench, in the order on April 15, said it is not disputed that Jadhav, a wrestler hailing from Maharashtra, was India's first individual Olympic medallist. The court



Khashaba Dadasaheb Jadhav

was hearing a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) filed by the 'Kustaveer Khashaba Jadhav Foundation', founded by his son Ranjeet Jadhav.

The PIL sought a direction to the Ministry of Home Affairs (Padma Awards Cell) to consider and decide afresh their

representation for posthumous conferment of Padma Vibhushan, India's second-highest civilian award, to Khashaba Dadasaheb Jadhav.

"The Union of India is directed to take an appropriate decision on or before May 4," the HC said, posting the matter for further hearing on May 5. The state Government, if required, shall comply with any requirements expeditiously, the court said.

Khashaba Jadhav, who passed away in 1984, had won the bronze medal in the Helsinki Olympic Games held in 1952.

Thane court acquits woman in child trafficking and prostitution case, cites lack of evidence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court has acquitted a 26-year-old woman charged with child trafficking and running a prostitution racket, observing that the prosecution failed to prove she had called the alleged victims for the flesh trade.

Special Judge (for POCSO Act cases) SP Agarwal, in the order on April 17, also said the prosecution could not prove the allegations of a decoy trap and the minor status of one of the alleged victims.

According to the prosecution, the Nayanagar police laid a trap near Mira Road station in Thane district on April 8, 2021, following "secret information"



that a woman was supplying females for prostitution. A decoy customer was used to fix a deal, following which the accused was arrested, and three "victims", including a 17-year-old girl, were rescued, the prosecution said. The accused was charged with trafficking

and other offences under the Indian Penal Code, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, and the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act.

The court, however, found loopholes in the police version. While the police claimed a call was made to the accused on a speakerphone to arrange the transaction, no recording or electronic evidence of the conversation was produced.

"The prosecution has not produced any documentary or electronic evidence proving such a phone call between the bogus customer and the accused... It was possible for the prosecution to give electronic evidence from both mobiles, but the prosecution has failed to do so," it said.



Editor's
TAKE

India braces for a below-average monsoon

El Niño is likely to result in a poor monsoon, which could trigger a ripple effect – from farm distress to food inflation, testing both policy preparedness and rural resilience

The past few years have been good for Indian agriculture; a normal monsoon and favourable weather conditions have given the agriculture sector the respite it needed. However, the chances of a good monsoon this year are bleak. Thanks to El Niño, India is likely to experience a below-average monsoon. While official projections suggest rainfall at around 92 per cent of the long-period average, this may not look like a big drop, but in practice, even a marginal shortfall can translate into severe distress when rains are erratic, delayed, or unevenly distributed. Indian agriculture is monsoon-fed, as nearly 61 per cent of farmers depend on rain-fed agriculture.

A weak monsoon is not only an economic dampener but also a social stress test. Moreover, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast comes at a time when unseasonal rains and hailstorms have already damaged Rabi crops, causing farmer distress. A weak Kharif season would compound these losses and make things unbearable for marginal farmers. Besides, global disruptions, including geopolitical tensions, have driven up fuel costs and caused a scarcity of fertilisers, pushing their prices up. Higher input costs, combined with lower yields, create conditions of inflation across the economy.

Farm distress does not remain confined to rural India; its implications extend far beyond. A poor monsoon affects rural demand, shrinks consumption, and causes fiscal strain on the government to subsidise the extra burden. It also impacts food security. The situation could be bad if key crops like rice, pulses, and oilseeds underperform. In that scenario the government would be forced to import them to keep prices in check, leading to a drain on foreign reserves. A failed monsoon is not an abstract risk for a large number of marginal farmers but a direct threat to livelihood and survival. The government, therefore, would do well to anticipate the situation and come up with a swift policy response to mitigate it.

In the long run, water management must take centre stage but this point, the government should urgently assess reservoir levels, repair canal systems, and prioritise water conservation through local structures such as ponds and check dams. MGNREGA can be crucial in building and restoring these assets, enhancing groundwater recharge and improving resilience at the village level. It would also put income in the hands of rural households. Besides, crop planning needs recalibration. Farmers should be incentivised to shift towards millets, pulses, and oilseeds-crops that are more resilient to water stress and increasingly aligned with nutritional and environmental goals.

Diversification through multi-cropping can act as a natural hedge against climatic uncertainty. A weak monsoon need not become a full-blown agrarian crisis if met with timely intervention and adaptive policy. The challenge is as much about governance as it is about rainfall. Preparing for the worst, while hoping for the best, remains India's most prudent course of action.



BHOPINDER SINGH

Last year, the United States Department of State had released a contested post on the social media of President Donald Trump, claiming that he had ended 7 wars in 7 months. The list had included the wars in Rwanda-Congo, Kosovo-Serbia, Egypt-Ethiopia, India-Pakistan, etc. They later issued a dramatically revised list of 8 wars in 8 months to include what they claimed was the end of the Israel-Hamas war (it is still on). Recently, Trump continued his unsubstantiated claims by announcing that he had previously solved 9 wars (he did not clarify which 9th war) across the world, and now had just ended the Israel-Lebanon war as his 10th peace deal.

Not known for his sense of history, facts, or even nuance in what he keeps claiming, the historically wounded and deeply fractured land of Lebanon becomes the latest “trophy” in Trump’s make-believe accomplishments. Besides the fact that Delhi has explicitly denied any hand of the United States of America in ending the Indo-Pak war, Serbia has clarified that it had no intention of going to war with Kosovo, and meanwhile the violence in Congo and the Israeli war with Hamas continues unabated. Going by the credibility of Trump’s claims, the missing 9th war that he is supposed to have ended could only be speculated to be the US-Israeli war on Iran, but that too is far from over.

So far, the invading Israeli military has killed more than 2,100 people in Lebanon, including nearly 200 children, and displaced over 1.3 million people (one-fifth of the country’s population). This Israeli invasion was in reaction to the firing of rockets at a military site (importantly, not on a civilian area) in the Israeli city of Haifa by Iran’s co-sectarian Hezbollah, immediately after the US-Israeli attack on Iran. Implicit in the weak Israeli argument for invading Lebanon by the Benjamin Netanyahu dispensation is the untenable logic that while it can attack a sovereign like Iran, it cannot allow any force (read, Hezbollah) to attack Israel in the name of standing up for Iranians. The Hezbollah rocket attack had led to two Israeli deaths, and the subsequent Israeli reprisals were reminiscent of the gross disproportionality à la Gaza Strip (where 70,000 Palestinians have been killed), with the same flattening of townships and razing of villages on the Lebanese side. As always, Trump has chosen to remain selectively mealy-mouthed about Israeli



AS A CHRISTIAN LEADER, AOUN HAS VERY LIMITED SAY IN THE AFFAIRS OF SHIITE HEZBOLLAH, AND THEREFORE ANY TALKS OF PEACE WITH THE LEBANESE GOVERNMENT ARE NOT THE SAME AS TALKS WITH HEZBOLLAH DIRECTLY

The writer, a military veteran, is a former Lt Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Puducherry

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The Pioneer

excesses on the Lebanese front, just as he chose to look away whilst Gaza Strip was reduced to rubble, with utter impunity and immunity.

Trump may never know that the Lebanese war with Israel predates Hezbollah. Beirut had joined Arab states in opposing the creation of Israel in 1948. The Israel-Lebanon border has never really been peaceful, with earlier Israeli invasions of Lebanon (1978 and 1982) setting the stage for the creation of Hezbollah. Today, with Iran busy warding off the challenge from American attacks, Israel realises that Hezbollah is essentially without the usual Iranian support, and hence the opportunity to push on, whatever the human consequences. This is despite the fact that Pakistani PM Shehbaz Sharif had clarified that Lebanon was part of the ceasefire and any strikes from Israel would be a violation. Israel did invade Lebanon nonetheless, and the seemingly hapless Trump administration was left meekly stating that it was a “legitimate misunderstanding”, thereby giving the Israelis a clean chit yet again. American allies in the European Union have openly leaned in favour of Lebanon by calling upon “all sides to implement the ceasefire, including in Lebanon”. Like the unheeded warning in Gaza Strip earlier, the World Food Programme has warned of a similar food insecurity crisis in Lebanon, but the Trump-Netanyahu duo remain unrepentant and unconcerned.

There are good political reasons for Netanyahu to keep the pot boiling with

Hezbollah in order to retain a state of emergency, which distracts from his unpopularity on the domestic front and serious charges against him personally. He instinctively favours brute force over diplomacy, and in Hezbollah he has a convenient handle. The history of invasions of Lebanon (including 2006) is instructive: angst against Israel can never be clamped down by force. The current invasion, if not pulled back by the Israeli Defense Forces (IDF), will lead to an even bloodier and existential war for survival. Hezbollah will go flat-out to counter the occupation in its own limited way, and perhaps that bloodshed is exactly what Netanyahu seeks to prolong his own relevance. Meanwhile, Donald Trump is busy singing hosannas in his own favour on account of some mythic peace that he supposedly brokered between the Israelis and Hezbollah, when Israeli soldiers continue to occupy Lebanese land. Serendipitously, Trump has a like-minded and shifty Lebanese President in Michel Aoun, who is known to shift loyalties.

As a Christian leader, Aoun has very limited say in the affairs of Shiite Hezbollah, and therefore any talks of peace with the Lebanese government are not the same as talks with Hezbollah directly. Ultimately, peace in Lebanon is dependent on how Trump ends his own ill-advised war on Iran, and the outcomes of the same will have the only tangible impact on ending the war in Lebanon. Short of that, history repeats itself, and Nero in Washington, DC dances as Lebanon burns.

PIC TALK

Tourists participate in river rafting in the Beas River near Manali in Kullu. PHOTO: PTI



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Pleasure is defined as a short-lived sensory experience requiring efforts, while comfort is a soothing state of ease and rest. Lots of people live very comfortably. Similarly, almost everyone has some pleasures like being able to eat tasty meals regularly. However, not many are either peaceful or happy in spite of living comfortably or having many pleasures of senses.

Why is it so? Seeking peace or happiness by being comfortable is not possible, because, as defined, it is only a state of ease and rest. Increasing comforts, as many do in search of peace and happiness, brings only disappointment, because being peaceful or happy requires control over the mind. And the mind is full of desires; it has many fears; it is troubled by something or other; is obsessed with many problems; etc. Similarly, people seek more pleasures of the



sensory types, and only compromise health, etc, and are a dissatisfied lot. The answer is in limiting the comforts and pleasures to what is appropriate, as instructed by Lord Krishna in the Bhagavad-Gita. They should be 'yukta' (just right) only. For example, I eat only 'sattvik' (in goodness) meals, and keep good health. I also limit my comforts to what is just right, that is comfortable living quarters, etc. But the most important need is to have a peaceful mind. Again, Lord Krishna has instructed in great detail how to become peaceful and, yes, happy also.

There are many requirements, as there must be for such an important objective of peace and happiness. We have to start with the right choices of the modes we associate with. Goodness, which is to choose what is good, is required.

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SINCE 1865

gets started, because God begins to help. Then, pleasures and comforts contribute to well-being and great satisfaction.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

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RECURRING LAPSES TURN LIVELIHOODS INTO FATAL FIRECRACKER TRAPS

Apropos the report ‘Explosion in firecracker unit in Tamil Nadu kills 18, several critical’ (April 20), the recurring tragedy of blasts in Virudhunagar once again exposes a grim and unacceptable reality-our failure to learn from past disasters.

The devastating explosion at Kattannarpatti, claiming 23 lives, comes barely days after another fatal incident in the same district. Yet, despite repeated warnings, inquiries, and assurances, little appears to have changed on the ground. How many more lives must be lost before safety norms are enforced with sincerity rather than merely on paper?

Authorities often cite licences issued by bodies such as the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation, but such certifications lose meaning when

compliance is poorly monitored. Overcrowded units, unsafe handling of volatile materials, and inadequate supervision continue to plague the industry.

Expressions of grief by leaders, including Droupadi Murmu, Narendra Modi, and MK Stalin, while important, cannot substitute for decisive preventive action.

What is urgently needed is a systemic overhaul-strict audits, real-time inspections, accountability for violations, and swift prosecution of negligent owners. Without this, such tragedies will continue to repeat, turning livelihoods into death traps.

The pattern is painfully clear. The response, unfortunately, remains unchanged.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Safety failures continue unchecked

The recent explosion at a fireworks unit in Virudhunagar district once again exposes a tragic and recurring pattern. Since 2022, the district has witnessed over 130 deaths in firecracker-related accidents. Each incident is followed by compensation announcements and promises of stricter enforcement, yet little changes on the ground.

This is not merely an industrial hazard but a clear governance failure. Unauthorised units, violations of safety norms, and excessive workforce deployment point to systemic regulatory lapses. The fact that hazardous activities continued even on a day when operations were officially prohibited reflects the absence of effective oversight. There is an urgent need for independent safety audits conducted by technical experts, strict enforcement of liability, and criminal accountability for violations. Officials who fail in their duty must also be held responsible.

Equally important is worker welfare. Most labourers lack formal contracts, insurance, and basic protection. Bringing them under labour laws, ensuring employer-funded insurance, and creating a welfare fund are necessary steps. The industry can survive only if human lives are prioritised over negligence.

A MYILSAMI | COIMBATORE

Reform stalled by political tactics

The government introduced three Bills in Parliament on April 16 in a special session to expand the Lok Sabha, enable delimitation based on the 2011 Census, and reserve seats for women. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 proposed 33 per cent reservation, while the Delimitation Bill empowered a commission to determine such seats. However, the Bills failed to pass. Earlier, Parliament had unanimously enacted the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, reserving one-third of seats for women. Yet, its implementation was made conditional upon delimitation after a fresh Census, delaying its execution. Despite strong public demand ahead of the 2024 elections, no progress was made.

With both the earlier Act stalled and the recent Bills defeated, women’s reservation remains uncertain. The ruling party is seen as having positioned itself advantageously regardless of the outcome, while the opposition faces criticism for blocking reform. However, the demand for reservation will only intensify, especially within the current strength of 545 Lok Sabha seats.

A credible, time-bound roadmap is essential to ensure that women’s political representation is not indefinitely postponed.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KOZHIKODE

Women’s Bill fails amid distrust

The editorial, “Women’s Bill fails: A reform lost in distrust” (April 20, 2026), rightly highlights how the Women’s Reservation Bill collapsed under avoidable mistrust. Linking it with Lok Sabha expansion and delimitation based on the 2011 Census triggered concerns, particularly among southern states that fear losing representation despite leading in population control. These anxieties deserve engagement, not dismissal.

The government’s decision to introduce such sweeping changes in a special session, without clear rules on seat allocation, fuelled suspicion. The absence of transparency created the impression of political manoeuvring rather than fair reform.

The opposition, too, must accept responsibility. Delays and tactical resistance undermined a long-pending reform. While quotas improve representation, they alone cannot dismantle entrenched patriarchy; broader structural change is essential.

The way forward is clear: separate reservation from delimitation, guarantee federal safeguards, and rebuild trust through bipartisan cooperation. India needs equitable representation, but such reform must rest on credibility, not coercion.

SK PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

PRAHAAR: A comprehensive national counter-terror policy

The PRAHAAR doctrine marks a significant shift — not a routine policy announcement, but a conscious reorientation of India’s counter-terrorism strategy, moving beyond reactive measures towards anticipation, and from mere containment to proactive pre-emption



ASHOK KUMAR

India has, for decades, confronted terrorism in both its overt and covert manifestations. This is not a new battle for us; however, its character today is far more complex, diffuse, and insidious than ever before. What was once largely confined to border regions and conventional methods has now evolved into a technologically driven, globally networked threat. Terrorist actors no longer rely solely on weapons and explosives; they operate through digital ecosystems, clandestine financial channels, and sustained ideological propaganda. Any response that fails to recognise this transformation is bound to be inadequate.

It is in this context that the Ministry of Home Affairs’ introduction of PRAHAAR must be viewed as a decisive and timely intervention. This is not merely another policy initiative; it represents a fundamental shift in strategic thinking. The emphasis is no longer on post-incident response, but on anticipatory action-identifying threats at inception and neutralising them before they manifest. This, by any standard, is the hallmark of a mature and capable security architecture. India’s counter-terrorism journey has yielded valuable lessons. The 2017 anti-Naxal doctrine of the Ministry of Home Affairs, SAMADHAN, stands as a notable example of how clarity of intent, strategic coherence, inter-agency coordination, and robust intelligence can significantly curb insurgent activity. It demonstrated that well-articulated policy, backed by strong political will and effective execution, delivers tangible results on the ground.

However, the present challenge extends well beyond earlier paradigms. Terrorism, often externally sponsored, has fragmented into smaller, decentralised modules-lone actors, micro-cells, and digitally connected networks. It now operates simultaneously across physical, virtual, and financial domains. Fragmented or siloed responses will not suffice against such a multidimensional threat.

PRAHAAR is designed precisely to address this complexity. It integrates technology, intelligence, law enforcement, financial oversight, and international cooperation into a unified framework. Its objective is clear and uncompromising: detect threats early, prevent their escalation, and, where necessary, respond with speed and severity.

The most defining feature of this doctrine is its holistic approach. It recognises that terrorism is not merely an act of violence, but a manifestation of ideology, organisation, and deliberate strategy. Consequently, the response too must be comprehensive and multi-layered.

PRAHAAR rests on seven core pillars:

- Prevention: Intelligence-led, proactive measures to neutralise threats at inception
- Response: Swift, coordinated action in the event of an incident
- Analysis: Data-driven decision-making based on precise intelligence assessment
- Human Rights Compliance: Ensuring all actions remain within the constitutional and legal framework
- Action against Terror Financing: Systematic dismantling of financial support networks
- Awareness and De-radicalisation: Countering extremist narratives through societal engagement
- Resilience and Recovery: Rapid restoration of normalcy post-incident

Together, these pillars create a strategy that not only counters terrorism effectively but also strengthens societal resilience.

Contemporary terrorist groups are increasingly leveraging advanced technologies-encrypted communications, the dark web, drones, and cryptocurrencies-to evade detection. Traditional policing methods, in isolation, are no longer sufficient. PRAHAAR addresses this gap by embedding cyber capabilities, advanced surveillance technologies, and financial intelligence into its operational framework.

India’s posture against terrorism has, in recent years, become markedly more assertive. The Balakot air strike, Operation Sindoor, and sustained operations against domestic terror networks underscore a clear shift: India is no longer confined to a defensive stance. The capability and resolve to undertake pre-emptive and decisive action are now firmly established.



PRAHAAR institutionalises this approach. It ensures that such actions are not ad hoc or situational, but guided by a structured and consistent policy framework.

At the heart of this doctrine lies the Prevention pillar. Its strategic focus is unambiguous: identify and neutralise threats at the earliest stage. This necessitates strengthening intelligence-led policing, ensuring real-time information sharing among agencies, dismantling recruitment pipelines, and disrupting support infrastructures.

Monitoring digital radicalisation and exerting stringent control over terror financing are integral to this effort. Prevention, however, has now transcended conventional boundaries. It is increasingly technology-driven. Artificial intelligence enables predictive threat analysis; big data analytics helps identify suspicious patterns; drone surveillance enhances border security; and cyber forensics allows tracking of encrypted communications. In an era where terrorism is rapidly digitising, expanding cyber capabilities is no longer optional-it is imperative.

The proliferation of deepfakes, fabricated digital content, and AI-driven misinformation has further complicated the threat landscape. Digital vigilance must, therefore, be accorded the highest priority to detect and neutralise risks at their nascent stage. At the same time, it must be recognised that radicalisation cannot be countered by security forces alone. It demands active participation from society-educators, community leaders, religious institutions, and civil organisations.

The Response pillar ensures swift and coordinated action during crises. Local police serve as the first responders, supported by specialised agencies such as the National Security Guard and the National Investigation Agency. This multi-tiered mechanism not only ensures immediate containment but also strengthens investigation and prosecution.

PRAHAAR also enhances national preparedness. Investments in modern equipment, drone surveillance, AI-enabled command systems, specialised training, cyber capabilities, and standardised operational procedures are aimed at ensuring seamless coordination between states and agencies. Strengthening international cooperation is equally critical, given the transnational nature of contemporary terrorism.

Equally important is the role of society. Radicalisation cannot be countered through force alone; it requires awareness, engagement, and credible counter-narratives. Preventing youth from straying into extremist pathways is as vital as any enforcement action. Countering adversarial propaganda-particularly in the digital domain-must be pursued with clarity and consistency.

Effective prevention demands a robust cyber-intelligence architecture, decisive control over AI-driven misinformation, and deep penetration into terror networks. Effective response, on the other hand, requires seamless coordination among police, intelligence agencies, armed forces, and civil administration.

Ultimately, no policy succeeds on intent alone. Its effectiveness depends on sustained effort, clarity of leadership, and disciplined execution.

Conclusion

PRAHAAR marks a significant evolution in India’s counter-terrorism strategy. Its architecture is sound, and the intent of the government is clear. However, its success will rest squarely on implementation. Policy formulation is only the first step; translating it into measurable outcomes on the ground is the real test. Alongside governmental efforts, citizens too must assume an active role in this collective endeavour. The Ministry of Home Affairs has, through PRAHAAR, delivered a long-awaited and necessary doctrine-one that has the potential to significantly strengthen India’s national security framework and decisively counter the menace of terrorism.



EFFECTIVE PREVENTION DEMANDS A ROBUST CYBER-INTELLIGENCE ARCHITECTURE, DECISIVE CONTROL OVER AI-DRIVEN MISINFORMATION, AND DEEP PENETRATION INTO TERROR NETWORKS

The writer is an IITian-turned cop who retired as Director General of Police, Uttarakhand. He is presently serving as the Vice-Chancellor of the Sports University of Haryana

ashok_kumar_ips89

@AshokKumar_IPS

ashok-kumar-ips

Dope vs Pope: Power in God’s Image



NILANTHA ILANGAMUWA

Hell must be calm and beautiful, as all monsters on the planet are, performing what hell itself was meant to perform. Jimmy Kimmel got it right when he reduced the moment to a satirical shorthand: “Dope vs. Pope.” Soon after President Donald Trump posted an AI-generated image of himself in a Jesus-like role, appearing to heal a sick man-widely interpreted by critics as resembling Jeffrey Epstein in a hospital bed, the reaction did not merely ripple through Washington or the Vatican, but spread across the wider political orbit that surrounds him. The image-later deleted from his social media account-showed Trump in a white robe, his hand glowing as it touched the forehead of a patient, framed by a staged backdrop of the American flag, the Statue of Liberty, fighter jets, an eagle, a praying nurse, and a uniformed soldier. Across political lines, it was read as self-exaltation, a deliberate borrowing of sacred imagery for personal elevation. The episode was not an ordinary online controversy. It worked as a break in meaning: political identity, religious symbolism, and artificial intelligence fused into a single manufactured claim of authority. To treat it as a passing provocation would miss the point. Political history is full of rulers who have clashed with religious power or bent it to their own needs. From emperors bargaining with the papacy to modern regimes trying to absorb religious institutions into the state machine, the Church has long stood as a rival source of legitimacy.

In the twentieth century, ideological systems often defined themselves against religious authority. Adolf Hitler, in the private fragments recorded in Table Talk, described Christianity as hostile to the logic of struggle and survival, treating it as a moral system that weakened his worldview. Joseph Stalin reduced the Vatican to irrelevance with the blunt question: “How many divisions has the Pope?” Benito Mussolini treated religion as something to be contained and managed under state supremacy. Across these systems, the Church was either dismissed, controlled, or stripped of independent authority.

Authority is no longer carried only through law, policy, or institutional negotiation. It is constructed through images that circulate quickly and provoke reaction. Political power now often appears first as visual impact before it becomes anything else. This matters because earlier conflicts between Church and state were built on jurisdiction, belief, and sovereignty. Today, the conflict is not structured in that way. The AI image of Trump as a Christ-like healer is not an argument. It is an act of symbolic appropriation that unsettles the boundary between sacred representation and political display. Religious imagery becomes material for personal projection, while political leadership borrows the visual language once reserved for spiritual authority.

Against this backdrop, Pope Leo XIV presents a sharply different form of authority. His statements repeatedly insist that the Church does not function as a party-political actor, yet he refuses silence on moral questions. He has stated that he does not intend to enter partisan politics, but also insists he will speak where he believes Gospel principles are at stake. In one of his most quoted interventions, he directly counters contemporary political reasoning by stating that “JD Vance is wrong; Jesus does not ask us to rank our love for others,” rejecting any attempt to organise Christian ethics into hierarchies of human value. This position avoids easy classification. It is neither aligned with ideological conservatism nor with progressive political agendas. Instead, it rests on a claim that moral truth cannot be reduced to political identity. Ethical teaching, in this view, is not meant to serve a faction, nor disappear into neutrality. It remains active in public life without becoming owned by it. He is equally direct about internal weaknesses within the Church. His criticism of “indoctrination” is not decorative language. It is a warning that religious teaching loses integrity when it suppresses independent moral judgement. He argues that indoctrination damages conscience by removing the possibility of genuine reflection, even when that reflection leads to disagreement. This places him in the middle of ongoing internal disputes over doctrine, authority, and pastoral direction. It is within this context that his African apostolic journey gains weight. Covering roughly 18,000 kilometres across several countries, and including a visit to the Great Mosque of Algiers, the journey is more than ceremonial travel. It signals a shift in where Catholic growth and influence now sit. Africa is no longer peripheral to global Christianity; it is one of its strongest centres. Beginning a major journey there is a deliberate acknowledgment of that reality.

The contrast with Trump is direct. The papal journey is physical, slow, and rooted in encounter. It depends on presence, dialogue, and institutional continuity. Trump’s communication style operates in a different register entirely. It is instant, visual, and designed for rapid circulation. One approach builds meaning through continuity in time; the other creates impact through immediate display and repetition. One draws authority from tradition; the other reshapes tradition into material for ongoing public reaction.

This difference also reflects a wider shift in how authority is understood. The idea of an American pope was once considered unlikely, largely because of concerns about how closely American political culture sits with global religious authority. Yet Leo XIV’s election complicates that assumption. He has been described as “the least American of Americans”, a phrase pointing to someone who carries national origin but does not appear confined by it. His Augustinian grounding, centred on shared life, unity, and moral order, frames authority as something held in common rather than performed for effect.

Trump’s use of religious imagery should not be reduced to simple disrespect. It reflects a wider condition in which institutions no longer hold exclusive control over meaning. Symbolic language now moves freely across digital platforms, detached from its original setting. Religious images can be lifted into political communication without mediation by religious authority. Despite all this, what if Trump genuinely believes he is the chosen one-the ‘son of God’-and that every action he takes is divinely instructed? Then who, in the end, is the real ‘dope’?



The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

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nilanthailangamuwa

Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam: India’s civilisational path to global peace and harmony



KUNWAR PUSHPENDRA PRATAP SINGH

In an era marked by persistent conflicts, geopolitical rivalries, climate crises, economic inequalities, and cultural tensions, the quest for global peace and harmony has become more urgent than ever before. The modern world, despite its technological advancements and interconnectedness, continues to struggle with divisions and distrust among nations and communities. In such a scenario, India’s ancient philosophical principle of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* — meaning “the world is one family” — emerges as a powerful and timeless framework for fostering global unity, peace, and cooperation.

The concept of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* originates from the Maha Upanishad, an ancient Indian text that emphasises the universality of human existence. It states that narrow-minded individuals discriminate between “mine” and “others”, while those with a noble outlook consider the entire world as one family. This profound idea reflects the inclusive and holistic worldview of Indian civilisation, which transcends boundaries of nation, religion, language,

and culture. It promotes a sense of shared responsibility and mutual respect among all human beings.

Unlike many modern political ideologies that prioritise national interest above all else, *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* advocates for a balance between self-interest and collective welfare. It calls for empathy, compassion, and cooperation as guiding principles of human interaction. In doing so, it provides a moral and ethical foundation for addressing global challenges that cannot be solved by any single nation alone.

Historically, India has embodied this principle through its commitment to peace and non-violence. The teachings of Lord Buddha and Mahavira emphasised compassion and non-harm towards all living beings. In the modern era, Mahatma Gandhi brought global attention to the power of non-violence (Ahimsa) as a tool for political and social transformation. His philosophy not only played a crucial role in India’s freedom struggle but also inspired civil rights movements across the world. Gandhi’s vision was rooted in the belief that humanity is interconnected, and that true peace can only be achieved through understanding and non-violent coexistence.

In contemporary times, the relevance of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* has only grown stronger. The challenges facing the world today-such as climate change, pandemics, terrorism, and economic instability-are inherently global in nature. They demand collective action, shared



responsibility, and a spirit of cooperation among nations. India has consistently advocated this approach on international platforms by promoting the idea of “One Earth, One Family, One Future”, which reflects the essence of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* in a modern context.

India’s actions on the global stage further reinforce its commitment to this principle. During the COVID-19 pandemic, India launched the “Vaccine Maitri” initiative, supplying vaccines to numerous countries, especially developing nations that lacked access to medical resources. This humanitarian effort demonstrated that India prioritises global well-being over narrow national interests. Similarly, India has actively participated in United Nations peacekeeping missions and has provided aid to countries affected by natural disasters, reflecting its role as a responsible and compassionate global actor.

Furthermore, *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* is not limited to diplomatic or political spheres; it also has profound implications for social and cultural interactions. In a world increasingly divided by identity politics, religious extremism, and cultural misunderstandings, this principle encourages dialogue, tolerance, and mutual respect. It reminds us that diversity is not a source of conflict, but a strength that enriches human civilisation.

Education plays a crucial role in promoting the values of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*. By instilling a sense of global citizenship and ethical responsibility in younger generations, societies can cultivate individuals who are more empathetic, inclusive, and cooperative. Cultural exchange programmes, international collaborations, and people-to-people connections can further strengthen this sense of global unity.

India’s soft power also contributes significantly to spreading this philosophy worldwide. Practices such as yoga, Ayurveda, meditation, and Indian classical arts have gained global recognition and acceptance. The celebration of International Yoga Day across countries is a testament to how India’s cultural heritage can unite people beyond geographical and ideological boundaries. These traditions not only promote physical and mental well-being but also foster a sense of inner peace and harmony, which are essential for building a peaceful world.

However, the path of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* is not without challenges. The current global order is heavily influenced by power politics, economic competition, and

strategic interests. Many nations prioritise short-term gains over long-term collective benefits, leading to conflicts and mistrust. Bridging these differences requires strong leadership, moral courage, and a willingness to embrace a broader vision of humanity.

Despite these challenges, the principle remains a viable and necessary path forward. It does not demand the erasure of national identities or interests, but rather encourages their alignment with global welfare. It calls for a shift in perspective-from competition to cooperation, from division to unity, and from self-centredness to shared responsibility.

In conclusion, *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* is not merely an ancient Indian ideal; it is a universal philosophy with profound relevance in today’s world. It offers a roadmap for building a more peaceful, just, and harmonious global society. By embracing this principle, nations can move beyond conflict and rivalry towards collaboration and mutual growth. As the world stands at a crossroads, grappling with complex challenges, India’s civilisational wisdom provides a beacon of hope — reminding us that we are all part of one global family, and that our collective future depends on our ability to live together in peace and harmony.

The writer is a Post-Doctoral Fellow (ICSSR, Ministry of Education), Department of Political Science, Faculty of Social Sciences, Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi

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TWO PATHS TO AI

For most people, the choice about an AI tool is by accident, a recommendation from a friend, a shared link, or whatever came first. But the question of which to use is crucial. Global spending on AI is projected to cross \$300 billion by 2027. Goldman Sachs estimates that AI can automate up to 25 per cent of work tasks. However, what has happened is not a single dominant model, but a split. At the centre of that split sit two of the most visible platforms: Claude and ChatGPT. From a user’s perspective, they reflect two distinct philosophies. OpenAI, which is behind ChatGPT, was founded on the idea to make AI available widely. Get it out there. Let people use it. The results will speak for themselves. ChatGPT became the fastest-growing product in history, reaching 100 million users in two months. Anthropic, which is behind Claude, was founded by former OpenAI researchers. Their principle is “responsible scaling,” or do not release something unless you are reasonably confident it will not cause harm.

The difference in personality is not accidental. ChatGPT has steadily expanded, and spans text, image generation, code assistance, file handling, and integrations across multiple tools. Claude’s emphasis is on longer context windows, document-heavy workflows, and a tone that prioritises clarity and caution. Although Claude and ChatGPT dominate conversations, this is not a two-horse race. The field has widened faster, and the new entrants are not chasing the same prize. Google’s Gemini is a quiet threat. It sits inside Gmail, Google Docs, Google Search, and Android. It is just there, open, when the user reaches for help. Grok, built by Elon Musk, is less filtered, more willing to engage with contested territory, and deliberately positioned against what its creators describe as the excessive caution of mainstream AI. Perplexity made a smarter strategic bet, and built an identity around the opposite. Meta plays a different game. Its Llama models are open-source, and Meta is not trying to win the chatbot race. It is trying to make the chatbot race irrelevant by handing the infrastructure to anyone who wants to build another infrastructure of their own.

In India, the pricing conversation is complicated. ChatGPT operates four distinct tiers. The free plan is available to anyone. ChatGPT Go was launched at Rs 399 a month. Above this sits ChatGPT Plus at ₹1,999 a month, and ChatGPT Pro at ₹19,900. Gemini offers its AI Pro plan at ₹1,950 a month, with a budget AI Plus tier available at under ₹500. Perplexity Pro lists at ₹1,999 a month, but is currently free for a year to Airtel subscribers. Grok’s SuperGrok tier comes in at ₹700 a month. Meta’s Llama, true to its open-source philosophy, costs nothing. Claude has no India-specific pricing. Claude Pro is billed in US dollars at \$20 a month, which effectively costs ₹2,200-2,400. As of writing, Claude remains the only major AI platform without rupee pricing or UPI integration. The pricing gap is not merely a commercial footnote. What is unfolding in India is less a product competition than a land grab. OpenAI chief executive Sam Altman recently suggested during his India’s visit that India could surpass the US in ChatGPT usage.

With more than 900 million internet users, mobile-first habits, and among the cheapest data costs in the world, India is the largest untapped AI market. Yet, data privacy sits at the centre of this. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act places new obligations on how data is collected, stored and processed. OpenAI nor Anthropic are not headquartered here. Both process data on servers outside India. By default, conversations with ChatGPT can be used to train OpenAI’s models unless users manually opt out, a setting deeply buried. Anthropic’s defaults are stricter. Meta’s open-source Llama models found quiet traction among developers and privacy-conscious organisations. They can be run entirely on a private server. The practical implications are already visible in how organisations are deploying these systems. A mid-sized law firm in Bengaluru uses Claude to review and summarise contracts. A digital marketing and content org in Mumbai runs ChatGPT to generate first drafts, headlines, and campaign briefs at volume. Claude is used when the task requires continuity and attention. The interaction is slower, more iterative, and focused on refining output.

In practice, users move between several. Instead of a single best tool, users are building informal stacks, choosing systems based on the nature of the task. What emerges is not a verdict but a map. ChatGPT for speed, versatility, and the widest toolkit. Claude for depth, long documents, and a more cautious disposition. Gemini for anyone inside Google’s ecosystem. Perplexity for those who need to verify than receive. Meta’s Llama for those who need control over where their data goes. In India, the choice is being made not by users but for them through telco bundles, promotional windows, and platform defaults. The models are moving faster than any comparison. What one system did better six months ago may be table stakes today. New versions arrive quarterly. Permanent capabilities evaporate within a product cycle. GPT-5’s launch is a useful reminder that more powerful does not mean useful.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | APRIL 21, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Cost of inflation on investments

If inflation returns, will retail investors earn better returns?

For most Indian retail investors, except for the damaging interlude in 2026, and possibly earlier, the past few years seemed rewarding. Portfolio values rose, equity markets delivered strong gains until 2026, and first several months in 2025, and fixed-income instruments offered stable returns. But as equities wobble, portfolios are cobbled afresh, people are doubled under the strain of uncertain interest rates, and troublesome inflation may flare up again, a deeper question emerges. How will the investors create wealth to beat inflation, or to keep up with it? It is time to calculate the costs of price rises on returns.

With the ongoing global tensions, although there are signs of an Iran-US ceasefire due to the ongoing peace talks, elevated global crude oil prices, and currency pressures, inflation is a key concern. The World Bank projected India’s retail inflation at 4.9 per cent for the current year, which is higher than the Indian central bank’s figure. Yet, both estimates agree that prices will be influenced largely by higher food and energy costs, along with the exchange rate pressures. While an inflation under five per cent does not seem unduly alarming, even moderate by the past benchmarks, the impact on returns is significant.

Like it or not, believe it or not, inflation quietly but surely erodes a household’s purchasing power, and drives down the returns on savings and investments. Despite the seemingly-positive earnings, the real gains, after adjusting for inflation, are lower than what they appear. For example, if a fixed deposit offers an annual return of 6-7 per cent, and inflation is at 4.9 per cent, the actual return is barely 1-2 per cent. Deduct the applicable taxes on the earnings, and the figure dwindles further. Nominal growth in savings is impacted by realities.

Hence, while the investors feel good about the nominal, or overall, returns, they realise that what they are left with after accounting for the price rises is minimal. Logically, the ability to spend does not improve, and even to maintain lifestyles seems tough. This gap is particularly important for retirees, and conservative investors who rely heavily on fixed-income products. Instruments such as FDs, debt funds, and small savings schemes struggle to consistently deliver inflation-beating returns. Investors struggle with budgets, and expenses. Inflation has the ability to upset the investment-savings apple cart.

Of course, we need to first figure out why inflation is on the rise, after it slumped, with food inflation in the negative (yes, prices actually came down). The current pressures are driven by a combination of global and domestic factors. Rising crude oil prices are a key contributor, especially for an import-dependent country like India. Geopolitical tensions further disrupt the global supply chains, and increase volatility in the commodity markets. At the same time, a weakened rupee makes imports more expensive, which adds to the price rises.

Equity investors may be relatively better positioned in an inflationary environment. Over the long term, equities have outpaced inflation, and delivered real positive returns. Firms often pass on the rising costs to the consumers to protect margins and earnings. But this is a tricky area. Inflation counts when equities are depressed, or extremely volatile, as is the case now. This year, the Sensex, the Bombay Stock Exchange Index, lost 7,000 points, or more than eight per cent. In addition, price rises, especially when the estimates go beyond the benchmarks set by the central bank, may lead to higher

interest rates, tighter monetary policy, and lower stock valuations.

As is the case now, the fears of inflation, coupled with the expectations of lower GDP growth can trigger market volatility. For the retail investors, this implies that while equities remain a key tool to create wealth, short-term returns are uneven. It is difficult to stay invested in such situations, despite the knowledge that the real benefits of equities lie in hanging there over longer periods rather than reacting to near-term market movements. Fixed-return instruments may gain due to the higher interest in such scenarios but, as mentioned earlier, the higher gains are immediately eroded by the

higher inflation. This explains why the focus during periods of price rises invariably falls on the debt and fixed-income investments. Traditional options such as FDs, bonds, and debt mutual funds deliver returns that are often unable to keep pace with inflation, especially after accounting for taxes. This creates a dilemma for the risk-averse conservative investors, especially the retirees. While these choices offer safety, security, and predictability, they may not help to preserve wealth over time. Those who rely solely on fixed income, and there are a lot of them despite the advice to diversify portfolios, may find that their savings are effectively losing value in real terms, even if the nominal figures are stable.

The key takeaway for the retail investors in such a scenario is to focus on real returns, and not just nominal gains. It is not an easy task, especially for those who swear by FDs, bonds, and debt funds. It is essentially to expand the portfolios, and go for a balanced mix that reflects the risk-averseness and safety issues. Equities should play a role to achieve long-term growth, while debt instruments can stay to provide stability and liquidity. Yet, the mix is tricky. Different experts, given their penchant for risks, advice differently.

For example, some contend that 50 per cent needs to be stocks, 35-40 per cent debt, and rest in gold and others. Others talk about 60-70 per cent in debt, and 20-25 per cent in equities. It is a choice that each individual needs to make. However, hybrid funds, inflation-linked strategies, and systematic investment plans (SIPs) can balance the risks and returns. It is crucial to periodically review investments, and adjust the allocations based on changing economic conditions. Hence, the 50:40 equity-debt ratio may change to 25:70, or vice versa. One cannot stick to a ratio, or depend only on fixed-income options.

Always remember, the reach of the tentacles of inflation are not always visible, but their grasp and clutches are forceful. In the current scenario, with expectations of lower growth and higher inflation over the next 1-2 years, and rising global uncertainty, the retail investors need to look beyond the headline returns, and assess whether their portfolios and investments are truly growing in real terms. The fact remains that in the end, it is not just about how much your portfolio grows but how much it actually buys, and allows to maintain lifestyles.

A Contrarian Investor

Predict elections, crude prices, war

Despite the illegality in India, prediction markets are the new craze

to democracy, via electoral shenanigans, and insider trading on classified information. The problem does not stem from the insider-trading cases like Iran and Venezuela, but invariably from thin liquidity, betting, or contract trading. “Low trading volume, and few participants mean even small trades can substantially shift prices, and manufacture the appearance of consensus, influencing political expectations rather than simply reflecting them, turning electoral ‘forecasts’ into instruments of influence rather than collective judgment,” explains the study. This is the case in normal betting, when huge flows of Indian money ruptures the existing odds, and forces the platforms to create new ones.

In the 2024 US presidential elections, a single trader reportedly bet \$25-30 million on a Donald Trump contract. In the 2025 race for the mayor in New York, “trading was concentrated among a small number of accounts, including foreign participants.” More evidence is required to prove or disprove the allegations that the “shifts in perceived viability can

increase support for frontrunners through candidate-quality interference, producing bandwagon effects in high-salience races.” While one is not sure, but knowing about lower value and volume of bets, the same may be true about the Indian elections.

Since the major financial platforms, and mainstream media display the PMs’ odds in real-time, it offers immense opportunities to speculators and manipulators to manage and massage the contracts. First, the credibility grants speculative probabilities, which is what PMs are, a veneer of respectability as objective forecasts, which they are not. Second, it allows traders to twist the odds by one-sided contracts. Third, although one does not realise, the beliefs of the traders shape the market probabilities which, in turn, influence the traders’ beliefs.

It is a never-ending cycle that takes the wagers on different trajectories. Although PMs are supposed to be more scientific, practical, and efficient compared to normal betting markets, and we are not sure about it, the former are as addictive, or pos-

sibly more addictive, than the latter. PMs exhibit similar structural and functional trends as online gaming. As per the study, “platforms deploy dark patterns (deceptive design elements), and nudges (prompts) to drive engagement, and impulsive trading.” Many platforms mirror the gambling features such as autoplay, countdown, visual feedback, leaderboards, loot-box-style token rewards, and timed prompts. These features turn forecasting into play, and “instant loss-chasing,” as users chase “fleeting sensations of foresight” rather than what they think, data and money.

However, unlike online sports betting, the PMs do not rely on the rush through rapid resolution. The latter provide unrestricted access, which facilitates distortions in behaviour. Anticipation, rather than resolution, “drives the dopamine reward loop. Hence, nearly 30 per cent of the users in PMs check hourly, and 10 per cent every minute, compared to 2.4 per cent, and 0.7 per cent, respectively, in online betting. Finally, the PM platforms create a “continuous stream of action even when primary contracts are slow-moving” to keep the users engaged. Terminological ‘washing’ is evident, forecasting, not betting.

Of course, the social harm is higher. Globally, more than 45 per cent of adults, and 18 per cent of teenagers gambled in the past year. Associated disorders are higher in the case of online gambling, up to 16 per cent. Despite the lack of studies, experts assume that the problems in PMs may be higher because of their unique features. There are the obvious economic costs, which are estimated at over 100 billion euros across the European Union, with low treatment access, and high dropout rates that range from 40 per cent to 70 per cent.

One need not forget that the business models of the gambling platforms, whether online betting or PMs, depend on the heavy users. The top fifth of the users, both in terms of volumes and values, generate more than 90 per cent of the revenues. However, such facts are hidden under the garbs of higher revenues through taxes, self-regulation measures, and the use of forecasting to replace betting and gambling. A game of chance becomes one of math, probability and, hence, skill.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

PIOTECH

From Civil Services to Global Classrooms

PRANJAL SINHA

Across classrooms and study desks around the world, students follow a familiar routine. They read chapters, attend lectures, and spend long evenings solving practice questions. Yet despite the effort, many end their study sessions with an unsettling question lingering in their minds: Did I truly understand this? Doubts often arise at the very moment learning happens, during a lecture or in the middle of a practice set. But without immediate guidance, those questions remain unanswered. Students move forward anyway, carrying small gaps in understanding that gradually widen over time. It is a quiet struggle faced by millions of learners.

This challenge did not go unnoticed. In fact, it was observed independently by three individuals whose professional journeys unfolded in entirely different spaces like public administration, global academic research and elite



Shivendu Shukla and Mridula Sinha

university education. Their shared observations eventually converged into two educational initiatives: Prepzy and Global R-Hub. One of the earliest threads of this story begins with Dr. S. Shivendu, whose career initially followed the path of public service. After graduating from the Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur and the Indian Institute of Management Ahmadabad, he joined the Indian Administrative Service in the Bihar cadre - a career widely regarded as one of the most prestigious in India.

Yet even during his years in Government, Shivendu remained deeply drawn to intellectual inquiry and the pursuit of unanswered questions. That curiosity eventually led him to pursue a PhD in economics at the University of Southern California. In 2008, he made a decision that surprised many: stepping away from the IAS to pursue a full-time academic career.

Today, he serves as a tenured professor at the University of South Florida, where his research explores the economics of emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence, blockchain, and cybersecurity. Through years of teaching university students, he began noticing a recurring problem. Students were investing immense effort in their studies but often had no clear way to assess whether their understanding was actually improving.

"You cannot fix a gap if you cannot see it," he observes.

While Shivendu was transitioning from governance to academia, another story rooted in public service was unfolding in Eastern India.

Mridula Sinha, who grew up in Ranchi, developed an early commitment to social development and education. After pursuing a Post Graduate Diploma in Rural Management, she worked in villages on initiatives aimed at empowering disadvantaged communities. Those experiences gave her a first-hand understanding of how deeply educational access and opportunity shape people's lives.

She later joined the Indian Administrative Service and went on to serve for decades in various leadership roles within Government. Among her many assignments, she held the position of Principal Secretary for Higher

Education and Technical Education in the Government of Jharkhand. Her work focused on strengthening educational institutions, expanding access, and improving the quality of higher education systems.

Alongside her administrative career, Sinha also pursued advanced academic exposure at institutions including Columbia University, Emory University, and the University of Southern California. These experiences allowed her to examine both Indian and International education systems from close quarters.

After retiring from public service, she continues to work in the development sector as a Public Policy Consultant, bringing decades of insight into education reform and governance. The third perspective came from a very different setting - a leading research university in the United States.

Arun Reddy, who grew up in Chandigarh, moved to the

The Race Beyond Chips: India's Data Opportunity

The Great AI Data Grab: Why India Must Stop Giving Its Digital Wealth Away



NISHANT SAHDEV

When Stanford University dropped its 2026 Artificial Intelligence Index Report earlier this month, the global headlines predictably obsessed over the flashy milestones. The media fixated on surging corporate investments and models outsmarting humans in math Olympiads. But buried beneath the charts detailing trillions of dollars in tech market caps was a quiet, existential warning. The most advanced computational systems on the planet are hitting a wall.

It isn't a lack of microchips, electricity, or data center capacity holding them back. It is a lack of authentic human reality.

The report highlighted a phenomenon the industry calls "peak data," warning that the global supply of high-quality, human-generated text could be entirely exhausted within the next few years.

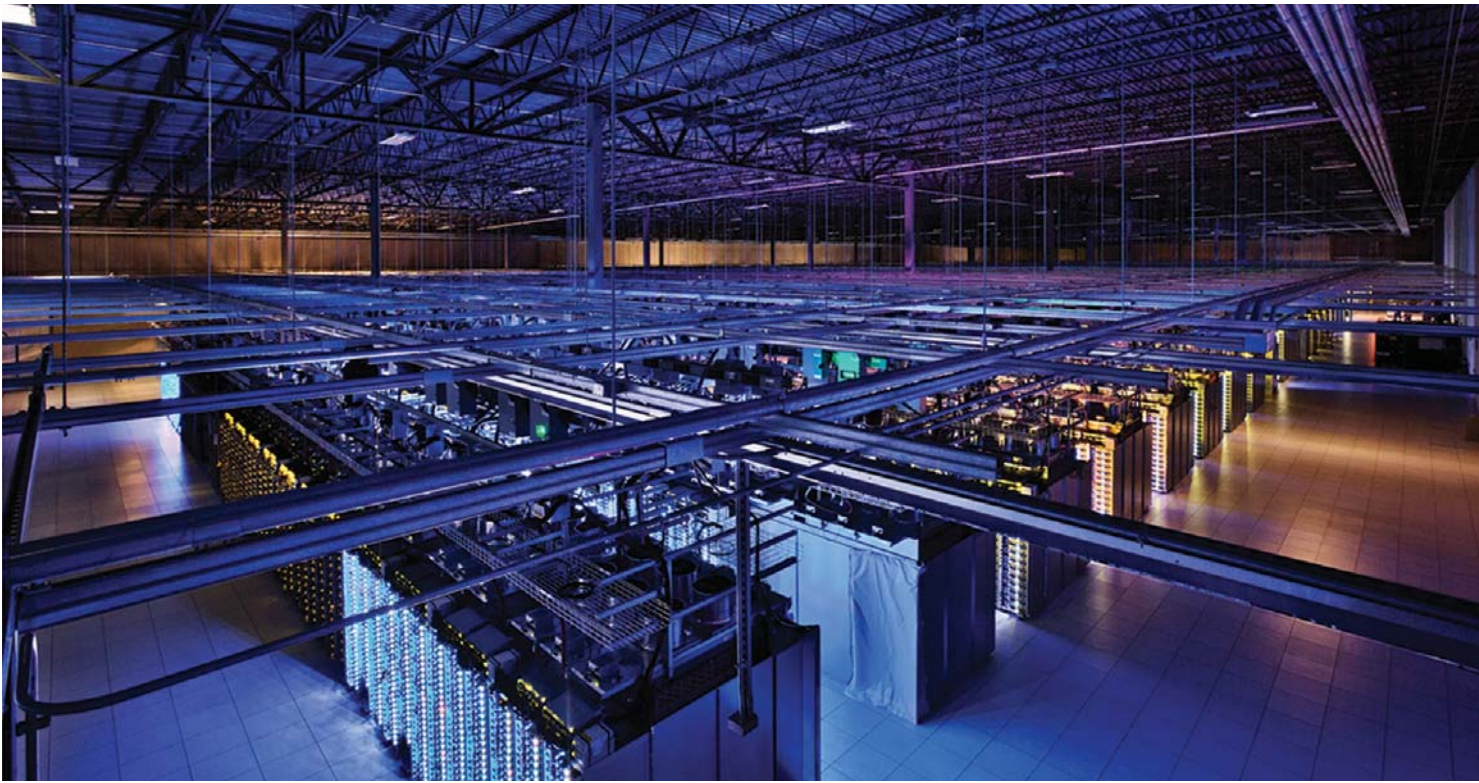
For the past decade, the AI revolution has operated essentially as a massive digital strip-mining operation. To build their neural networks, tech giants have relentlessly scraped the open internet, vacuuming up digitized books, public forums, news archives, and billions of everyday interactions. Silicon Valley treated the web as an infinite, boundless mine of cognitive wealth.

That assumption is now cracking. As researchers are discovering, the industry is scraping the digital landscape vastly faster than humanity can naturally replenish it. Investors who believed the AI boom was constrained only by how fast we could build semiconductor foundries are waking up to a much colder truth: we are literally running out of internet.

So, what is the tech industry's backup plan? Synthetic data. If they can't find enough human writing, they will simply use AI-generated content to train the next generation of AI. In narrow, highly technical fields, this can work. But you cannot mathematically manufacture the complexity of human life. When systems learn primarily from outputs produced by other systems - a closed, recursive loop - they begin to suffer from "model collapse."

It is a kind of algorithmic inbreeding. The models start repeating mistakes, losing nuance, and smoothing over the unusual, jagged edges that define real life.

Human society is messy. It is emotional, deeply multilingual, and full of brilliant contradictions. An algorithm might be able to generate a sterile, statistical summary of retail economics, but it cannot hallucinate the chaotic, lived experience of a crowded Mumbai bazaar. It cannot anticipate the complex



bargaining habits of informal traders, or track the rapid linguistic shifts of a first-generation mobile internet user in Bihar. Data isn't just cold code; it is the digital exhaust of human culture and survival. If you are trying to build consumer products for the real world, those unscripted details matter immensely.

The Leverage of Authentic Reality

This impending scarcity changes everything, and it demands an immediate strategic pivot in New

Delhi. For years, India's digital policy has been largely defensive. We have focused on protecting citizen privacy, fighting platform abuse, and throwing up localised walls to shield our population from Western tech monopolies. Those are vital protections. But defense alone is just a legal shield - it isn't an offensive economic strategy.

India holds an asset that is skyrocketing in value: one of the deepest, most complex reservoirs of real-world human data on the planet. This isn't just about having a massive population. It is a rare collision of scale, an open democracy, intense linguistic diversity, and the explosion of our Digital Public Infrastructure. With nearly 900 million internet users, regional-language adoption is rising faster than English. This isn't a settled, mature market; it is relentlessly dynamic.

Look at the sheer volume of high-fidelity reality we generate every day. The Unified Payments Interface

(UPI) completely rewired digital commerce. The Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) is digitizing the informal retail sector, while the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission is structuring health data for a vastly diverse population. When you combine that with digitized land records and urban transit networks, you get a continuously updating, high-resolution map of human life.

For global AI builders, this data is gold. Multilingual AI needs real cultural context. Diagnostic tools need diverse patient histories across varied income brackets. Agricultural AI needs hyper-local crop data. Any tech firm hoping to build intelligence for the next five billion users

cannot do it without access to the depth of India's datasets.

Rewriting the Rules of the Trade

Right now, the global data trade is a one-way street. Raw, organic data moves outward, proprietary intelligence products come back, and the financial profit stays offshore. We are effectively giving away the cognitive blueprint of a billion people for free.

India has a narrow, fleeting window to stop being a passive supplier and become an active rule-maker.

The solution isn't to build a digital iron curtain. It is to create a Strategic Data Consortium - a robust, state-backed framework where India can price access to its most valuable datasets, protect its citizens, and negotiate with global monopolies from a position of real strength.

To pull this off, we need to erect three distinct policy pillars.

First, we have to rewrite the legal definition of data extraction. Scraping Wikipedia for human discovery is one thing; a trillion-dollar company sending multi-billion-parameter web crawlers to harvest a nation's digital life for commercial profit is another. We need to classify mass automated scraping as unauthorised resource extraction.

Second, India needs to build licensed data exchanges gated by national APIs. High-quality, anonymised datasets can be shared through regulated channels.

And we need to price it smartly. Indian universities and domestic startups should get heavily subsidised access to spark local innovation. But if a massive foreign AI lab wants that data, they must pay premium commercial rates.

Third, we have to negotiate for hard infrastructure, not just licensing fees. If frontier AI firms want preferred access to Indian reality, payment shouldn't stop at cash. India should demand local compute capacity, domestic server farms, advanced semiconductor transfers, and equity stakes in the products built using our data. Imagine a global AI model predicting monsoons that is actually partially owned by an Indian public trust and running on servers powered in Tamil Nadu.

A Playbook for the Global South

If we get this right, India won't just secure its own future; we will write the playbook for the Global South. Countries across Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia are facing the exact same vulnerability. Their demographic data is training systems while the profits sit in

Silicon Valley. By creating shared standards on data pricing and fair exchange, India can lead a new, non-aligned movement for the digital age.

Of course, the critics will push back. Free-market purists will warn that this creates bureaucratic red tape, stifles investment, and invites trade retaliation. Those are fair warnings, and they highlight why the policy design must be meticulous.

A Strategic Data Consortium has to put cryptographic privacy first. Data must be rigorously anonymised, access must be auditable, and independent oversight is non-negotiable. Most importantly, the economic wealth generated from this data has to return to the public as a tangible "citizen dividend." Think public-good AI tutors for rural schools, or subsidized cloud computing for local founders.

The global AI race is constantly framed as a geopolitical war over semiconductors. Yes, chips matter. Energy grids matter. But hardware alone cannot synthesise intelligence. To truly understand the world, models need contact with human life.

As machine-generated junk increasingly pollutes the internet, authentic human data is becoming the rarest commodity on earth. The nations that realize this first won't just consume foreign algorithms; they will dictate the terms on which those algorithms are built. The next great global resource contest won't be fought over oil or silicon. It will be fought over access to reality itself.

Author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure, and global systems

Jugaad meets AI: Why frugal thinking could decide the next tech race



ROHIT YADAV

Artificial intelligence is the most powerful technology the world has built in a generation. It is also, so far, almost entirely designed for the wrong people. The industry's default assumption is abundance. More computing power, more money, more data, more everything. The most advanced AI models cost hundreds of millions of dollars to build and burn electricity that could power small cities. This is innovation engineered for people who already have everything, and it is being sold to a world where most people have very little. That contradiction is not a footnote to the AI story. It is the central problem that will determine whether this technology fulfils its promise or simply widens the gaps that already exist.

That gap is not new. It is the same one that frugal innovation has been quietly closing for decades. And if history is any guide, the country that masters frugal AI will not just serve the world's majority. It will lead the next technological era.

Frugal innovation is not about cutting corners. It is about starting from a completely different place. Instead of building something expensive and then trying to make it cheaper, you design from scratch with constraint as your guide. The goal is not a discount version of a luxury product. It is something better suited to the reality most people actually live in. The idea is not uniquely Indian, and it would be dishonest to claim otherwise. Kenya gave the world M-Pesa, a mobile banking system built for people



without bank accounts, now studied in business schools globally. Brazil has its own word for it, gambiarra, the art of ingenious improvisation. Even Henry Ford, when he built the Model T, was practicing a version of this thinking: how

do you make something powerful accessible to ordinary people?

But India has a particular claim to this space, and not just because of jugaad, the Hindi word that has quietly entered global business vocabulary. India's claim is one of scale, diversity, and a proven track record. The Jaipur Foot, a prosthetic limb that costs a fraction of its Western equivalent and lets users squat, walk on uneven terrain, and climb trees, is now exported to over twenty six countries. Aravind Eye Care performs world class cataract surgeries at almost no cost, using a system so

efficient that Harvard professors fly to Madurai to study it. ISRO put a spacecraft in Mars orbit for less than the budget of the Hollywood film Gravity. India did not achieve these things despite its constraints. It achieved them because of them.

Here is the irony that should make every Indian optimist sit up straight. The most exciting frontier in global AI research right now is not

bigger models or smarter chat-bots. It is efficiency. After years of building systems that require enormous computing power and vast amounts of electricity, the industry is now desperately asking: can we do this smaller? Cheaper? Faster? Can AI run on a basic phone? Can it work without an internet connection? Can it speak in languages that are not English? This is jugaad thinking. Silicon Valley has simply

arrived at it twenty years late.

India is already building in this space. Bhashini, the government backed language AI initiative, is working to make digital services accessible in dozens of Indian languages, because an AI that only speaks English is not really intelligent, it is merely privileged. Startups across Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Chennai are building diagnostic tools for district hospitals, crop advisory systems for smallholder farmers, and voice first interfaces for users who have never typed a sentence in their lives. These are not poor substitutes for real AI. They are a different and for most of the world a far more relevant vision of what AI should actually be.

Having the right instinct, however, is not enough. For India to lead rather than simply participate, a few things need to change. Investment must flow into AI research rooted in Indian problems: climate resilience, multilingual education, rural healthcare,

judicial backlog. These are not niche concerns. They are some of the most consequential unsolved problems on the planet, and India should be the country writing the solutions, not waiting to license them from abroad. The talent pipeline must stretch beyond IITs and metro cities, because the next breakthrough idea might come from a self-taught developer in Guwahati or an engineering college in Coimbatore that nobody has heard of. And regulation must be homegrown and inventive, not a copy paste of frameworks designed in Brussels or Washington, protecting citizens without strangling the innovation that makes frugal AI possible in the first place.

Every previous technology wave arrived in India on someone else's terms. We wrote the world's code during the IT boom, but the intellectual property belonged elsewhere. We became one of the world's largest internet markets, but the platforms were built in America and China. AI is different. For the first time, the very constraint that held emerging economies back, the need to do more with less, to solve harder problems with fewer resources, is the defining skill of the moment.

Frugal innovation is not a consolation prize for countries that cannot afford the real thing. It never was. It is a philosophy, a discipline, and in the age of AI, a serious competitive advantage. The world does not need a smarter version of Silicon Valley's AI. It needs an AI that was built thinking of the majority first. That is the AI India should be building.

Author is a Assistant Professor, School of Business Management, Narsee Monjee Institute of Management Studies, Mumbai PhD, IIM Ranchi

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

2 terrorists killed in KPK

Pakistani security forces killed two terrorists of the banned TTP in the country's restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa(KPK) province, the army said on Monday. An intelligence-based operation was conducted on Sunday in the Bannu district, the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the media wing of the army, said in a statement. Two terrorists were killed in the operation conducted as part of ongoing efforts against "Fitna al-Khawarij", it said. Fitna al-Khawarij is a term used by the state for terrorists belonging to the outlawed Teh-reek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). One of the terrorists was identified as a key commander of the TTP, listed among the most-wanted terrorists. He was allegedly involved in multiple attacks targeting security forces and civilians.

USA

Mother and 6 children killed

A mother and six children ranging in age from 3 to 11 were killed in an explosion and fire at a central Pennsylvania home, authorities said. Firefighters responding to a report of an explosion and fire at a home in Lamar Township in Clinton County near Mill Hall on Sunday morning confirmed that seven people were trapped, but they could not search the building engulfed in flames, Pennsylvania State Police said in a statement. All seven died, and police identified them as Sarah Stolfus, 34, four sons, ages 11, 10, 5 and 3, and two daughters, ages 8 and 6. The cause is under investigation. A propane leak inside the home may have caused the explosion and fire, police said, noting that exterior propane tanks did not explode and were not contributing factors to the explosion and fire. Neighbour Christina Duck told WNEP-TV she was eating breakfast when it began.

China calls Strait of Hormuz international waterway

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Monday called for the opening of the Strait of Hormuz for normal passage of ships, as Beijing described it as an "international waterway"amid assertions by Iran that it has an inalienable right over it. The Strait of Hormuz should remain open to normal navigation, which is in the common interest of regional countries and the international community, Xi told Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman during their phone talks, an official statement said. This is the first statement by the Chinese leader on the closure of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran, followed by the US blockade of Iranian ports in their current conflict. The closure of the Strait has resulted in acute energy shortages



across the world, especially in Asia, and China, which is a major importer of Iranian oil, is increasingly concerned about the prolongation of the US-Israel-Iran war.

"The Strait of Hormuz should remain open for normal passage, which aligns with the common interest of countries in the region and the international communi-

ty,"Xi said in his call with the Saudi Prince. "China advocates an immediate and comprehensive ceasefire, supports all efforts conducive to restoring peace and insists on resolving disputes through political and diplomatic channels,"he said, according to the official statement. Separately, the Chinese Foreign Ministry has expressed concern over the US Navy firing on a cargo ship travelling from China heading to an Iranian port, defying the American naval blockade. The ship was subsequently seized by the US Navy. "We express concern over the forced interception of relevant vessel by the US,"Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told the media here on Monday. He also called the Strait of Hormuz an international water-

way in response to an Iranian official's assertion that Iran will not cede control over it, saying that Tehran has an "inalienable right"over it. The situation in the Strait of Hormuz is sensitive and complex, Guo said, responding to questions over the US intercepting the cargo ship. For its part, Iran vowed retaliation and called it a "piracy"act. Tehran also said it will not participate in a second round of talks with the US in Islamabad. "We hope relevant parties will act responsibly, abide by the ceasefire agreement, avoid provoking conflicts and exacerbating tensions, and create the necessary conditions for the resumption of normal navigation in the Strait,"Guo said. Asked about Iranian security forces firing on Indian-flagged vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, Guo

said,"I have already stated China's position on the Strait of Hormuz issue. We would like to reiterate that the Strait of Hormuz is an international waterway, and keeping it open to navigation serves the common interests of countries in the region and the international community."He was responding to a question how the Iranian forces opening fire on the Indian-flagged vessels raises concerns over navigational safety and China's views on the escalation and what measures it is considering to safeguard its shipping and energy interests in the Strait. Guo said China hopes all parties will work together to prevent the situation in the Strait from deteriorating further, and stands ready to continue making efforts alongside the international community to help de-escalate tensions. (PTI)

Israel condemns soldier for defacing Jesus' statue

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Tel Aviv

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu condemned an Israeli soldier filmed defacing a statue of Jesus Christ during operations in Lebanon, saying he was "stunned and saddened" by the soldier's actions. Photos surfaced of a soldier smashing the head of a toppled statue of Jesus with a sledgehammer. The Israeli military overnight confirmed the images were genuine, setting off a wave of condemnation. Netanyahu said Israel had launched a criminal investigation into the soldier's actions. The Israeli military also said it was assisting the



community to restore the statue. The military did not immediately confirm where or when the incident took place. The Israeli military controls a large swath of southern Lebanon, reach-

ing some 10 kilometers (6 miles) from the Israeli border, and has not allowed residents to return. US Ambassador to Israel Mike Huckabee, a staunch Christian, said Israel must take action against the "outrageous act." Cardinal Pierbattista Pizzaballa, the Latin Patriarch of Jerusalem, on Monday expressed "profound indignation and unreserved condemnation" of the defacing of a statue of Jesus Christ by an Israeli soldier in Lebanon, saying the act "constitutes a grave affront to the Christian faith." The Israeli military confirmed on Sunday that images showing an Israeli soldier smashing the head of

a toppled Christ statue with a sledgehammer were genuine, setting off a wave of condemnation. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel had launched a criminal investigation into the soldier's actions. Foreign Minister Gideon Saar described it as "shameful" and apologised "to every Christian whose feelings were hurt." In a statement from Jerusalem, The Assembly of Catholic Ordinaries of the Holy Land, headed by Pizzaballa, called for "immediate and decisive disciplinary action, a credible process of accountability, and clear assurances that such conduct will neither be tolerated nor repeated."

UK calls for toll-free Hormuz

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Britain on Monday called for a lasting settlement to ensure freedom of navigation and a toll-free Strait of Hormuz as the US-Iran ceasefire hung in the balance. UK Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper arrived in Japan for the final leg of what has been branded as an "intensified shuttle diplomacy tour"to advance coordination with key allies on shared geopolitical, economic and energy security priorities. During the six-day tour spanning Europe and West Asia, the British minister held in-person talks with Foreign Ministers from 11 countries, including Pakistan, Turkey,



Egypt, the UAE, and Ukraine, concluding with a meeting with the Japanese Foreign Minister for the annual Strategic Dialogue in Tokyo. "An important meeting with Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar on importance of extending the ceasefire & getting shipping routes

through the Strait of Hormuz fully reopened,"said Cooper, following the meeting with her Pakistani counterpart on Sunday. "The UK is grateful to Pakistan for the role they have been playing in facilitating diplomatic talks," she said. (PTI)

Iran death toll rises to 3,300 amid ongoing conflict

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Iran on Monday offered a new death toll for the war with Israel and the United States, with its forensic chief saying at least 3,375 people had been killed in the conflict. The figure came from Abbas Masjedi, the head of Iran's Legal Medicine Organisation. Masjedi, quoted by the judiciary's Mizan news agency and other outlets Monday, said only four of the dead remain unidentified. His comments did not break down casualties among civilians and security forces, instead just saying that 2,875 were male and 496 were female. Masjedi said 383 of the dead were children 18 years



old and under. Masjedi's figures raised questions about whether or not they included security force

members, particularly given the levels of intense bombings targeting military bases and arsenals in the country.

US funding to help Cyprus upgrade key military bases for a regional role

MENELAOS HADJICOSTIS ■ Paphos (Cyprus)

With help from US taxpayers, Cyprus is upgrading key military installations to strengthen the mission it has carved for itself as a safe haven in the eastern Mediterranean for evacuees from the conflict-wracked Middle East and as a humanitarian aid hub. Cyprus' main Evangelos Florakis naval base, just 142 miles (229 kilometers) from Lebanon's coast, will get a new, US European Command-funded heliport that will be able to accommodate large, Chinook-type transport helicopters for air-



Cyprus' elite naval commandos, known as frogmen, train during an exercise at the Evangelos Florakis naval base in Mari, Cyprus AP

lifting evacuees out of conflict zones. In the island's southwest, the Andreas Papandreou air base will be expanded to include a new apron where dozens of heavy-lift military transport aircraft bringing in

personnel and equipment in support of regional humanitarian missions can be refueled and undergo maintenance more quickly, Lt. Col. Paris Samoutis, a spokesperson for Cyprus' National Guard, told the Associated

Press which obtained rare, exclusive access to the restricted facilities. The US is paying for these two projects - part of a wider program of upgrades for both bases - to help Cyprus meet the requirements of large-scale operations in response to humanitarian crises. Work is expected to start next year. Exact funding for both projects hasn't been released as cost assessments are underway. Samoutis said the US has put up 500,000 euros (\$588,000) for a development plan that will determine the overall cost of the air base's expansion to include the new apron.(AP)

NSA Doval discusses bilateral relations, regional situation with Saudi leaders

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Riyadh

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval has met Saudi Arabia's senior leaders and discussed the bilateral relations, the regional situation and other areas of mutual interests. Doval, who reached Riyadh on Sunday, was received at the airport by India's Ambassador Suhel Khan and Saudi Arabia's Deputy Minister for Political Affairs Saud Al-Sati. Doval held meetings with Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan, Energy Minister Abdulaziz bin Salman and National Security Advisor Musaed Al-Aiban. During the meetings, the



National Security Advisor Ajit Doval with Saudi Arabia Minister of Foreign Affairs Faisal bin Farhan during a meeting in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia AP

two sides discussed bilateral relations, the regional situation and other issues of mutual interests, the Indian Embassy in Saudi Arabia said in a post on X. Doval's visit comes amid a possible second round of

talks between the US and Iran this week in Pakistan to end the West Asia conflict. The first round of talks between the US and Iran in Pakistan on April 11 and 12 concluded without any agreement. More than 17,000

US and allied forces kick off combat drills with Philippines

JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

The United States and the Philippines kicked off one of their largest combat exercises on Monday in an annual display of allied military might aimed at deterring aggression in Asia, despite Washington's preoccupation with the war in the West Asia. The large-scale combat drills between the US and Philippines will expand this year to include other militaries, including from Japan, France and Canada, which have signed visiting forces agreements with Manila, the Philippine military said. More than 17,000



American and Filipino military personnel will participate in the Balikatan — Tagalog for shoulder-to-shoulder — exercise. The event will last nearly three weeks and will include mock battle scenarios and live-fire maneuvers in locations including Philippine

provinces facing the disputed South China Sea and the Taiwan Strait. Nearly 10,000 US military personnel will take part in the combat drills, a major deployment that US military officials said underscores Washington's commitment to Asia despite its preoccupation with the war against Iran. "Regardless of the challenges elsewhere in the world, the United States focus on the Indo-Pacific and our ironclad commitment to the Philippines remains unwavering,"Marine Lieutenant General Christian Wortman said in the opening ceremony. (AP)

US shooting: Louisiana gunman kills 8 children, 7 of his own

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Shreveport

A gunman in Louisiana killed eight children, including seven of his own, and shot two other people in an early morning attack carried out in two different houses on Sunday in one of the deadliest mass shootings in the country in more than two years, authorities said. Those killed ranged in age from 1 to about 12 years old, and one of the adults wounded was the mother of the suspect's children, said Shreveport Police Department spokesperson Chris Bordelon. The suspect, whom Bordelon identified as



Shamar Elkins, died after a police pursuit. Investigators did not say what may have set off the violence. Bordelon said there was still much to investi-

gate but that detectives were confident the shooting was "entirely a domestic incident." This is an extensive scene unlike anything most of us have ever

seen,"Bordelon said. He said Elkins had been known to police and was arrested in 2019 in a firearms case. Officials were not aware of any other domestic violence issues. Officers fired at the suspect during a chase after he car-jacked a vehicle at gunpoint, Bordelon said. Police said the attacks began before sunrise in a neighbourhood south of downtown Shreveport when the suspect shot a woman at one home and then drove to the other location "where this heinous act was carried out."Seven children were killed inside the second house, and one was found dead on the roof

after apparently trying to escape, Bordelon said. State Republican Tammy Phelps said some children tried to get away through the back door. "I can't even imagine what the police officers, first responders actually dealt with when they got here today,"she said at a news conference. The two wounded women were in critical condition, officials said. A neighbour wakes up to mass shooting Liza Demming, who lives two houses down from where most of the victims were shot, said her security camera captured video of the suspect running away along with the sound of two shots.

"That's pretty much all I saw, was him running out of the house and the cars leaving,"she said. Demming later went outside and saw the covered body of a child on the home's roof. She said she did not know the gunman's name. "He looks like the dad that comes over here,"she said, adding that he was just with the children a few days ago. Pastor Marty T Johnson Sr, of nearby St Gabriel Community Baptist Church, who owns one of the homes where the shootings occurred, said a person who works for him had rented it to the family, but he never had dealings with them.

Indian Defence chief in UK for training and operations dialogue

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The Chief of Defence Staff, General Anil Chauhan, is in London for talks covering the spectrum of military training, operations and defence industry partnerships between India and the UK. General Chauhan, who arrived for a three-day visit on Sunday, is hosted by Chief of the Defence Staff (CDS) Air Chief Marshal Sir Richard Knighton. The commanders are also set to interact with senior UK civil and military leaders on deepening defence cooperation between both nations. "General Chauhan's landmark visit shows the trust and ambition driving the UK-India defence partnership. We are stepping up cooperation to strengthen interoperability, spur innovation and support a free, open and secure Indo-Pacific,"said Lindy Cameron, the British High Commissioner to India.



Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan, right, with Britain's Air Chief Marshal Richard Knighton during his visit to the United Kingdom PTI

"From joint training and defence industry cooperation to strategic dialogue, we are moving faster and closer, because India is a key defence partner for the UK. We will continue to build on this momentum in the months ahead,"she said. Representatives of the British defence industry are scheduled to meet General Chauhan to progress talks on greater defence co-production between the two countries. He will also be given a tour of the Royal College of Defence Studies in London, where he will meet a multinational cohort of students. "The visit signals the significant progress we have achieved together across all areas of defence and highlights how much common ground we can share going forward,"said Commodore Chris Saunders MBE Royal Navy, Defence Adviser, British High Commission. (PTI)

60 nations discuss Palestinian stability

SAM MCNEIL ■ Brussels

More than 60 nations are sending representatives to Brussels to discuss with Palestinian Prime Minister Mohamed Mustafa stability, security and long-term peace in Israel, the West Bank and Gaza, as global attention largely remains focused on the West Asia on the ongoing crises in Iran and Lebanon. Ongoing attacks in the West Bank and continued devastation in Gaza dim the prospect for a two-State solution, said Belgian Foreign Minister Maxime Prevot ahead of the meeting on Monday. He is co-hosting the meeting with the EU's top diplomat, Kaja Kallas. "We observe without

naivety that the two-state solution is being made more difficult by the day," Prevot said. "But Belgium and many European and Arab partners continue to believe that this remains the only realistic path to a lasting peace, for Israelis, for Palestinians and for the stability of the entire region." The 27-nation European Union is the largest single donor to the Palestinian Authority, with its 90-year-old president Mahmoud Abbas ruling from Ramallah for two decades. And while the EU has avoided directly joining the Board of Peace created by United States President Donald Trump, preferring the multilateralism of the



European Union foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas, Palestinian Prime Minister Mohammad Mustafa during a meeting of the Global Alliance for the Implementation of the Two-State Solution in Brussels

United Nations and global legal norms, the bloc is eager not to be sidelined in diplomacy in a volatile region just across the Mediterranean. Outrage in

Europe over the humanitarian catastrophe in Gaza drove many EU leaders to condemn Israel's war conduct and to pressure Prime Minister Benjamin

Netanyahu's Government. With the recent ouster of long-serving Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban, a close ally of Netanyahu, there might now be enough political support within the bloc for stronger actions like targeted sanctions on Israeli settlers or even the suspension of some ties to Israel. Palestinians in the West Bank say that Israel has used the cover of the Iran war to tighten its grip over the territory, as settler attacks surge and the military imposes additional wartime restrictions on movement, citing security. Gaza requires "one state, one Government, one law and one goal," Mustafa said on Monday in Brussels. (AP)

UK police arrest 2 in connection with weekend arson attack



DANICA KIRKA ■ London

British police have arrested two teenagers in connection with a weekend arson attack on a synagogue in northwest London, as Jewish leaders express concern about a wave of incidents targeting their community. Deputy Commissioner Matt Jukes of London's Metropolitan Police Service on Monday said officers arrested two young men, aged 19 and 17, overnight in relation to the attack on the Kenton United Synagogue in the borough of Harrow. The department has made 15 arrests related to six attacks on Jewish targets and a Persian-language media organisation critical of Iran's Government that occurred over the past few weeks, he said in an interview with the BBC. One "serious line of inquiry" is that Iran is hiring local criminals to carry out these attacks amid tensions in the West Asia, including the US-Israeli war against the Islamic Republic, Jukes said. (AP)

US strike on alleged drug boat kills three in Caribbean Sea



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The US military said it launched another strike on a boat accused of ferrying drugs in the Caribbean Sea, killing three people Sunday. The Trump administration's campaign of blowing up alleged drug-trafficking vessels in Latin American waters has persisted since early September and killed at least 181 people. Other strikes have taken place in the eastern Pacific Ocean. Despite the Iran war, the series of strikes have ramped up again in the past week or so, showing that the administration's aggressive measures to stop what it calls "narcoterrorism" in the Western Hemisphere are not letting up. The military has not provided evidence that any of the vessels were carrying

drugs. The attacks began as the US built up its largest military presence in the region in generations and came months ahead of the raid in January that captured then-Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro. He was brought to New York to face drug trafficking charges and has pleaded not guilty. In the latest attack Sunday, US Southern Command repeated previous statements by saying it had targeted the alleged drug traffickers along known smuggling routes. It posted a video on X showing a boat moving along the water before a massive explosion engulfs the vessel in flames. President Trump has said the US is in "armed conflict" with cartels in Latin America and has justified the attacks as a necessary escalation to stem the flow of drugs into the United States and fatal overdoses claiming American lives.

VP Radhakrishnan concludes Sri Lanka visit with key agreements signed

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan concluded his two-day visit to Sri Lanka on Monday during which he held talks with the island nation's top leadership as the two countries inked a number of agreements to deepen bilateral cooperation. Radhakrishnan, the first vice president to visit Sri Lanka, arrived in Colombo on Sunday and held talks with President Anura Kumara Dissanayake on the same day. The two leaders discussed ongoing Indian project implementation in Sri Lanka, emphasising the \$450 million Cyclone Ditwah aid offered by India.



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan during his visit to the Gangaramaya Temple in Colombo, Sri Lanka

the fishermen issue in a humanitarian manner, considering the livelihoods of fishing communities on both sides. Following the talks, the two sides inked six MoUs, including the construction of a medical ward in Mullaitivu, the establishment of a premature baby unit in Dehiattakandiya, construction of EYE, ENT and mental health units in Muthur, among others. India also announced the extension of OCI eligibility up to the sixth generation of the Indian diaspora and the simplification of the process for the benefit of the Indian-origin Tamil community. The two sides also announced the resumption of train services on the restored Northern Railway Line as a part of the post-Ditwah cyclone rehabilitation package. They also announced the installation of a set of three Bailey bridges – one in Central Province (Kandy) and two in Uva Province as a part of the post-Ditwah rehabilitation.

It was also announced that Sri Lanka will join the India-led International Big Cat Alliance. The vice president also met Prime Minister Harini Amarasuriya, who is also the education minister, and discussed cooperation in that area. An announcement regarding the enhancement of the Ceylon Estate Workers Education Trust scholarship scheme was also made. The number of scholarships under this scheme is being doubled from 350 to 700 and the monthly stipend is being increased from LKR 2,500 for A-level students and to LKR 7,500 for those pursuing higher education. The vice president also announced the completion and handing over of the final tranche of houses under Phase 3 of the Indian Housing Project. This Phase 3 includes 4,000 houses for estate workers in the plantation regions of the Central Province, Uva and the Southern Province of Sri Lanka.

Fire destroys 1,000 homes on Malaysia's Borneo island

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kuala Lumpur

A fire that tore through a Malaysian coastal settlement on Borneo Island destroyed about 1,000 homes and displaced over 9,000 people, authorities said. The fire started early Sunday in the Sandakan district and spread rapidly through rows of wooden houses constructed on stilts above the sea, according to the fire and rescue department. Officials said strong winds and the close proximity of the structures helped fuel the fire, while narrow access routes and low tide conditions made it harder



for emergency crews to reach affected areas and contain the flames. No deaths have been reported, though thousands of residents have been forced from their homes and moved to temporary shelter. The cause of the fire has not been confirmed and remains under investigation.

Powerful 7.5-magnitude earthquake strikes off Japan, tsunami alert issued

MARI YAMAGUCHI ■ Tokyo

A powerful earthquake struck off the northern Japanese coast, and the Japan Meteorological Agency issued a tsunami alert in the region. The quake, registering a preliminary magnitude of 7.5, occurred off the coast of Sanriku in northern Japan at around 4.53 pm (0753 GMT), at a depth of about 10 kilometres (6 miles) below the sea surface, the agency said. A tsunami of about 80 centimetres (2.6 feet) was detected at the Kuji port in the Iwate prefecture, and a smaller tsunami of 40 centimetres (1.3 feet) was recorded at another port in the prefecture, the agency said. The agency urged residents in the region to immediately stay away from the coast or along rivers and take shelter on higher ground. It also cautioned people in the area against possible aftershocks for



about a week. The Iwate prefecture issued non-binding evacuation advisories to residents in 11 towns. A tsunami of up to 3 metres (10 feet) could hit the area, the agency said. In addition to the tsunami alert in Iwate and Aomori to the north and southeastern Hokkaido, the agency also issued a milder tsunami advisory for the coasts of Miyagi and Fukushima, south of the epicentre. Another 7.5 magnitude quake in December left dozens injured. (AP)

French prosecutors summon Elon Musk over allegations of child abuse images, deepfakes on X

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris



Elon Musk has been summoned to Paris on Monday, where investigators are looking into allegations of misconduct related to the social media platform X, including the spread of child sexual abuse material and deepfake content. The world's richest man and Linda Yaccarino - the former CEO of X - have been summoned for "voluntary interviews," while other employees of the platform are scheduled to be heard as witnesses throughout this week, the Paris prosecutor's office said. It remains unclear whether Musk and Yaccarino will travel to Paris. A

spokesperson for X did not respond to questions from The Associated Press and Yaccarino's current company, eMed, did not answer a request sent to the press email. French prosecutors also suspect that controversy around the platform's AI system Grok's deepfakes was

concocted to boost the value of Musk-owned companies ahead of a key market listing, and alerted US authorities. Musk welcomed a report that US justice officials refused to help French investigators, posting on X, "This needs to stop." The reason for summoning Musk was summoned after a search took place in February at the French premises of X as part of an investigation opened in January 2025 by the cyber-crime unit of the Paris prosecutor's office. Musk and Yaccarino have been invited in their capacities as managers of X at the time of the events investigated. Yaccarino was CEO from May

2023 until July 2025. "These voluntary interviews with the executives are intended to allow them to present their position regarding the facts and, where appropriate, the compliance measures they plan to implement," prosecutors said. "At this stage, the conduct of this investigation is part of a constructive approach, with the ultimate objective of ensuring that platform X complies with French law, insofar as it operates within the national territory." The Paris prosecutor's office said Musk and Yaccarino's potential no-show on Monday "is not an obstacle for investigations to continue."

Bulgaria: Pro-Russia Rusev wins presidential election

VESELIN TOSHKOV
■ Sofia

The center-left coalition of ex-president Rumen Radev has emerged as the clear winner of Bulgaria's parliamentary election, the country's central electoral commission said Monday, ending half a decade of political fragmentation. With 96 per cent of the ballots counted by early Monday, results showed the Progressive Bulgaria coalition receiving 44.7 per cent of the vote, over 20 percentage points ahead of the center-right GERB party of veteran leader Boyko Borissov and the pro-Western reformist bloc by the We Continue the Change party. Both parties ran neck-to-neck, scoring 13.4 per cent



and 12.9 per cent respectively. Two other parties also appear to have gained seats in the 240-seat chamber, according to the latest results. Borissov conceded defeat and congratulated the election winner. Radev described his party's victory as "unequivocal," a "victory of hope over distrust, a victory of freedom over fear," saying

Bulgaria would "make every effort to continue on its European path". "But believe me, a strong Bulgaria and a strong Europe need critical thinking and pragmatism. Europe has fallen victim to its own ambition to be a moral leader in a world without rules," Radev told reporters. During his presidency, Radev gained a

reputation as being sympathetic to Russia. He repeatedly opposed EU efforts to send military aid to Ukraine for its war against Russia's full-scale invasion. He has often argued that supporting Ukraine risks drawing Bulgaria into the war and has favored reopening talks with Russia as a way out of the conflict. Radev resigned from the mostly ceremonial presidency in January, a few months before the end of his second term, to launch a bid to lead the Government in the more powerful role as prime minister. The former fighter pilot, 62, earned a Master of Strategic Studies degree from the US Air War College in 2003, before being appointed Bulgarian air force commander. (AP)

US energy blockade on Cuba pulls the plug on Havana's legendary nightlife

ANDREA RODRIGUEZ
■ Havana

Havana's broad avenues are empty at night. Theatres are closed. Bars and cafes have curtains lowered. It is hard to find lights in the streets or Cubans making money entertaining tourists. Under the weight of an oil embargo imposed by the second administration of US President Donald Trump, and the island's most severe economic crisis in decades, the city's once bustling nightlife has gone quiet. "I feel empty inside when I see my streets empty," said Yusleydi Blanco, a 41-year-old accountant. "I can't be happy when my country is sad." Worse than the Special Period Following a 2016 deal between then-Presidents

Barack Obama and Raul Castro easing US travel restrictions on Cuba, money flooded the island as tourism spiked. A small number of entrepreneurs opened newly allowed private businesses and bought imported modern vehicles that shared the streets with classic cars from the 1950s. In 2018, a record 4.7 million tourists arrived on the island. Hotel accommodations were so saturated that travellers without lodging were seen sleeping in a park in the small western Cuban town of Vinales that draws thousands of tourists and rock climbers to its scenic limestone cliffs. Today, gasoline sales are limited to 20 litres (5 gallons) per vehicle and owners can wait months for a turn at the pump. Buses now stop running at 6 pm and interna-



tional airlines including Air France, Air Canada and Iberia have stopped flying to Havana because they cannot refuel there. The sound of cars has disappeared in the wealthy El Vedado neighbourhood, where the soundscape of chirping birds has re-emerged. The Cuban Government reported the arrival of 77,600 tourists in February, down from 1,78,000 on the same month a year ago. "This is worse than the Special Period," said 65-year-old parking attendant Dolores de la Caridad Mendez about the years of economic devastation that followed the collapse of the Soviet Union, Cuba's Cold War patron, in the 1990s. In contrast with his Democratic predecessors, US President Donald Trump has tightened economic

sanctions against Cuba, demanding an end to political repression, a release of political prisoners and a liberalisation of the island's ailing economy. The deepening crisis has led to persistent blackouts, cuts to the state-run food ration system, and severe shortages of water and medicine that have transformed daily life into an ordeal for many in the island of 10 million. Between 2021 and 2024, approximately 1.4 million Cubans left the island – mostly young people but also accomplished musicians, actors, dancers and other entertainers who fuelled Havana's nightlife. In January, the US captured then-President Nicolas Maduro of Venezuela, which had been Cuba's primary supplier of oil. The Trump administration severed

that supply and threatened to impose tariffs on other countries that sold oil to Cuba, which went without a single shipment until a Russian tanker came in March. For entrepreneurs and business owners across the island, life has become difficult as tourism plummeted and their hopes of selling cheaper goods to fellow Cubans dashed against the rocks of a vastly harder economic reality. "You wake up and you're ready to conquer the world, saying, today I'll sell more than ever," said Yeni Perez, owner of the Old Havana cafe Entre Nos. "Then not a single client comes in and you go home devastated." "The next day," she said, "You say, Let's give it another chance. It's a time that's testing everyone's stamina." (AP)

A geopolitical crisis in West Asia framed as a clash of religions!



AKHIL GUPTA

The escalating conflict in the Middle East, involving Israel, Iran, and the United States, has once again drawn the world into a familiar and troubling narrative. What should be understood as a geopolitical crisis is all too often framed as a clash of religions. Judaism, Islam, and Christianity are portrayed as civilisations locked in an inevitable struggle for supremacy.

The language used in public discourse frequently reinforces this perception, as if faith itself were the source of our deepest divisions. Yet, this framing reflects a profound misunderstanding of religion. As I explore in my book Bridges Across Humanity, at their

core, the world's great religious traditions share remarkably similar foundations.

They are not opposing fortresses, but rather different pillars supporting the same shared moral vocabulary developed over millennia. Judaism speaks of repairing the world through tikkun olam.

Christianity places love at the center of its message, urging believers to care for their neighbor. Islam emphasises compassion and mercy as the defining attributes of the Divine.

While the teachings differ in form and context, their ethical core is strikingly aligned. Each tradition calls for humility, responsibility, compassion, and justice. The conflict we witness today is therefore not a failure of religion, but a failure to understand it. The reality is that faith is frequently hijacked by those who seek power.

Over time, religious traditions

have been drawn into political narratives, national identities, and historical grievances by politicians and so-called priests who weaponise belief for their own ends. These figures use religion as a convenient symbol under which deeper, more cynical motives regarding power, land, and control are concealed. History is tragically replete with examples of this manipulation.

Consider the devastating European wars of religion in the 16th and 17th centuries. The vicious conflicts between Catholics and Protestants, culminating in the Thirty Years' War, decimated populations across Europe. This is in spite of the fact the Jesus, who was the Prophet for both groups, taught to love thy neighbor like thyself. Millions perished in violence ostensibly fought over theological differences.

Yet, historians widely agree

that these wars were largely driven by dynastic ambitions, the struggle for territorial dominance, and the consolidation of state power by ambitious monarchs and religious leaders. It was only when the exhaustion of war led to the Peace of Westphalia in 1648—an agreement that prioritised political sovereignty over enforced religious uniformity—that the continent began to recognise the folly of using faith as an instrument of state warfare. When this

wisdom within their traditions, religion functions as a bridge, rather than a barrier.

This misunderstanding, perpetuated by those who misuse religion, is particularly dangerous for a new generation trying to make sense of the world. Many young people today encounter religion primarily through headlines about violence, extremism, or confrontation orchestrated by political and religious hardliners. As a result, faith can appear rigid, divisive, or outdated.

The deeper philosophical and ethical insights that religions offer to unite us are rarely presented with the clarity they deserve. What young people need today is not less religion, but a clearer, more lived understanding of it—free from political manipulation. When approached with openness, the teachings of the world's traditions offer powerful guidance on how human beings can live together meaningfully.

In my book To Flourish Is to Love, Learn, Play, I explore a simple, practical framework to reclaim this shared humanity. These three actions are not abstract ideals, but daily habits that directly counteract the rigidity of manufactured conflict. Love is not mere sentiment; it is a profound responsibility to one another. It is the very foundation of the bridges we must build across cultures, demanding that we see the divine in our neighbor. Learning must not be confined to institutions.

It is a lifelong discipline of curiosity and reflection. Cultivating a learning mindset dismantles the dogma and ignorance that political leaders often exploit to fuel geopolitical hatred. Joy, celebration, and playfulness are essential aspects of human life. They are the antidotes to fear, preventing societies and individuals from becoming hardened, cynical, and easily manipulated.

If we return to these fundamentals, the narrative around religion begins to change. Instead of seeing faith traditions as opposing camps, we recognise them as beautiful, varied expressions of the exact same human search for meaning. The emphasis shifts from defending our isolated identities to cultivating mutual understanding.

This shift does not erase political conflicts or historical complexities. Those challenges remain real, difficult, and demanding of our attention. But at a moment when religion is so often invoked in the language of war by those who seek to divide us, returning to our shared foundations—and committing to love, learn, and play together—may be the most important task before us to build lasting bridges across humanity.

US-based author is the founder of Universal Enlightenment & Flourishing and former chairman of Blackstone India

CBI arrests two RCOM senior officials in bank fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Monday said it has arrested two senior executives of Reliance Communications (RCOM), a company of the Anil Ambani group, in an alleged bank fraud case, the agency said on Monday.

It identified the officials as RCOM Vice President Anil Kalya and Joint President D Vishwanath. The federal agency will seek their remand before a court.

The investigation pertains to RCOM, Anil Ambani and others, registered based on a complaint filed by the State Bank of India (SBI), with allegations that the bank sanctioned credit facilities to the company but due to the accused borrowers' "fraudulent" activities, the lender suffered a wrongful loss of around ₹2,929.05 crore.

According to the complaint, a wrongful loss of ₹19,694 crore was caused to 17 public sector banks and financial institutions.

Investigation found that RCOM entered into "circuitous" transactions



through "shell" entities controlled by company officials. Furthermore, the CBI said in a statement that RCOM obtained discounted Letters of Credit (LCs) opened for "bogus" service-related transactions with its group entities, which devolved and caused huge losses to the banks.

According to the agency, Vishwanath was in overall charge of the group's banking operations, and he directed the "misutilisation" of funds.

It said he coordinated with banks for the sanction and disbursal of the facilities

to the accused company.

The probe agency said Kalya "actively" supported Vishwanath, adding that they were both "important" RCOM functionaries managing corporate finance, banking operations, payments and fund utilisation.

The agency, over the last few months, has registered seven cases against the Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group based on complaints lodged by various public sector banks and LIC for alleged frauds totalling thousands of crores of rupees.

Meanwhile a spokesperson for Reliance Group clar-

ified, "D Vishwanath and Anil Kalya served as Chief Financial Officer (CFO) and Vice President (Accounts and Finance), respectively, at Reliance Communications (RCOM) after the company was admitted into the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) in 2019. RCOM operates under the supervision of Resolution Professional, Anish Nanavaty, who was appointed by the Committee of Creditors led by the State Bank of India (SBI), with Deloitte acting as advisor."

"Reliance Communications is no longer part of the Reliance Group as the company has been undergoing CIRP since 2019 under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), 2016, and has remained in the resolution process for nearly seven years, with proceedings still pending in 2026. Anil D Ambani served as a non-executive director on the board of RCOM and stepped down from this position in 2019, nearly seven years ago. He was not involved in the day-to-day operations of the company."

Water Management takes centre stage at PlumbexIndia 2026 in Bengaluru

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

PlumbexIndia 2026, India's leading platform for water, sanitation and plumbing, concluded with strong industry and government participation, reinforcing its role in advancing the country's water security and sustainable infrastructure agenda. The three-day event, organised by the Indian Plumbing Association (IPA), brought together over 15,000 visitors, 180 exhibitors, and representatives from countries, such as USA, Germany, Italy, Spain, Denmark, France, Israel, Japan, Taiwan, and China.

The event was supported by two key ministries of government of India, Ministry



of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), Ministry of Jal Shakti (MoJS) and The Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT Mission), underscoring growing alignment between policy and industry.

Gurmit Singh Arora, National President, Indian Plumbing Association said

"Plumbex India 2026 has once again demonstrated the power of collaboration in addressing India's most pressing water challenges. The conversations, innovations, and partnerships forged here reflect a shared commitment across government, industry, and academia to build resilient, efficient, and sustainable water systems. As India continues to urbanise rapidly, platforms like PlumbexIndia are essential in translating ideas into actionable solutions on the ground."

The event featured high-level discussions on urban water management, groundwater sustainability, engineering-led infrastructure solutions, and design-driven innovation, with participation from leading experts across sectors.

Postal Department posts revenue of ₹15,296 crore for FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Department of Post has clocked revenue of ₹15,296 crore for financial year 2025-26, a 16 per cent growth year-on-year, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said on Monday. Announcing the revenue scorecard after the Postal Department's



annual business meet here, Scindia said the year has been "historic" for the department. He said that with sharp focus on deepening the reach of ser-

vices, acquisition of customers and six sigma service level agreements with customers, the department is aiming for higher growth for FY27.

"...So it has been a very historic year for the Department of Post...as you are aware, we've also come out with three new products. We are now looking at increasing the penetration of many of

our services, acquiring new customers, performing against very strict 'Six Sigma' service level agreements with all our clients to post an even greater growth rate over the next fiscal year," Scindia told reporters.

The revenue for fiscal 2024-25 stood at ₹13,218 crore, and in 2025-26, the topline number increased to ₹15,296 crore.

DAILY SUDOKU

4		1	7					
			5			8		4 9
	6				4		7	
						6	2	9
7								3
		1	6	8				
			7					
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1	8			9			5	
						5	3	7

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (20.04.26)								
6	7	8	1	5	9	3	2	4
5	2	3	8	4	7	1	9	6
4	1	9	2	6	3	5	8	7
3	9	4	7	2	6	8	5	1
2	6	5	9	8	1	7	4	3
1	8	7	5	3	4	9	6	2
9	5	1	6	7	2	4	3	8
8	4	2	3	1	5	6	7	9
7	3	6	4	9	8	2	1	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

TUESDAY | APRIL 21, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8	
			9									
10										11		
13										15		16
17										18		
20	21									22		23
24										25		
27										28		
										29		
30												

SOLUTION (20.04.26)											
ACROSS	23, St-onec-hat	19, Tot	DOWN	1, H-and-icap	21, Orders	22, Meddle	23, Seethrough	24, H-an-ding	25, Consider	26, En-trea-ts	27, E-N-suring
9, Aitch-bone	25, Contended	26, Eyed (rd)	2, Standingjole	3, Con-nots	4, Devo-U-r	5, Consider	6, Thumbs	7, Br-and-ed	8, Celebrated	11, I-ron-s	16, D-Rover
10, Otherw-i-se	27, I-n-d-eed	29, End-O-rse	32, Hair shirt	35, O-pen-in-g	36, Ef-for-t	37, Fo-U-r	38, Great-aunt				
12, Dent											
13, Onions											
14, Man-hole											
15, Child star											
17, Dispenser											
18, Pig-eon-s											
19, Terror											
20, Bolt											

- ACROSS
- 1 Impertinence when out of bread? (5)
- 6 It's fun being a rogue! (5)
- 9 Unimportant figure in legal proceedings (7)
- 10 Transport by motor and railway (5)
- 11 Trick a pet companion (5)
- 12 Like the way of stars (5)
- 13 Told within the family (7)
- 15 Succeed in hitting a reduced target (3)
- 17 First fellow to have a mare (4)
- 18 She gets the wrong angle on an article (6)
- 19 Living creature (5)

- DOWN
- 2 Raised by the chap at the back (6)
- 3 Star me as a runner (6)
- 4 As an essay, a pointless entry (3)
- 5 Do without an empty space (5)
- 6 Discharging certain material (7)
- 7 Perform a dramatic piece musically (4)
- 8 She conceals her heartache in different ways (6)
- 12 Man behind me in a race (5)
- 13 Landed property managed by some charity (5)
- 14 Language resembling Latvian in parts? (5)
- 15 Lamp spirit? (5)

- 20 See a complaint as something tasteful (6)
- 22 Weary of a strange rite (4)
- 24 Athenian bird? (3)
- 25 Intermediary, and a little bent, outwardly! (7)
- 26 Val takes it to be essential (5)
- 27 Up in the air, slip out of the way (5)
- 28 Girl from Tangier (5)
- 29 It provides for the rest of the audience (7)
- 30 Is cruel to a wild beast (5)
- 31 End of the ad, perhaps (5)

- 16 Accepted with thanks by a boy (5)
- 18 Flying station in London? (5)
- 19 In any case, Sid's in the Brentford team (7)
- 21 Interrupt the French with an exclamation (6)
- 22 Pain due to a double portion of porridge (6)
- 23 Is in repose, but you won't agree! (6)
- 25 Hospital traditionally for the hereditarily honoured? (5)
- 26 Garment from the glove stall (4)
- 28 Clandestine union? (3) 30 A fabulous place for older swingers to have a party (2,6)

Parashurama Jayanti event calls for community unity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Leaders and members of the Brahmin community gathered in large numbers in the capital to mark the birth anniversary of Lord Parashurama, with a strong focus on unity, education and social upliftment.

The event was organised by the World Brahmin Federation at the Andhra Association Building in the Lodhi Institutional Area. Participants from across the National Capital Region attended the programme and discussed the need for strengthening community bonds and improving opportunities for future generations.

Speakers at the event stressed the importance of policies aimed at the social and economic progress of Brahmin families. They highlighted the role of education and cultural values in shaping the next generation and called for collective efforts to ensure growth and stability within the community. World Brahmin Federation Chairman Shashikant Sharma, in his address, urged the youth



to move forward with confidence and knowledge. He said that while success in competitive fields is important, equal attention must be given to building strong moral values among children.

He called on the younger generation to take responsibility for improving the condition of the community through education and awareness.

Several community representatives attended the event, including Vice Chairman Sukhbir Sharma, R S Goswami, K C Pandey, Ambar Swami, K C Bhardwaj, Pandit Abhishek Dutt, Dibban Lal Sharma,

Dharampal Sharma, Shreyansh Dwivedi, Dr Manju Sharma, Meenu Sharma, Pooja Sharma, Radheshyam Sharma, Vinod Sharma and Yugal Kishore Sharma.

Delhi State President Balbir Sharma, who coordinated the programme, also addressed the gathering. He underlined the need for unity and cooperation within the community and called for sustained efforts to maintain solidarity.

Lord Parashurama and ceremonial sashes. A community meal was also organised for attendees as part of the celebration.

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e tenders are hereby invited for the purchase of following item:-

Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Patiala Dairy Hiring of :- a) Vehicle for procurement activities and extension work etc. (Swift Dezire, Toyota Etios, Honda Amaze, Verna i.e Sedan cars with open diggi). b) Double cabin pickup vehicle for LN2 gas supply route and extension work.	02 No's 01 No.
2.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy Hiring of vehicle (Tata 407, 409, Mahindra Max, Mahindra Pickup, Bolero, Tata Ace or its Equivalent) for transportation of milk cans from MPDS/Farms to MCC's.	04 Routes Kalanaur-01 Tugaiwal-02 Batala-01

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

General Manager (Purchase)

1018/12/2026-27/10651

BRIEFLY

Man City star Rodri to undergo tests on groin injury

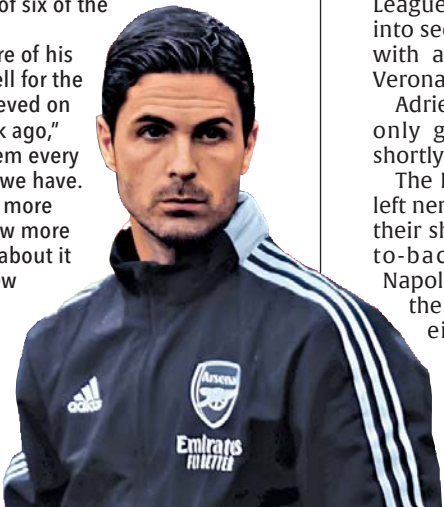


Manchester City midfielder Rodri sustained a groin injury in the 2-1 win over Arsenal in the Premier League, manager Pep Guardiola said. The Spain international came off in the 88th minute. "We'll make a test tonight," Guardiola said Sunday. Rodri has returned to his best form in recent weeks after regaining his full sharpness after ACL and groin injuries. Rodri's absence would be a blow to second-placed City's title hopes. The team is three points behind Arsenal but has a game in hand.

Arsenal convinced about winning title, says Arteta



Arsenal's players are "more convinced" than ever that they can win the Premier League despite losing to title rival Manchester City, manager Mikel Arteta said. The 2-1 defeat at Etihad Stadium was a second straight loss in the league for Arsenal and the fourth in its last six games in all competitions. City trimmed the gap to Arsenal to three points with a game in hand and, for many, is the new favorite for the title, given its own form – Pep Guardiola's team is unbeaten in the league since Jan. 17 – and pedigree as the winner of six of the last eight championships. However, Arteta felt the nature of his team's performance bodes well for the future. "I believe today, I believed on Wednesday, I believed a week ago," Arteta said. "Because I see them every day and I know the level that we have. "But today, if they need to be more convinced, I think they are now more convinced. They were talking about it in the dressing room. It's a new league now ... everything is still to play for." Arsenal struck the goal frame twice, through Gabriel Magalhaes and Eberechi Eze, while Kai Havertz headed over from close range in stoppage time.



Man City beats Arsenal in major title race swing



STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Manchester

The Premier League might just have a new title favorite. Manchester City swung the race for the championship in its favor by beating Arsenal 2-1 on Sunday thanks to a second-half winner by Erling Haaland. Haaland's league-leading 23rd goal of the campaign in the 65th minute allowed City to trim the gap to Arsenal, the long-time front-runner, to three points. City has a game in hand at relegation-threatened Burnley on Wednesday, after which Pep Guardiola's team is likely to have overturned its goal-difference deficit to Arsenal and taken the lead with five rounds remaining. "Panic on the streets of

London" read a banner held aloft behind one of the goals after the final whistle - a reference to a 1980s song by The Smiths and a nod to Arsenal's end-of-season implosion that has seen Mikel Arteta's team lose four of its last six games in all competitions, including two straight in the league. This might be a familiar sinking feeling for Arsenal fans, who have seen their team finish as runner-up for the past three Premier League seasons. "Two weeks ago, this didn't look very likely, this scenario," City captain Bernardo Silva said. An often-frenetic match exploded into life when Rayan Cherki gave City a 16th-minute lead with a

weaving run and finish, only for Arsenal to draw level in bizarre circumstances two minutes later after Gianluigi Donnarumma's clearance was charged down by Kai Havertz and rebounded into the net from close range. Haaland and Arsenal pair Eberechi Eze and Gabriel Magalhaes struck the goal frame, before Haaland slotted home a low shot from Nico O'Reilly's cross, dealing a huge blow to Arsenal's hopes of a first league championship since 2004. City is expected to beat next-to-last Burnley, but has a tougher run-in than Arsenal that includes trips to Everton and Bournemouth and a final-day meeting with Aston Villa. (AP)

AC Milan steadies Champions League push with 1-0 win at Verona, Juventus beats Bologna

DANIELLA MATAR
■ Milan

AC Milan boosted its chances of qualifying for next season's Champions League and moved back into second spot in Serie A with a 1-0 win at Hellas Verona. Adrién Rabiot scored the only goal of the match shortly before halftime. The Rossoneri had been left nervously looking over their shoulders after back-to-back losses against Napoli and Udinese. But the victory lifted Milan eight points above fifth-placed Como and back into second after Napoli's loss against Lazio the previous day.



Juventus remained within three points of Milan with a 2-0 win over Bologna. Milan hosts Juventus next week. Milan and Napoli are 12 points behind Serie A leader Inter Milan with five rounds remaining. If Inter beats Torino next Sunday and both Milan and Napoli fail to

win, the Nerazzurri would clinch the title. Rabiot was by far the best player of the first half and he broke the deadlock in the 41st minute. The France international won the ball in midfield and then spread it to Rafael Leao, before racing into the area to receive the

Endrick stars as Lyon beats Paris Saint-Germain 2-1

JEROME PUGMIRE
■ Paris

Brazil forward Endrick scored one goal and created another as Lyon won 2-1 at leader Paris Saint-Germain (PSG) to go third in Ligue 1 and boost its chances of Champions League qualification. PSG's fifth league defeat of the season left it one point ahead of second-placed Lens, with PSG having a game in hand. But PSG still has to travel to Lens in May, after the league postponed their game on April 11 due to PSG's involvement in the Champions League. Coach Paulo Fonseca's Lyon leads fourth-placed Lille on goal difference with the top three gaining direct entry to the Champions League and the side in fourth entering qualifying. **Endrick responds in style:** Fonseca recently criticized Endrick following some mediocre performances and benched him against Lorient last weekend. Endrick came on and played a part in both goals in a 2-0 win. He gave Lyon the lead on Sunday in the sixth minute. The livewire 19-year-old made a clever run behind the PSG defense to meet Afonso Moreira's pass and score with a crisp shot past goalkeeper Matvei Safonov. Lyon hit PSG with a classic counterattack in the 18th as Endrick sent Moreira clea



through from halfway and the 21-year-old Portuguese forward hit a low shot into the left corner. PSG striker Goncalo Ramos had a penalty saved by Lyon goalkeeper Dominik Greif in the 33rd. Moments later PSG midfielder Vitinha limped off with a right ankle injury.

Safonov kept out a curler from Moreira in the second half: Moreira was outstanding cutting in from the left flank and pushed his case for a first callup to the Portugal side. PSG midfielder Fabian Ruiz came on late in the game for his first appearance in three months following a knee injury. Khvicha Kvaratskhelia pulled a goal back four minutes into stoppage time with a curler from 20 meters out, but Lyon was a worthy winner and PSG coach Luis Enrique hugged Fonseca. **Balogun's run:** American forward Folarin Balogun scored for the eighth straight league game as Monaco rallied to draw 2-2 with Auxerre. Seventh-placed Monaco is one of several sides chasing a Champions League place next season. (AP)

Bayern Munich clinches another Bundesliga title



CIARAN FAHEY
■ Munich

Bayern Munich clinched another Bundesliga title by easing to a 4-2 win over Stuttgart. Harry Kane scored his league-leading 32nd goal of the season after going on as a second-half substitute, and Bayern should have scored more against the overwhelmed Stuttgart defense. The win moved Bayern an unassailable 15 points clear of second-placed Borussia Dortmund with four rounds of the German league remaining. Bayern only needed a point to be sure of the title after Dortmund's defeat to Hoffenheim the day before. It's Bayern's record-extending 35th German championship including the first for the club in 1932. Every other title came after the Bundesliga's formation in 1963. Stuttgart's Chris Fuhrich had riled the home team with the opener in the 21st minute, but Bayern's Raphael Guerreiro, Nicolas Jackson and Alphonso Davies replied by scoring in a six-minute spell in the first half. Spanish player Chema scored a spectacular second goal for Stuttgart in the 88th. **Cockatoo celebrations:** Bayern's players lined up wearing cockatoo T-shirts in front of the fans, but there were none of the traditional beer showers that usually accompany league wins. The Bundesliga is just the first in a potential treble of trophies for Bayern this season. The Bavarian powerhouse faces Bayer Leverkusen away for their German Cup semifinal on Wednesday, and then it has a two-legged Champions League semifinal tie against defending champion Paris Saint-Germain. "It's not — hopefully not — the last title," Bayern president Herbert Hainer said. "Because we'll definitely win our fourth consecutive German championship with the women's team, and we're in the cup final with the women. And I hope that we can wrap everything up on Wednesday so that we can then travel to Berlin (for the cup final) with the men." **Muted atmosphere:** The atmosphere was muted at the start of the game. There were reports of a clash between Bayern and Stuttgart fans before the match. Bayern coach Vincent Kompany rotated his squad with eight changes to the team that started against Real Madrid in the Champions League on Wednesday, with Manuel Neuer, Kane, Michael Olise, Dayot Upamecano and Aleksandar Pavlovic on the bench. Serge Gnabry was out with a thigh injury sustained in training the day before. The 23-year-old Jamal Musiala became the second youngest Bayern player to reach 150 Bundesliga appearances after Uli Hoeneß, who was 11 days younger, according to stats provider Opta. (AP)

Hockey India announces 36-member senior men's national coaching camp

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Hockey India on Monday named a 36-member core probable group for the upcoming senior men's national coaching camp, scheduled to be held at the Sports Authority of India (SAI) Centre in Bengaluru from April 20 to May 9. The coaching camp will focus on tactical cohesion, conditioning, and match-simulation sessions as the team aims to fine-tune its preparations in the lead-up to a busy international season, which includes European leg of the FIH Pro League 2025-56, World Cup, and Asian Games. Also, the squad will look to build rhythm, refine combina-



tions, and strengthen depth across all departments. The goalkeeping unit features experienced names including Krishan Bahadur Pathak, Suraj

Karkera and Pawan, alongside emerging talents such as Mohith Honnenahalli Shashikumar and Princedeep Singh. In defence, the team will be

anchored by stalwarts like Harmanpreet Singh and Amit Rohidas, supported by Jarmanpreet Singh, Jugraj Singh, Sanjay, Sumit, and a promising pool comprising Poovanna Chandura Bobby, Yashdeep Siwach, Nilam Sanjeev Xess, and Amandeep Lakra. The midfield sees a strong blend of experience and youth, with Manpreet Singh, Hardik Singh, and Vivek Sagar Prasad leading the charge. They will be joined by Rajinder Singh, Manmeet Singh, Moirangthem Rabichandra Singh, Vishnu Kant Singh, Raj Kumar Pal, Nilakanta Sharma, and Rosan Kujur. The forward line features an exciting mix of proven performers and rising stars, including Mandeep

Singh, Dilpreet Singh, Abhishek, and Sukhjeet Singh. They will be supported by Shilanand Lakra, Araiyeet Singh Hundal, Angad Bir Singh, Uttam Singh, Selvam Karthi, Aditya Arjun Lalage, and Maninder Singh. List of 36-member core probable group for the upcoming coaching camp: **GOALKEEPERS:** Krishan Bahadur Pathak, Pawan, Suraj Karkera, Mohith Honnenahalli Shashikumar, Princedeep Singh **DEFENDERS:** Amit Rohidas, Jarmanpreet Singh, Sanjay, Harmanpreet Singh, Jugraj Singh, Sumit, Poovanna Chandura Bobby, Yashdeep Siwach, Nilam Sanjeev Xess, Amandeep Lakra

Matt Fitzpatrick delivers another playoff winner

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Hilton Head Island (US)

Matt Fitzpatrick was in a playoff at Harbour Town against an American favorite, facing a large and noisy gallery cheering and chanting for his opponent — Scottie Scheffler this time, the No. 1 player in the world. It was practically a repeat from three years ago, right down to the shot into the 18th hole that Fitzpatrick said was "out of this world." The 31-year-old from England quieted the crowd with a 4-iron from 204 yards, a little more left than he intended but no less magnificent. It covered the bunker, rolled past the pin and settled 13 feet away for a birdie to beat Scheffler and win the RBC Heritage for the



second time. The playoff was almost a repeat from when Fitzpatrick defeated another American favorite, Jordan Spieth, in a playoff at the RBC Heritage three years ago. That time, he

hit 9-iron with the wind at his back that rolled out to a few inches for the winning birdie. This time the closing hole was a brute, the toughest at Harbour Town on Sunday. "It was quite funny that the playoff was just going to keep playing on 18. I was thinking it was going difficult in a way to separate ourselves because it's such a difficult hole," Fitzpatrick said. "To do it how I did was special." Scheffler, trailing by three shots with four holes to play, forced a playoff with a pair of late birdies for a 4-under 67 and some help from Fitzpatrick, who hit a poor chip from right of the green and missed a 20-foot par putt for his only bogey of the day and a 70. (AP)

Jon Rahm caps wild week in Mexico with another LIV Golf win

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mexico City

Jon Rahm capped off a chaotic week on LIV Golf when he closed with a 7-under 64 for a six-shot victory in LIV Golf Mexico City, his second victory this year on the Saudi-funded circuit. Rahm went all of last season on LIV without winning, though he did claim the points title. And he had experienced disappointment before in 2017 at Chapultepec Golf Club when it was a World Golf Championship. There was no doubt this time after he made birdie on the reachable par-4 second hole and then holed out for eagle on the next hole. He played bogey-free. "If you would have told me last week on Thursday afternoon that I'd be winning by a six-shot margin this week, I would not have believed you because of how bad I played," said Rahm, who tied for 38th in the Masters. "Hell of a an effort." The week has been filled with uncertain-



ty surrounding the Saudi-funded league, with CEO Scott O'Neil writing a memo to staff to say LIV was assured of funding through the end of the year amid reports speculating about the league's financial future.

Atiqa Mir secures highest Indian finish in WSK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lonato (Italy)

Racing prodigy Atiqa Mir keeps scaling new heights and on this occasion, the 11-year-old recorded the highest-ever race finish by an Indian in her category at World Series Karting (WSK) with a stellar P2 in Race 1 here.

Atiqa, the first Indian to be supported by Formula 1 Academy and the highest-ranked female worldwide in the OKN category (age 12-14), showed scorching speed in the opening race of WSK Euro Series Round 2 at the South Garda Karting here.

This was also the second time ever that a female finished P2 in a race in OKN class at WSK.

Atiqa has been turning heads with the sheer weight of her performances on the European circuit and this weekend among the spectators in Lonato were Mercedes F1 boss Toto Wolff and their star driver George Russell.

Atiqa hit her straps from the get go, finishing P2 in the warmup. In qualifying, she was a contender for



pole position but missed the all important slipstream, usually worth 2 tenths of a second. Despite that, she finished fourth fastest in her group and only a 10th of a second behind the pole sitter.

The highlight of Atiqa's weekend

was unarguably Race 1 where she finished P2. She displayed strong racecraft and speed while battling the best drivers in the world. She missed P1 by only 8 tenths of a second.

Atiqa had incident filled races

during the rest of the weekend with some hard racing resulting in some nosecone penalties, placing her in P12 out of 60 drivers in the Heat Rankings. The Pre Final and Final races were tough and she ended the weekend with P15 on road out

of 60 drivers.

Reflecting on her performance, Atiqa said: "A breakthrough weekend for me with another strong qualifying and a P2 finish. A few incidents spoiled what could have been a really strong weekend but it wasn't meant to be. Lots of positives this weekend and now I will prepare for the biggest race of my career in two weeks time (Championship of the Future Euro Series and FIA European Championship)."

Atiqa's father Asif Mir, a former Formula Asia Vice Champion, said the weekend was full of racing incidents and her daughter did the best she could in the circumstances.

"A strong start to Atiqa's weekend with good qualifying and Race 1. She struggled after that as she had outside row starts in all her remaining races but she held her own. The racing was very rough and she got nosecone penalties for no fault of hers but such is racing. Her progress is strong and we keep working hard to make her a better driver."

It is not like no one can shake me: Sujeet Kalkal

AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

Virtually unbeatable in the 65kg category over the past one year in international circuit, Indian wrestler Sujeet Kalkal says he is "a favourite of himself" even as he remains grounded about the unpredictability of results in elite sport.

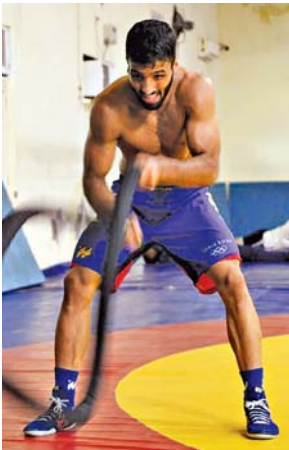
Sujeet, who has clinched gold medals in every competition he has entered since that U23 Asian Championship triumph in June 2025 — barring the Senior World Championship — believes consistency and self-belief have been key to his rise.

His most recent gold medal-winning performance came at the Senior Asian Championship in Bishkek.

"I don't follow anyone in particular. I like watching my own bouts, mostly on Sundays. You can say I am my own favourite," Sujeet told PTI in an interview.

Unlike many of his peers, Sujeet does not idolise any particular wrestler, though he admires veterans like Yogeshwar Dutt, Bajrang Punia, who went out of the scene following protest against then WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh.

"I used to watch



Yogeshwar Dutt and others. You learn from them - endurance, speed, power, but I mostly analyse my own bouts. Our schedule is busy, but on Sundays or rest time, I watch my bouts and also those of senior wrestlers. That helps identify mistakes and improve," he said.

Despite his dominance, Sujeet refused to claim absolute control over the 65kg weight category, which once belonged to Olympic medalist Bajrang Punia, who went out of the scene following protest against then WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh.

HCL Squash: Suraj Chand bags men's singles title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

India's Suraj Kumar Chand secured the HCL Squash PSA Challenger Tour title with a straight game win over South Korea's Jeongmin Ryu in the men's final here on Monday.

The Indian second seed, ranked 134 in the world, beat his eighth seed opponent 11-5, 11-9, 11-3 for his fourth PSA Tour title.

Egyptian seventh seed Rouqiaia Othman defeated Malaysian second seed Harleen Tan 12-10, 11-7, 9-11, 11-7 in the women's final.

"We would like to thank our sponsors and partners,



especially HCL, MYAS and SAI, for their support. Having an Indian winner makes it special," SRFI Secretary-General Cyrus Poncha said in a release.

Ex Afghan pacer Shapoor Zadran suffering from life-threatening disease, admitted in Delhi hospital

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former Afghanistan pacer Shapoor Zadran is battling for his life after being diagnosed with Hemophagocytic Lymphohistiocytosis (HLH), a rare and life-threatening disease.

The 38-year-old left-arm pacer is currently admitted to the intensive care unit of a New Delhi hospital, where he has been undergoing treatment since January.

HLH, which mainly affects children, is a condition in which the immune system becomes severely impaired. The patient suffers from hyperinflammation triggered by an overactive immune response, leading to damage to the body's tissues, including the bone marrow, liver, spleen and lymph nodes.

His younger brother, Ghamai Zadran, said



Shapoor first felt unwell last October, and doctors in Afghanistan later advised him to travel to India for treatment.

"It was a very serious infection," Ghamar told 'ESPNCricinfo'.

SRH eye home advantage against DC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad will look to make home advantage count when they take on inconsistent Delhi Capitals in a mid-table clash of the Indian Premier League here on Tuesday.

Both teams sit on six points, though fourth-placed Sunrisers Hyderabad are marginally ahead, having played a game more and boasting a superior Net Run Rate.

For SRH, the narrative has been one of gradual correction. In the absence of skipper Pat Cummins, who has linked up with the squad but remains unavailable for this game, their bowling unit initially looked thin.

But over the last two games, a relatively unheralded group has stepped up. Names like Praful Hinge, Sakib Husain and



Shivang Kumar have seized their opportunity, injecting both energy and control into the attack.

Hinge's standout performance against Rajasthan Royals was followed by a collective bowling effort, led by Eshan Malinga, against Chennai Super Kings, where SRH delivered a clinical exhibition of death bowling, helping them secure back-to-back wins at home. That resurgence with the ball has been central to their recent momentum.

However, the same cannot be said of their batting. SRH's approach remains aggressively high-

risk, but the returns have been inconsistent. Openers Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma, along with stand-in captain Ishan Kishan, have not quite clicked together.

The lack of collective starts has repeatedly exposed the middle order. As a result, the burden has largely fallen on Heinrich Klaassen.

sixes. Prize is my bat, doesn't make sense but hope it'll make us happy. When you let players be, I think they just deliver. That's our mantra."

Arya and Connolly added 182 runs in just 13.2 overs for a hugely

Shreyas Iyer reveals six-hitting contest behind PBKS' run-fest

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Apr 19 (PTI) A light-hearted six-hitting contest inside the dressing room is the reason behind Punjab Kings' batting blitz, said skipper Shreyas Iyer as the table-toppers dished out another batting master-class to slay Lucknow Super Giants by 54 runs here on Sunday.

Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly smashed 93 and 87, respectively, as PBKS posted 254/7 — the highest total of this IPL

season.

"Exceptional partnership, some shots were jaw-dropping. Hitting fast bowlers off the back-foot straight. Composure in the middle overs was sensational," Iyer said during the post-match presentation.

"Was talking with Cooper and Arya, said let's compete for the most no. of

sixes. Prize is my bat, doesn't make sense but hope it'll make us happy. When you let players be, I think they just deliver. That's our mantra."

Arya and Connolly added 182 runs in just 13.2 overs for a hugely

entertaining second-wicket stand.

"I don't tell them how to go about their specific innings, they have their patterns set. Ricky Ponting motivates just before the game, I chip in, boys come in and deliver."

PBKS bowlers also produced a solid effort, restricting LSG to 200/5, to complete a comprehensive win.

"Majority of our bowlers are international bowlers with immense experience. We have plans against certain batters, it's all



Mumbai Indians beat Gujarat Titans by 99 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Tilak Varma roared back to form with a magnificent maiden century in the Indian Premier League, helping Mumbai Indians break their four-match losing streak with a 99-run mauling of Gujarat Titans here on Monday.

Tilak remained not out on 101 off 45 balls, reaching the milestone with a boundary off the innings' last ball to lift MI to 199 for five after a forgettable start.

In reply, GT were bowled out for 100 in 15.5 overs, with left-arm seamer Ashwani Kumar returning excellent figures of 4/24 in four overs.

None of the GT batters could make any contribution of note.

Varma played the best knock of his career, smashing his maiden IPL hundred to

take Mumbai Indians to 199/5 and gain some breathing space against Gujarat Titans here on Monday.

Tilak (101 not out in 45 balls) did the unthinkable, scoring an incredible 81 runs off 23 balls to give the total respectability, which looked improbable after the power-play thanks to an intimidating first spell by Kagiso Rabada.

At the strategic time-out post 14th over, TV cameras caught skipper Pandya animatedly telling something to Tilak, who had scratched around to reach 19 off 22 balls and was occasionally booed by the Motera crowd.

But after that break, one saw the Tilak that one has always known as he threw the kitchen sink at GT's fastest bowlers. Prasadish Krishna went for 19, and new pace sensation Ashok Sharma was toyed with for 26 runs.

DP World Players Championship tees off in Nuh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nuh

As many as 130 professionals, including leading domestic names such as Veer Ahlawat, Om Prakash Chouhan and Manu Gandas, will vie for top honours when the ₹1 crore DP World Players Championship tees off at the Classic Golf & Country Club here on Monday.

The tournament will have a strong field with Saptak Talwar (2026 DP World PGTI



Order of Merit leader), Khalin Joshi and Honey Baisoya (both winners on the DP World PGTI this season) and Angad Cheema (two-time

winner on the DP World PGTI last year) also competing.

Sri Lanka's N Thangaraja, a three-time winner on the DP World PGTI last year,

will be the leading foreign contingent in the field.

The host region of Gurugram and Nuh will be represented by prominent names such as Dhruv Sheoran and Tapendra Chai — both winners on the DP World PGTI — as well as Manish Thakran and Shivendra Singh Sisodia, winners on the DP World PGTI NexGen, and Kushal Singh, Manav Bais and Saurav Rathi.

World Athletics' Integrity Unit designates India as country having 'extremely high' risk of doping



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Monaco

India was on Monday designated as a country with an "extremely high" risk of doping by World Athletics after topping the list of doping offenders for the past two years, a development which will put the athletes under more stringent anti-doping stipulations.

In a decision taken recently by the Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU) Board, Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has been re-categorised from Category B to Category A under Rule 15 of the World Athletics' Anti-Doping Rules.

"The doping situation in India has been high-risk for a long time and, unfortunately, the quality of the domestic anti-doping programme is simply not proportionate to the doping risk," AIU Chair David Howman said in a release.

"While the AFI has advocated for anti-doping

reforms within India, not enough has changed. The AIU will now work with the AFI to achieve reforms to safeguard the integrity of the sport of athletics, as we have done with other 'Category A' Member Federations."

India has ranked in the top two for the most Anti-Doping Rule Violations (ADRVs) in athletics between 2022 and 2025.

According to the AIU, India recorded 48 ADRV's (ranked 2nd) in 2022, 63 (ranked 2nd) in 2023, 71 (ranked 1st) in 2024 and 30 ADRV's (ranked 1st) in 2025 (data received so far).

Under the World Athletics Anti-Doping Rules, the AIU Board categorises all Member Federations according to their doping risk to the sport. Category 'A' Member Federations, representing the highest risk, are subject to more stringent requirements, including minimum testing of their national team athletes.